ICTE3002
Human Computer Interface

Curtin University
Dubai

Assignment 1

REPORT

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Executive Summary & App Logo

This project focuses on the design and development of HelpEra, a mobile application that aims to improve the mental health of young adults aged 18 to 30. The app includes accessible self-reflection tools, safe journaling, professional matching, and guided assistance for friends and family. The key features of this app include the “My Journal” section, which reduces trauma repetition, progressive support cards, a Focus Mode for accessibility, and strict privacy controls. The project was carried out using design thinking and Kanban processes, which included user research, persona design, and competitive analysis of platforms like TalkLife and 7 Cups. Low/high-fidelity prototypes were created using Balsamiq and Figma, with expert comments guiding iterative development. Moreover, HelpEra aligns with the UN Sustainable Development Goal 3. It takes a user-centred approach to digital mental health care, emphasising accessibility, empathy, and anonymity.



Figure 1: App Logo

1. Introduction

Mental health challenges represent a growing global concern, with rising rates of depression, anxiety, and emotional distress affecting individuals across all demographics. Despite this prevalence, a significant treatment gap exists-many individuals lack access to timely, affordable, and appropriate mental health support, leading them to suffer in silence without adequate intervention.

The purpose of this report is to document the user-centered design process undertaken by Team UXplorers for “HelpEra”, a mobile application designed to address this gap. HelpEra is a mental health support app targeted at young adults aged between 18 and 30, including university students and early-career professionals, as well as their support networks of friends and family who wich to educate themselves to better help others.

The application provides users with easily accessible mental health resources, self-reflection tools, and educational content designed to promote emotional awareness, self-care, and early intervention. By offering a private, user-friendly platform, HelpEra aims to reduce barriers such as stigma, lack of knowledge, and financial constraints that commonly prevent individuals from seeking mental health support.

Our team selected this project for two primary reasons. First, the project aligns with the UN’s SDG 3 (Good Health and Well-Being). Secondly, the team members share a personal interest in mental health awareness and reducing the stigma surrounding help-seeking behaviors. By recognizing the sensitivity of the issue, UXplorers aimed to build a space that feels safe, approachable, and free of judgment for new help-seekers.

This report will document our complete design journey, including user research, person development, competitor analysis, point identification, ideation, requirements specification, prototyping, expert review, and final design outcomes.

2. Background

2.1. Project Description

Mental health issues represent a significant and growing challenge in the present society, affecting individuals across all age groups, socioeconomic backgrounds, and geographic locations. According to the WHO, depression is a leading cause of disability worldwide, and anxiety disorders affect hundreds of millions of people globally (World Health Organization 2025). Despite this prevalence, a substantial treatment gap persists-many individuals who experience mental health challenges do not receive professional support due to barriers including cost, lack of availability, stigma, and limited knowledge about where or how to seek help.

Young adults, especially early-career professionals and university students, represents a demographic at an increased risk. This population frequently experience stress, anxiety, and emotional overwhelm related to social transitions, career uncertainty, academic pressure, and financial concerns. Simultaneously, they are typically digitally literate and comfortable using mobile applications, making them ideal candidates for technology-enabled mental health support.

2.2. Problem Statement

While multiple mental health platforms and online resources currently exist, most exhibit significant limitations. Many focus exclusively on clinical treatment pathways, which can feel overwhelming and intimidating for many people seeking initial support and are unsure about how to approach it. Others lack proper privacy protection, creating concerns about sensitive data disclosure. Peer support platforms often suffer from inconsistent quality, inadequate safety systems, and insufficient guidance for users in crisis.

Friends and family members who wish to support loved ones facing mental health challenges face their own difficulties. They frequently encounter generic advice, overwhelming information, and limited actionable guidance, which can increase their anxiety and reduce their effectiveness as supporters.

2.3. Design Purpose

HelpEra was envisioned to address these gaps by providing a supportive, user-friendly, educational platform that helps users understand and manage mental health in a non-judgmental, accessible manner as follows:

Gap	Explanation
Efficiency	Enable users to quickly find relevant information or tools with minimal efforts, recognizing that individuals experiencing distress have limited cognitive resources.
Universal Accessibility	Support diverse user needs through readable typography, calm visual design, respectful language, and adherence to accessibility standards including WCAG 2.1 level AA.
Trust Building	Establish user confidence through transparent privacy practices, clear boundaries, and respectful communication.
Cognitive Accessibility	Reduce cognitive load and emotional overwhelm through clear layout, minimalistic design, and progressive disclosure of information.
Engagement Promotion	Create a positive, reassuring user experience that encourages ongoing engagement without inducing guilt or pressure.
Intuitive Interaction	Provide a simple, intuitive interface navigable by users with varying levels of digital literacy.

Table 1: Design Gaps Addressed by HelpEra

3. Team

3.1. Team Members

Student No.	Name	Student ID	Role
1	Resham Furqan	22526025	Project Manager
2	Maria Waheed	21631986	UX Research Leader
3	Blessed Dendere	22177562	Persona and Stories Leader
4	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba	22354695	Competitor and UX Role Leader
5	Natalee De Silva	21957117	Figma and Documentation Leader

Table 2: Team Members

3.2. Team Details

Item	Details
Team Name	UXplorers
Project Name	HelpEra
Assignment	1
Tutor	Ms Shahra Jafar Ali

Table 3: Team Details

4. Software Engineering Lifecycle and Tools

4.1. Chosen Lifecycle Model: Agile with Kanban

Team UXplorers adopted an Agile lifecycle utilizing a Kanban Board for task management and workflow visualization. This approach was selected to support continuous, user-centered design improvement throughout the project duration. Kanban enables us to visualize work progress, limit work-in-progress, adapt designs based on emerging feedback without the constraints of rigid phase boundaries.

4.2. Justification for Model Selection

A Kanban-based Agile approach is particularly well-suited to mental health application development for several reasons:

1) **Flexibility:**

   Design ideas and problem understanding can evolve organically as user research reveals new insights, without requiring reworking of a fixed, upfront plan.

2) **Low Overhead:**

   Kanban provides lightweight project management appropriate to the scope of this project, avoiding the administrative burden of more formal methodologies.

3) **Clear Visibility:**

   The Kanban board provides all the members with real-time visibility into task status, improving coordination, reducing duplication of effort, and enhancing individual accountability.

4) **Incremental Progress:**

   Each iteration delivers tangible, demonstrable outputs-including personas, affinity maps, low-fidelity prototypes, and high-fidelity designs-maintaining momentum and enabling regular feedback.

5) **User-Centered Iteration:**

The approach supports continuous refinement of pain points, HMW statements, and design solutions based on ongoing user research and testing.

4.3. Kanban Board Structure

UXplorers implemented a Kanban board with the following columns:

- To Do: Tasks selected for the current work cycle
- In Progress: Tasks actively being worked on by team members
- Review: Completed tasks awaiting peer or group review
- Completed: Finished and approved tasks

Work-in-progress limits were applied to each column to prevent team overload and maintain focused effort on priority tasks.

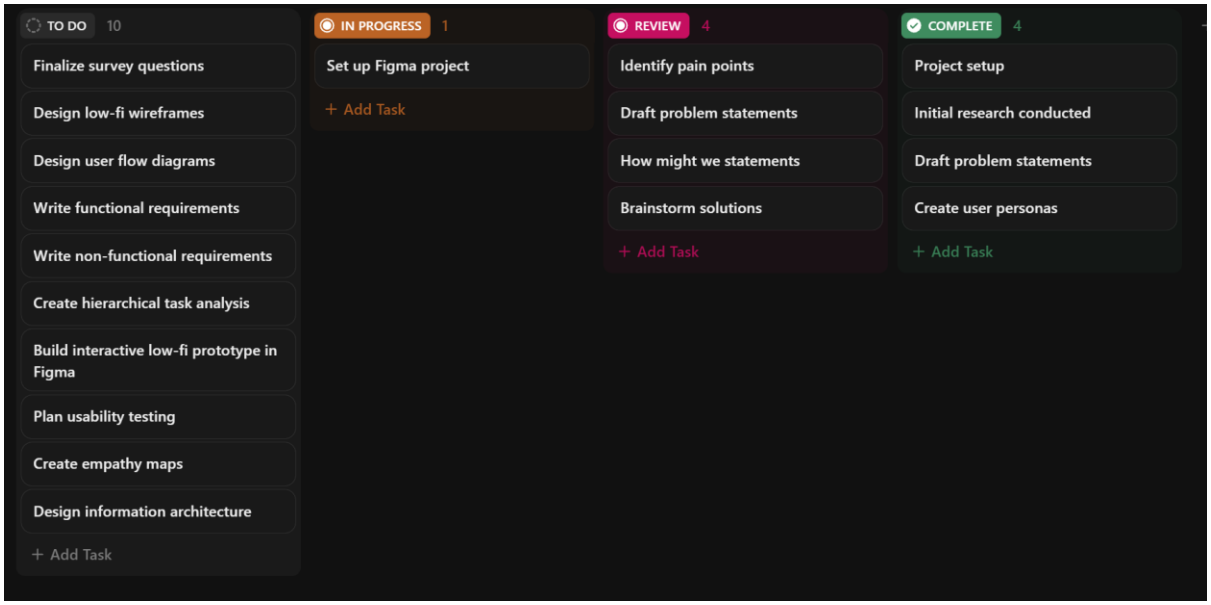


Figure 2: Kanban Board Structure

4.4. High-Level Tasks

The following high-level tasks are managed through the kanban board:

Phase	Tasks
Research and understanding	User interviews, surveys, competitor analysis, pain points, affinity mapping.
Design Thinking and Ideation	Problem statements, HMW questions, ideated solutions, solution grouping.
Requirements Specification	Functional and non-functional requirements, hierarchical task analysis.
UI/UX Design	Wireframing, low-fidelity prototype, user flows, personas, and empathy maps.
Evaluation and Refinement	Hi-fi design, style guide, Figma handoff preparation
Project Management and Documentation	Meetings, kanban board updates, milestone tracking, report writing

Table 4: High-Level Tasks

4.5. Project Milestones

Milestone	Description	Target Date
Project Setup	Roles assigned and Kanban board created	15/01/2026
User Research Complete	Personas, pain points, affinity mapping finalized	15/01/2026
Design Ideation Compete	HMW statements and ideated solutions grouped	15/01/2026
Prototype Development	Low-fidelity prototype created and reviewed	18/01/2026
Evaluation Complete	Expert review and revisions finalized	15/02/2026
High-Fidelity Prototype and Handoff	Hi-fi prototype and style guide ready	20/02/2026
Final Report Submission	Complete report submitted	23/02/2026

Table 5: Milestones

5. Design Thinking

5.1. Design Thinking Process

The design of HelpEra was based on an iterative Design Thinking strategy to allow making the interface and the selection of interaction decisions based on the real needs of users and refined them through feedback constantly. The team did not follow a linear sequence of events as is the case in the Design Thinking model (see figure 3) but instead treated the whole process as a loop, i.e., the knowledge gained throughout the testing and review incorporated frequently into the problem definition and feature prioritization. This is in line with the expectations of the assignment that Design Thinking section be specific to the project and elaborate how the process informed the decision-making process of user-centric design.

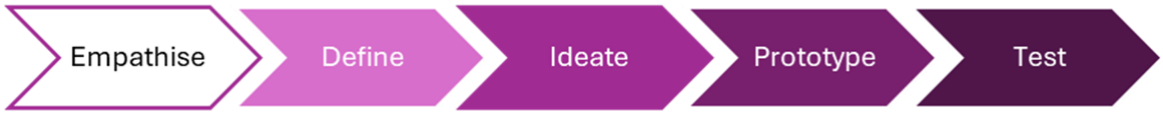


Figure 3: Design Thinking Model

5.1.1. Empathise: Interpretation of User Feelings, Obstacles & Background

The empathise stage was dedicated to developing an insight into how young adults (18 30) and supporters (friends/family) perceive the process of struggling with mental health and what makes them unwell to seek or maintain support. Our initial research was user research (online survey), which was complemented by an initial search of the mental-health app space. The focus was not merely on what users do (e.g., search information or coping tools), but how users feel, i.e., stressed, overwhelmed, hesitant and fearful of being judged. These emotional limitations were considered design requirements since mental health support tools are normally applied when cognitive ability is low and encouragement is required.

Making empathy work also led to early interface consideration that were evident in the kick off prototype concept. As an example, HelpEra provides users with a friendly entry point and distinctly differentiates between the Login/Sign Up option and offers access to Emergency/Hot-line Services at the

very beginning, which is consistent with the principle that crisis routes must be conveniently located. The latter choice was further supported by subsequent feedback in which the lack of hotline visibility was found to be a usability issue and reversed by placing it higher up on the opening screen.

5.1.2. Define: Transforming Insights to Problem Clarity

Once we had gathered and analysed research insights, we proceeded to the formulation of the major issues that HelpEra had to address. The team grouped findings in themes of pain-points using affinity mapping. These themes were: privacy issues, emotional safety, usability / content overload, technical stability, social risk in peer space and professional matching friction.

Out of these combined themes, the stage of defining was narrowed into the explicit problem statements to make sure that the design would address the right issue and not just add features. As an illustration, we formalised problems related to (1) privacy and trust, (2) safety and stability when performing vulnerable tasks such as journaling, and (3) supporter anxiety and content overload, in which the supporters cannot find actionable advice without being overwhelmed. These problem statements became the filters of subsequent decisions in the form of features and layouts that were more likely to make the problem more overwhelming or less trustworthy were viewed as not being aligned with the main problem definition.

5.1.3. Ideate: Transforming Problems into Opportunities of How Might We

During ideation, the team used How Might We (HMW) questions as it restructured the identified problems to generate directions in the solution without prematurely settling on a design. This move enabled contemplation of various concepts as well as being connected to actual user pain points. Our HMWs were directly based on the issues that emerged during research, e.g.: how to make first-time users aware that they do not have to start with a lot of

information, how to make complicated information comprehensible to non-professionals, how to stop repeated trauma disclosure in professional matching, and enable friends/family to be better guided.

The results of such ideation also contributed to the organization of the content experience to the prototype. As an example, instead of offering dense reading as the sole choice, the kickoff prototype displays supportive links, such as Start Your Healing Guide and Explore Articles, providing the users with the structured navigation and an opportunity to browse depending on their emotional condition and readiness.

5.1.4. Prototype: Low-fi to Kick Off Concept Rapid Visualisation of Solutions

After choosing direction in the solutions, the team transitioned to in stages prototyping to mitigate the risk and facilitate rapid prototyping. Initial prototyping was based on the main customer experiences like emergency assistance, mood checking, condition awareness, and reflective aids. These initial solution concepts are shown in the kick-off prototype screens with the mood-based entry (How are you feeling today?) where the user is directed to relevant supporting activities (e.g., groundwork exercises in panicky states or reflection prompts in calm/okay states).

Another feature that can be seen in the prototype is how we were able to apply emotional needs to UI flow decisions. Using the case of grounding flow, where the immediate reassurance (which is made possible by being grounded) is offered (First, know you are safe) followed by a single clear next step (Grounded Exercises), users can find support when they are overwhelmed and requiring reduced cognitive load. Similarly, guided prompts and optional actions (Save/Skip) are implemented by the reflection/journaling screens, which assist in the control of users and decrease pressure, which is important in mental health.

5.1.5. Test and Refine: Refine the Features with an Objective of Feedback

The processes of testing and evaluation were not considered as a conclusiveness. In the initial circles, we have used internal team walkthrough and peer review with the aim of confirming that core navigation and task flows were perceivable. Changes that followed feedback that were recorded in our Design Thinking process include:

- **Hotline discoverability:** it was reported that the emergency access was shadowed and as a result, it was relocated to a more noticeable place on the starting screen.
- **Learn content overwhelm** based on the feedback, it was found that showing too much information at the same time was overwhelming and it was planned to make information more organized and easier to digest.
- **Repetition and emotional fatigue:** based on the feedback, it is easy to consider the repetition of the experience to the professionals as exhausting, and that is why we introduce a secure sharing idea (Send to Professional) that would help us maintain the continuity of care and curb repetitive disclosure.

These revisions represent the essence of Design Thinking which is to learn by evidence and improve the design, and not to assume the initial solution is right. This type of thinking is also consistent with our broader milestones of the project where research, pain points, ideation, prototyping, and evaluation were achieved as milestones.

5.1.6. Summary of the Connection between 5.1 and the Rest of the Report

This Design Thinking procedure had a direct impact on the later parts of the report: user-centred approaches (5.23), survey analysis (5.4), and requirements/HTA (Section 6). Specifically, the empathise and define steps provided that the choices of HelpEra prototype, including visible access to emergencies, emotionally supportive micro copy, and structured learning, were pegged on what is essential to both people in need and people who provide them with support.

5.2. User-Centered Design

HelpEra was developed based on a user-centered design (UCD), which implies that major interface and interaction choices were informed by evidence on user needs, feelings, and the reality that helps them face obstacles to seeking help. UCD was not regarded as a luxury in this project; it was a necessity since the mental-health support tools tend to be utilized in situations when the user is unenergetic, has little attention, or perceives vulnerability. Consequently, the design will place emphasis on lessening cognitive load, emotional safety, and ease of access to high-risk pathways (such as emergency assistance).

5.2.1. Engaging Users at an Early Stage (and ethically)

To make sure that the product direction was based on the needs of the users, the team used the data collection based on the primary user input, which was online survey, as the common method of the requirements discovery at the early stages. This option enabled the research to be carried out within a relatively short period of time and at the same time ensured privacy and comfort of the participants, which is essential in sensitive matters. The survey covered young adults between the ages of 18 and 30 (students and young professionals in the early career), which is the target audience of HelpEra.

Participation ethics were also considered because the subject of the research concerned personal wellbeing. Their involvement was said to be anonymous, and voluntary and the team matched the practice with the expectations of the Research Participation Agreement in the unit (to alleviate pressure on the participants and to avoid gathering information that could identify them). The task break of final report also asks to describe the involvement of users and to discuss the research participation agreement within this section, which is followed in this report.

5.2.2. Converting User Requirements into Design Solutions.

UCD also only makes sense when the product is obviously influenced by the input of the user. The following decisions are presented in HelpEra, where the needs of the users were converted into interface structure and interaction flows, and kickoff prototype represented the first actual translation of the needs.

1. **The focus on safety and urgency (Emergency access is always visible)**

   Mental health tools should be user-friendly to facilitate the user who may be in distress. HelpEra in the kickoff prototype allows users to access the Emergency/Hot-line Services option on the entry screen, hence, one does not have to navigate deep into the application to get emergency help.

   This is an item of UCD: critical tasks must be accessible in a short time, particularly in cases where the attention and calmness of a user could be diminished.

2. **Emotion-based entry design (less effort)**

   Rather than asking the user to guess what they require, the prototype opens with a clear check-in: How are you feeling today? and offers direct emotional response of from user (e.g., calm, anxious, overwhelmed, panicky).

This is person-centric since it is like the experience of people in distress, as people might not be aware of which feature is right, but they tend to be aware of how they feel. The interface will then direct the user to the right kind of support as opposed to them trying to find by feel.

3. **Improving cognitive load by means of guided micro-steps.**

   On a choice of a higher distress state (e.g., panicky) the prototype answers with a calming language and one distinct subsequent activity: grounding exercises.

   This is an expression of UCD since it recognizes the fact that panic state users may have a hard time making complicated decisions. A cool interface + a single glaring button lowers the cognitive load and gives usability an enhanced experience during urgent situations.

4. **The endorsement of autonomy and non-pressure interaction.**

   The prototype promotes contemplation and journaling in a lighter state but retains user control at center stage. As an illustration, Save and Skip are offered in gratitude reflection to allow users to interact without being coerced.

   It is user-centered since it observes emotional readiness- users are free to take part where they can and to abstain where they cannot.

5. **Design to meet the needs of learning and supporters (structured pathways).**

   The Learning flow of HelpEra contains a well-defined pathway of Start Your Healing Guide and Explore Articles, indicating an orderly journey to those users who require guidance and a navigation option to those users who enjoy being lost.

   The guide format (Understanding Anxiety, Coping with Anxiety Attacks, helping somebody with Anxiety etc.) also facilitates the aim of the

project, in helping the help-seekers and supporters to receive action-oriented, structured information instead of receiving information dumping.

5.2.3. Alignment of UCD with the Project Scope and Report Requirements

The assignment presupposes a process of developing UI/UX design which illustrates the principles of user-centered design and provides clear evidence of user engagement. HelpEra fulfills this by (1) engaging the users in pre-launch survey research, (2) applying ethical practices of participation as befitting a sensitive field, and (3) demonstrating direct evidence of user-crafted decision-making in the kickoff prototype, particularly in emergency accessibility, less cognitive burden, and supportive interaction design.

5.3. User Interviews, Surveys, Questionnaires and Observations

To ensure that the design decisions made in the case of HelpEra were informed by actual user needs, concerns and expectations, as opposed to assumptions, user research was carried out. As HelpEra is a mental health support application (sensitive situation), we placed emphasis on the approach that would enable the participants to make their contributions in a relaxed and confidential manner, yet with sufficient information to inform the initial design orientation.

5.3.1. The Target Users and the Method of Recruitment

The study concentrated on young adults between the ages of 18 and 30, and these are the university students and young professionals in their early career. This sample was chosen since, in most cases, they are under stress, anxiety, and emotional overload because of academic pressure, work transitions, social pressure, and financial issues and are very familiar with mobile apps. The survey was distributed by a convenience sample (peers, friends, and family

members of the target age range) to guarantee the attainability of responses within the deadline of the assignment.

Ethical participation was also considered in this research. Mental health being personal, participation was anonymous and voluntary, as per the expectations of the Research Participation Agreement of the unit (i.e. no coercion to participate; no identifiable data necessary to answer).

5.3.2. Selected Option: Online Survey (Google Forms)

HelpEra applied the online survey as the main initial research technique. This suited perfectly well since it facilitated the collection of data in a relatively short time and it also allowed the participants to answer the questions discreetly (this is of essence, when a subject that needs to be addressed is stigma, privacy or vulnerability.).

The questionnaire was developed in Google Forms, and to help the group with brainstorming questions and narrowing down on what we needed to learn about our users, FigJam was utilized in the classroom. The Appendix contains the transparency and assessment needs by including screenshots and documented responses.

5.3.3. Aim and Objectives of the Surveys

Questions used in the survey were directed at recording both practical and emotional user needs including:

- how frequently users experience stress or emotional distress,
- whether they have used mental health/wellbeing apps before,
- what barriers stop people from accessing support,
- what features users would find helpful,
- what types of content users prefer (learning resources, self-reflection tools, etc.),
- how likely users are to use a “non-clinical” support app,

- and how important privacy/anonymity is for this type of application.

These research objectives were the direct drivers of the kickoff prototype concept. As an illustration, the prototype has an Emergency / Hot-line Services button on the entry screen to minimize friction during an urgent situation and emotional check-ins (How are you feeling today?), to minimize cognitive overload when the user is overloaded.

5.3.4. Overview of the Instrument (Sample Survey Questions)

The questionnaire was made up of 7 main questions. Examples include:

1. How frequently do you experience stress, anxiety or emotional distress?
2. Have you ever utilized any mental health or well-being application?
3. What do you consider to be the major barrier to mental health care?
4. What do you think is the best aid in a mental health support app?
5. What content type would you like (self-reflection tools, learning materials, etc.)?
6. What is your likelihood of using a non-clinical, non-complicated mental health support application?
7. What matters about privacy and anonymity of such apps?

Appendix A contains the full survey screenshots and answers as well as the evidence of the Research Participation Agreement as the report template requires.

5.3.5. Limitations (and the Ways We Addressed Them)

Since this is a preliminary survey and the sampling was convenience-based, the results might not be applicable to all demographics and clinical populations. Outcomes are self-reported and are based on perceptions and not clinical examination. Nevertheless, the survey was still informative regarding the priorities of users, particularly in terms of privacy, content overload, and the

appearance of what the help in a practical sense should look like (just for the early design direction). These lessons are technically condensed in the following section (5.4 Data Analysis) in which survey results are summarized into design-learned lessons.

5.4. Data Analysis

This part will generalize the survey findings to discover user need trends and translate them into tangible design requirements of HelpEra. It is noted in the assignment template that trend analysis of research should be identified by data analysis and demonstrate how the results are applied in the user-centered design solution. This was also stipulated in our team assignment as a new quick findings task, hence the emphasis here is limited to findings that are concrete, practical and not a mere enumeration of answers.

5.4.1. Summary of the Data Set and Profile of Participants

The target population (1830 years old) provided 20 responses because of a survey. The study sample consisted mostly of 1820 (11/20) and 2124 (8/20), the smaller part was made of 2530 (1/20). Regarding roles, most of the respondents were university students (9/20), then there were students and early-career (6/20) and early-career professionals (4/20). This fits with the target audience outlined in the report background that of young adults, in study/work scenarios and frequent stress and anxiety (HelpEra).

Key finding 1: Stress is common, and it is necessary to support it in a “low-energy and rapid fashion.

Another significant pattern in the data is that most of the participants were not experiencing stress/anxiety occasionally. 9/20 said they experienced stress/emotional distress daily, and 8/20 said they did it weekly. This means that HelpEra will have to perform exceptionally well at times of low capacity

when a user will hardly be willing to read extensive content or use complicated menus.

Design translation: This gives the kickoff prototype its reasoning to start with a quickly-mood-check-in profile (How are you feeling today?), instead of the dashboard-heavy feature-filled one. It also supports the necessity of instant grounding resources that can be opened in a couple of taps, which is in line with the design objective of the app to minimize cognitive demands and allow quick use of applicable resources.

Key finding 2: Reasons are primarily psychological + trust-related, and not simply a lack of apps.

Discussing barriers to seeking mental health support (selecting the top 3 options), the respondents choose the following barriers:

- Stigma / fear of judgement (14 selections)
- Privacy / confidentiality concerns (13 selections)
- Hard to find the “right” support / matching (13 selections)
- Time constraints + not knowing where to start (7 selections each)

This trend is important as it indicates that it is not merely that users require information. Most of them are afraid to be judged, they are afraid of privacy and are not aware of where to start, hence they fear. These results are consistent with the previously identified themes in the team in terms of privacy/trust and accessibility barriers (including cognitive overload and distress).

Design translation: These findings are the very point that led to making privacy and trust visible within the experience instead of being covered in settings. The prototype has a special section of privacy and disclaimer that elaborates encryption, anonymous use, local storage and data minimization. The report

has its objective of Trust Building (transparent privacy practices and clear boundaries) as well.

Key finding 3: Journaling and useful computer-aided tools are more desired than professionally looking features.

In the case of preferred app content (select 3 maximum), the participants most frequently chose:

- Safe journaling/reflection (17 selections)
- Quick grounding/breathing tools (14 selections)
- Support for friends/family ("how to help someone") (13 selections)
- Clear Learning Content (10 selections)
- Less frequently: Emergency hotline access (6 selections) and Professional matching (4 selections)

This indicates that to a lot of users, self-support and everyday coping by HelpEra is the greatest value, and professional matching comes afterwards as a secondary element, and not the essence of the application.

Design translation: This priority can already be observed in the kickoff prototype in the form of guided reflection/journaling flows and grounding exercises, supported using straightforward language and straightforward next steps. It also facilitates an educational, non-clinical (e.g. Understanding Anxiety and Coping with Anxiety Attacks) learning pathway, which is in line with the desire to learn using easy-to-follow learning material, but not become lost in clinical lingo.

Key finding 4: A real user group is that of supporters and they require some organized guidance.

Most of the respondents said they have assisted a mentally challenged person in some way (13/20 “Yes). This, combined with the fact that the most popular content is that which addresses how to help someone (13 selections), helps to affirm that the supporters cannot be regarded as an appendix.

Design translation: The guidance by the supporters of HelpEra is represented in the prototype through the information about how to assist a person with anxiety (e.g., what to say, what not to say, and what to do in practical scenarios). This also corresponds to the issue of the team of the anxiety of supporters and content overload as they are not effective with generic advice and cannot read too much in emergencies.

Key finding 5: The privacy rating is high, and trust signals should be conspicuous.

Privacy/anonymity had an average score of 4.2/5, and most participants gave the highest scores (4s and 5s). The most recorded trust builders in the trust question (choose up to 3) were:

- Anonymous use option (16 selections)
- Verified professional / trusted resources (16 selections)
- Clear privacy policy in simple language (10 selections)
- Emergency support clearly visible (7 selections)

This goes to affirm that trust is a UX requirement rather than a legal requirement. Users desire to observe use of anonymity, indications of verification, and safety channels.

Design translation: The privacy section of the kickoff prototype clearly demonstrates the anonymity and encryption of the use of the model, as well as delimiting the crisis limits and responsible use. Also, one feedback point that was recorded in the log of the report process was emergency visibility (the

hotline was shifted to a more salient startup location) and it indicated that trust and safety signals were actively developed.

Key finding 6: The users desire to have customized instructions and reduced bombardment.

What the existing apps should do better (select up to 3) the highest needs were:

- More personalized guidance based on mood/needs (14 selections)
- Better crises support access (12 selections)
- Better professional matching + better supporter features (10 selections each)
- Less overwhelming content and more practical tools (8 selections each)

This implies that users tend to feel that existing solutions do not fit well either because they are too generic (similar advice to all people) or too heavy (too much to read when I am already overwhelmed). This aligns with the design intent of the project that is to do gradual disclosure and not to overload.

Design translation: This is explicitly connected to the mood-based navigation strategy (How are you feeling today?) since it allows the provision of lightweight personalization without intricate onboarding. It also favors the organization of the learning material in a guided pathway (healing guide) instead of just throwing a long reading list, which will take care of the issue of overwhelm.

5.4.2. Overall Insight Summary and Design Priorities

There were three themes that appeared throughout the dataset:

1. The support that is the least effort now (stress is common; users need grounding + journaling) is the most important.
2. Trust and privacy should be observable (the stigma and privacy issues are the greatest barriers; anonymity and trusted resources create confidence).
3. Advocates require organized assistance as well (most of the respondents help other people; instructional material is valued greatly).

Based on these outcomes, the kickoff prototype direction was justified and improved, particularly the entry based on moods, useful coping mechanisms, content of supporter learning, and effective communication of privacy/safety within the UI.

5.5. Personas

At HelpEra, we aim to create an application that not only satisfies our consumers, but that caters to a wide audience of people. With that in mind, we concluded by portraying two realistic yet contrasting personas that can be found in most corporate environments. This is represented under the influence of workplace experience, motivation, and inequality, especially in areas where individuals are subject to pressure-filled, fast-paced, and performance-based environments.

The first person, Sarah Zhou, is a confident sales assistant who was the most suitable candidate to depict forthright, competent and goal-driven users who are subject to systemic barriers, i.e. gender discrimination. She best represents the notion that skills and effort do not always equal the results. Her interest in liberation-focused content mirrors how individuals will still seek validation and ideological reinforcement in events of injustice. She also shows how a constant cycle of hard work without results can lead to mental and psychological struggles.

In contrast, we have Tinashe K. Dube, who should be in a better position as a male but is also in a predicament. An insecure graphic designer who is skilled and proficient in his work but is psychologically impacted by workplace targeting and social anxiety. He can represent how mental health, especially in cases of self-doubt and perceived hostility, can influence and even disrupt everyday life, judgement, and media consumption. He best reflects individuals who are more focused on digital validation rather than outspoken justice.

All together, these two personas enable us as the developers to tackle the different requirements our users require based on their different personality traits, lived experiences and mental fortitude under the influence of their needs, behaviors and media content. They address both internal conflict and embodied resistance in navigating systemic structure and social interactions.

5.5.1. Sarah Zhou

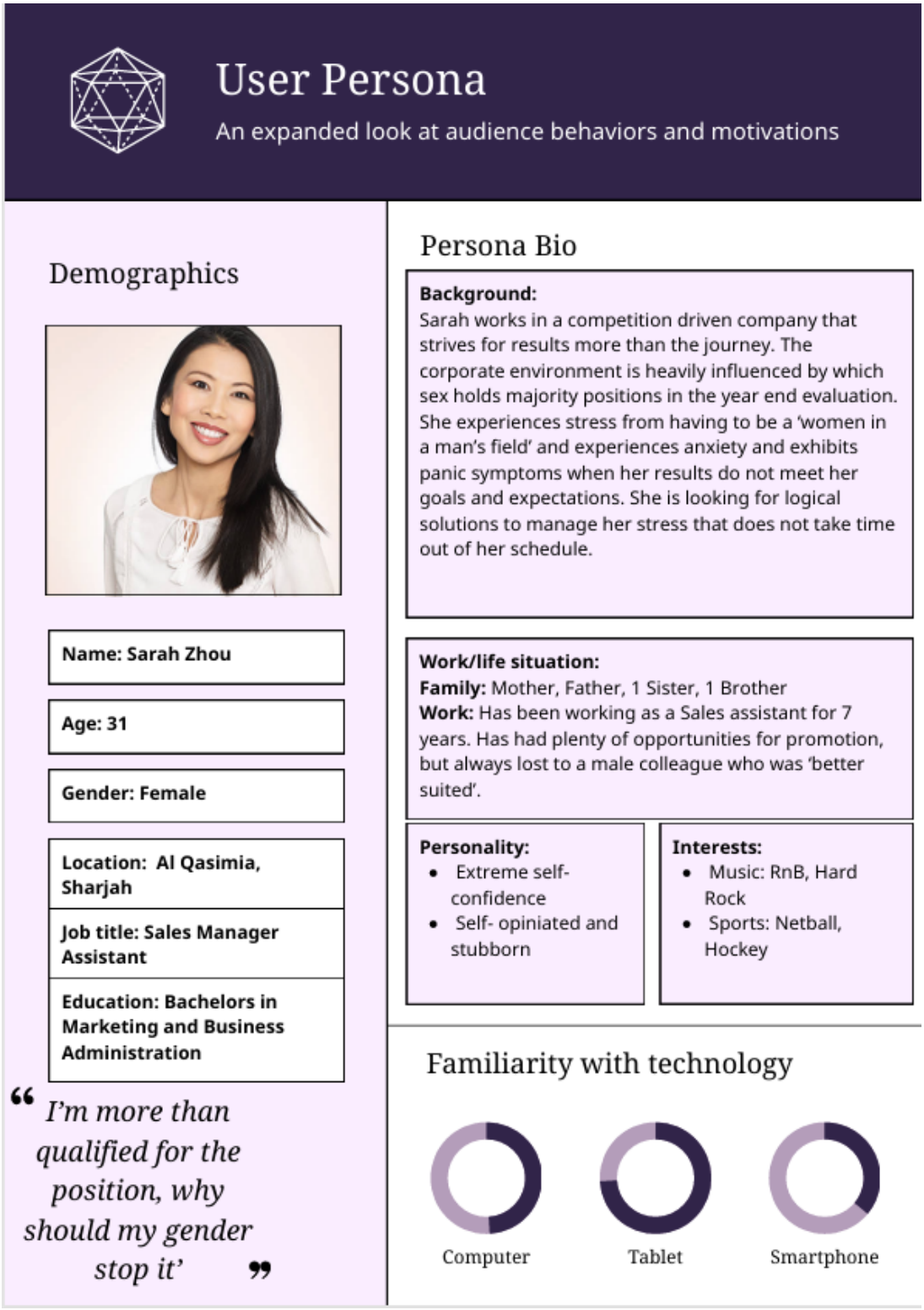


Figure 4: User Persona 1 (a)

Audience Insights

Goals:
- Better quality of sleep
- Keep a journal/diary on different mood patterns
- Minimize the effects of anxiety
- Promotion at work

Pain points:
- Has no time to schedule therapy sessions
- Discussions of mental health at work are seen as 'weakness'
- Overwhelmed by clustered and overflowing information on app

Behavior:

- **Daily routine description:**
  - Starts day by reviewing sales targets to surpass
  - Excessive concern on perfomance metrics
  - Evenings used to search for advanced placement
- **Decision-making style:**
  - Decisive and stubborn
  - Acts without prior consent
  - Decisions based on her view
- **Tech usage:**
  - Sales tracking software - High level
  - Online communities about gender bias

Application Expectations:
- Basic and easy to understand interface
- A feature to track her mood
- Privacy and user confidentiality

Preferred Media Channels

Influencing Factors/ Platforms Used	Media habits
Feminist and Misandrist Podcasts	Listens to critiques on gender power structures
Chloe Laws, Winona LaDuke	Watches discussions on women in media and social justice
Women Empowerment	TED talks in women in men's field and validates self-opinion

Figure 5: User Persona 1 (b)

5.5.2. Tinashe K. Dube

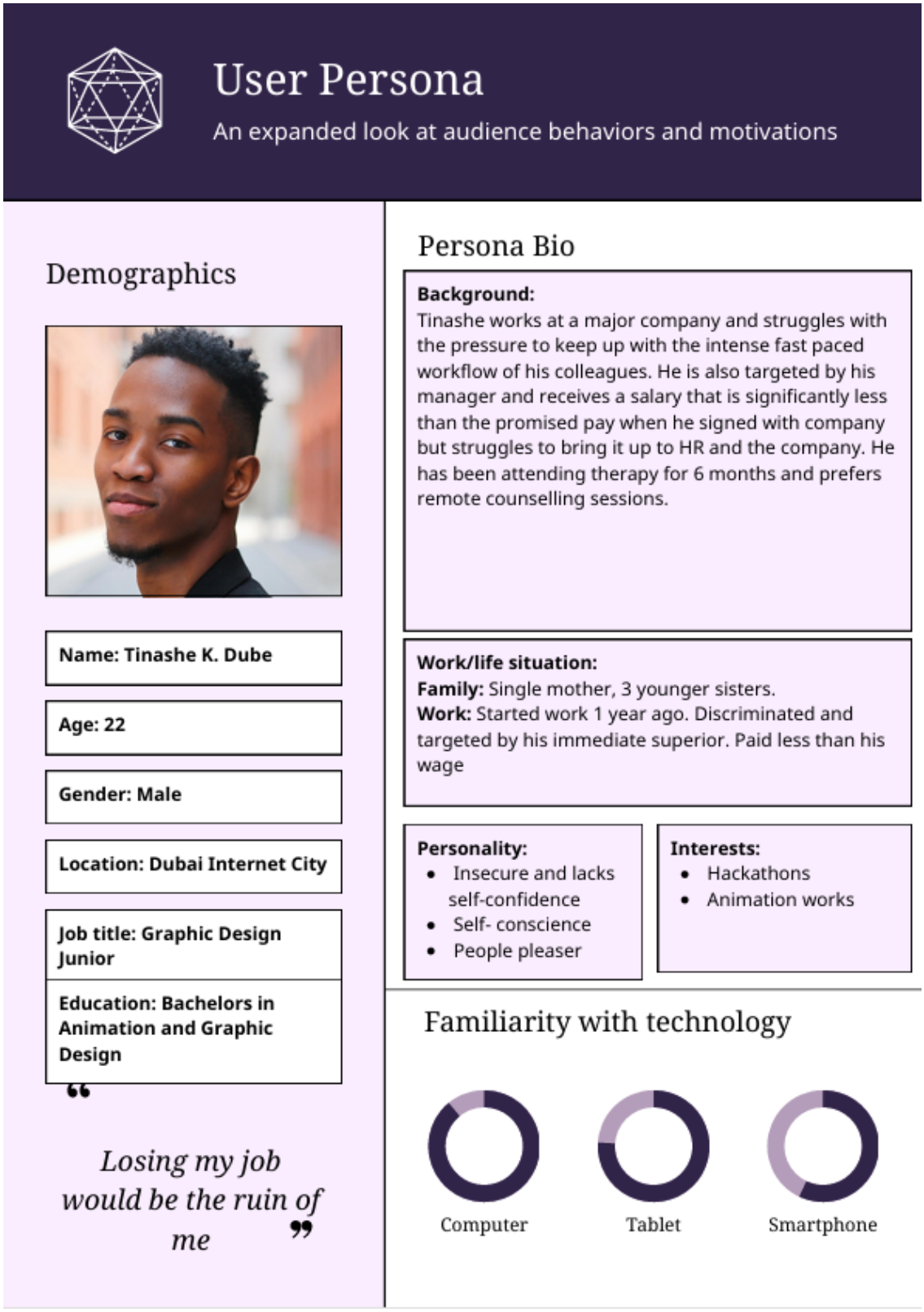


Figure 6: User Persona 2 (a)

Audience Insights

Goals:

- Build up his self-confidence and security
- Courage to seek justice for his mistreatment
- Recognize his emotional triggers and maintain them

Pain points:

- Financial and pay inequity
- Irregular schedule
- Clinically credible sources of information

Behavior:

- **Daily routine description:**
  - Starts day by checking emails
  - Avoids informal work interactions
  - Evenings used to improve skills
- **Decision-making style:**
  - Hesitant and seeks validation
  - Delayed decision making
  - Decisions influenced by others' emotions
- **Tech usage:**
  - High proficiency in design tools (i.e figma)
  - Excessive checks for errors in emails

Application Expectations:

- Structured features.
- Crisis support and emergency hotlines.
- Checkpoint style progress tracker/ dashboard.

Preferred Media Channels

Influencing Factors/ Platforms Used	Media habits
MAPPA	Watches animation produced by studio for their visuals and for reference for work
Linus Torvalds	Watches documentaries and interviews feauturing him
Github	To explore open-source projects to gain more creative insight

Figure 7: User Persona 2 (b)

5.6. User Journeys, User Flows, Empathy Maps

5.6.1. User Journeys and Flows

Journey 1: First Time User

Trigger: User downloads the app

User Flow:

Welcome Screen

User creates account by ‘signing up’

Consent and Privacy Information

User selects their purpose for using the app

Assessment of user’s mood

Personalize app – notifications, font size, light/dark mode

Home Screen

Success Criteria:

Completion rate

Time to complete onboarding

Feature engagement within 2 hours

Visual Representation:

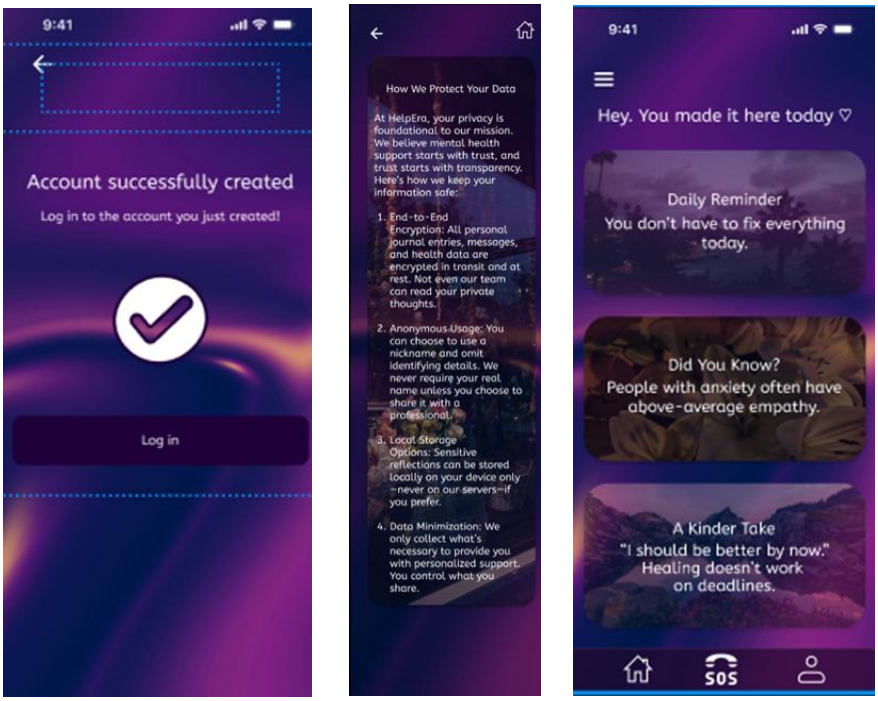


Figure 8: Journey 1

Journey 2: Daily Check-In

Trigger: Notification Reminder/ User opens app

User Flow:

User opens app

User logs in

Mood scale (emoji)

Journal track

Success Criteria:

Active users (daily)

Consistency in checking in

Visual Representation:



Figure 9: Journey 2

Journey 3: Crisis Support Flow

Trigger: User expresses distress and seeks help

User Flow:

Precarious mood detected

Immediate calming session initiated

Support Tool (breathing exercises, articles, guides)

Close contacts notified of user's distress (professional if user is affiliated with one)

Emergency contacts and hotlines displayed

Optional live support resources

Success Criteria:

Response time

Engage with support resources

Follow-up checks after emergency

Visual Representation:

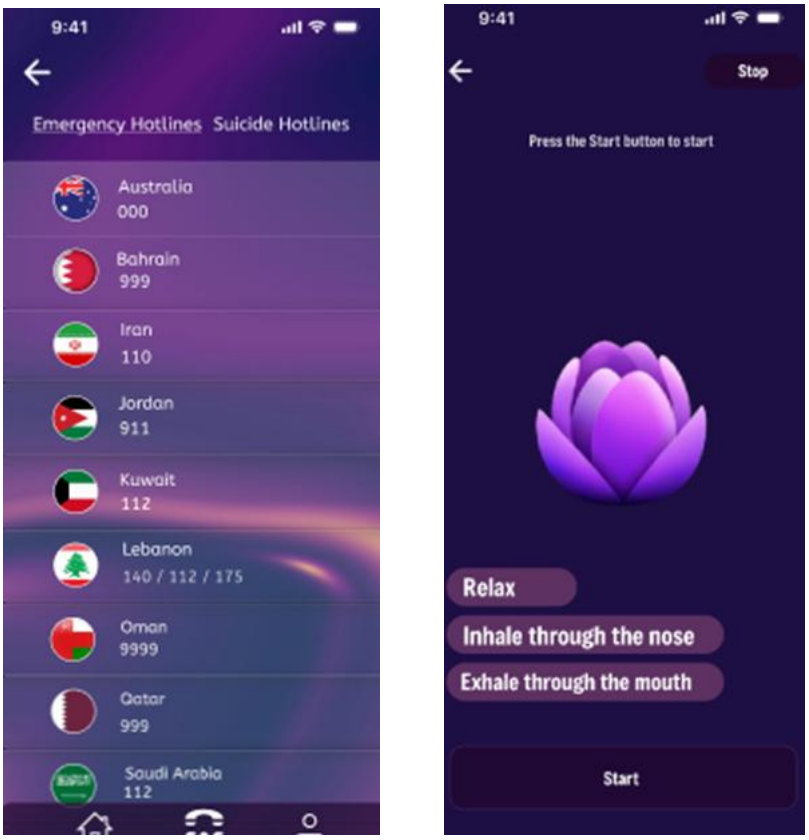


Figure 10: Journey 3

Journey 4: Engagement with other users

Trigger: User joins a community group

User Flow:

User opens community page

Selects the ‘Discover Groups’ option

Show a list of recommended groups based on user’s history and activity

User selects group (includes description of groups purpose)

User selects group to join based on their interests

Success Criteria:

Engagement in the community or group chat

Visual Representation:

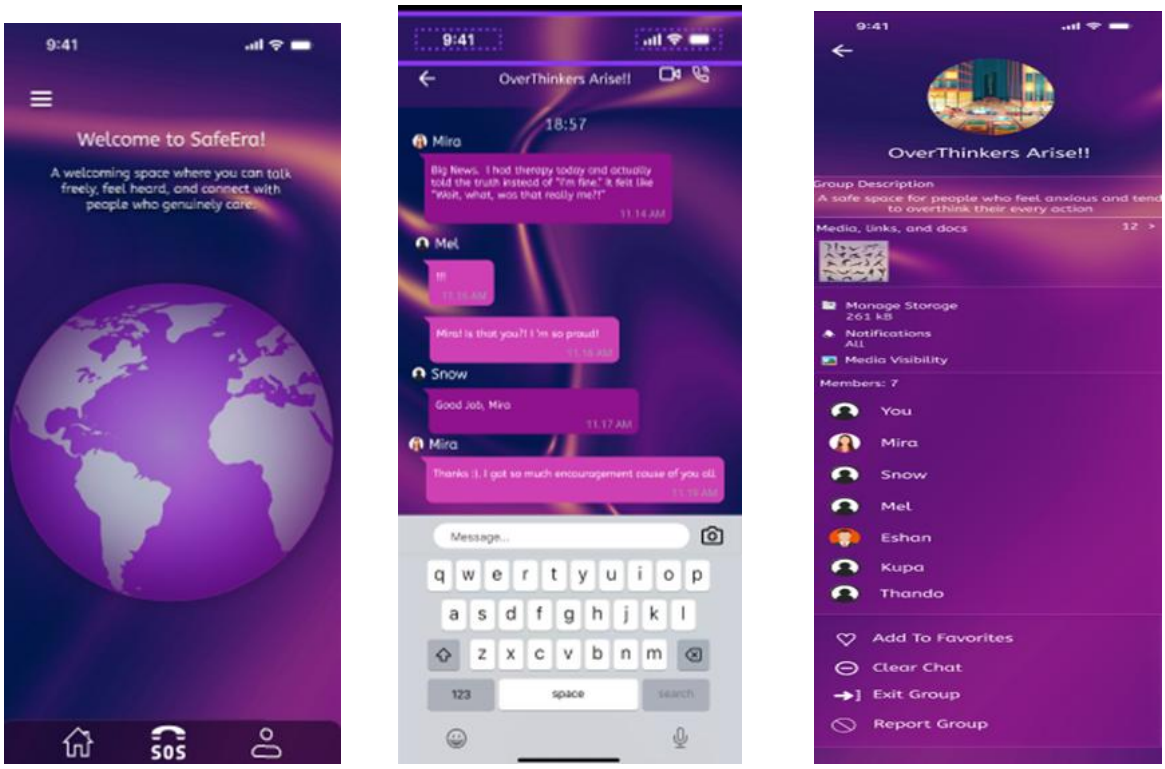


Figure 11: Journey 4

5.6.2. Empathy Maps

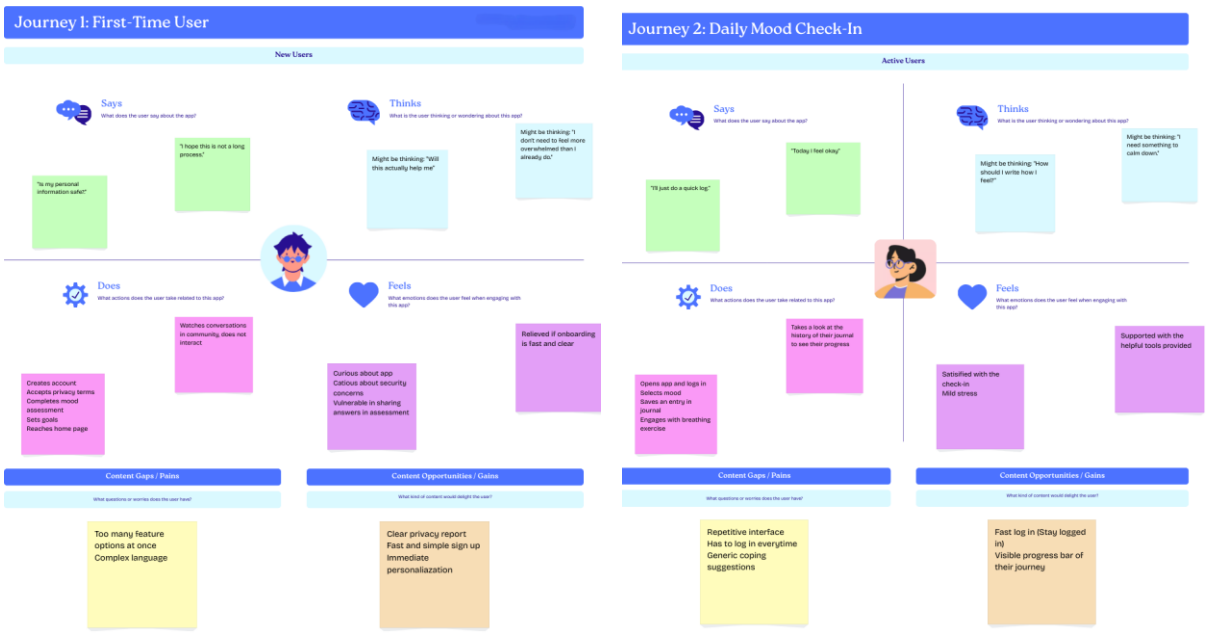


Figure 12: Empathy Maps (1)

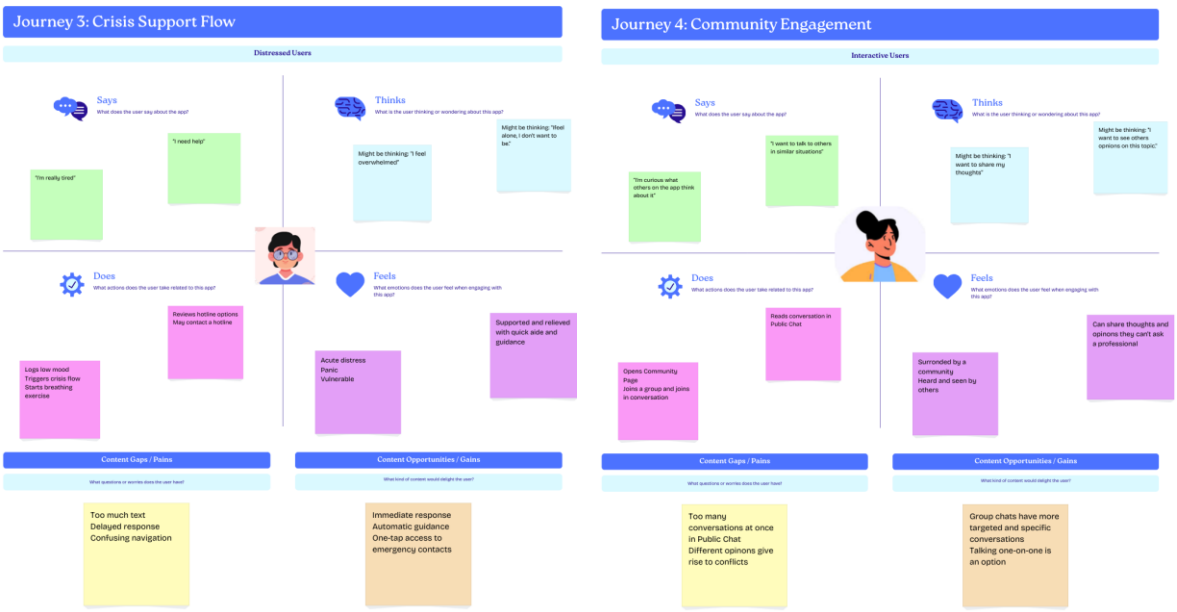


Figure 13: Empathy Maps (2)

Visual Comparison

User Journey	Anxiety Level	Cognitive Load	Emotional Vulnerability	Motivation Level	Urgency
Onboarding	5	6	6	7	4
Daily Check-In	4–7	3	5	6	5
Crisis Flow	9–10	8	10	7	10
Community Engagement	2	6	6	8	3

5.7. User Stories

Story 1

As Sarah, I want to be aware of the app's policies on data protection, so I can feel reassured about sharing my personal information.

Story 2

As Evan, I want to seek advice on breathing exercises, so that I can calm down my brother during panic attacks.

Story 3

As a psychology student, I want to research mental cases so that I can do my assignments.

Story 4

As a manager, I want to learn about mental illness, so that I can improve the workplace environment.

Story 5

As Ari, I want to see the patterns, so that I can share it with my therapist.

5.8. Use Cases

Use Case 1: Mood Entry Logging

Primary Actor: User

Goal: Make a record of the day's overall mood/ emotional state

Preconditions: User logs in to the app

Main Flow:

Select a mood state

Save entry

Redirected to page with suggested actions to take next

Alternative Flow:

Critical state of mood

Redirected to Emergency Hotline page

Crisis Support Flow

Use Case 2: Access Articles on Mental Health

Primary Actor: User

Goal: Learn about mental health condition

Main Flow:

From the Learn Page, select a mental health disorder to learn about

Select ‘Healing Guide’

Select One of the options (understanding, coping, help and breathing exercises)

Read and complete required instructions

Alternative Flow:

From the Learn Page, select a mental health disorder to learn about

Select ‘Explore Articles’

Browse through list of articles concerning mental health disorder selected

Selected desired article

5.9. Competitor Analysis

To effectively position Help Era in the digital mental health ecosystem, the team ran a formalized competitor analysis workshop using FigJam. As part of this process, we outlined each competitor’s core offerings, flow of user journey, safeguards and service gaps with respect to the product. From there, we then used affinity mapping to identify potential strengths to leverage and weaknesses that provide differentiation.

The following competitors were selected because they provide solutions to similar challenges around peer-based support, emotional expression, and online mental health communities.

5.9.1. 7 Cups

Description

- 7 Cups is an online mental health platform that provides active listening services conducted by “listeners”, volunteers who have been trained in active listening, via anonymous text or voice chats.

Advantages:

- 7 cups provide anonymous, 24/7 peer to peer emotional support chat through trained volunteer “listeners” in a supportive online community
- Immediate access to someone to talk to without having to book an appointment.
- They offer self-help tools and community style support alongside chat.

Disadvantages:

- 7 Cups support quality can be very inconsistent, because while listeners are trained, they are not licensed therapists, and the listeners' experience and skill (quality off support) may vary.
- Their safety systems and background checks on the “listeners” are not up to standard.
- There is limited continuity when going from peer support to professional care.

Translation to HelpEra

Based on our analysis of the support workshop, Help Era can leverage the advantage of receiving assistance immediately and without having to identify yourself, and then work to improve the overall safety and structure of the service.

To accomplish this, Help Era will:

- Create peer response templates that help to define the kind of support someone should expect (e.g., "Personal Experience", "Not Medical

Advice"). These templates will help make sure safety is considered when giving support.

- Add automated safety alerts that help users find a professional to work with if risk indicators are identified.
- Ensure professional verifications and background checks are done before allowing professionals to provide support. This will decrease the potential of any safety and security risks that may affect our users.
- Create a "My Journey" summary that is encrypted and will allow people to maintain the same level of care with the same person beyond the context of the workshop.

(7 Cups 2019)

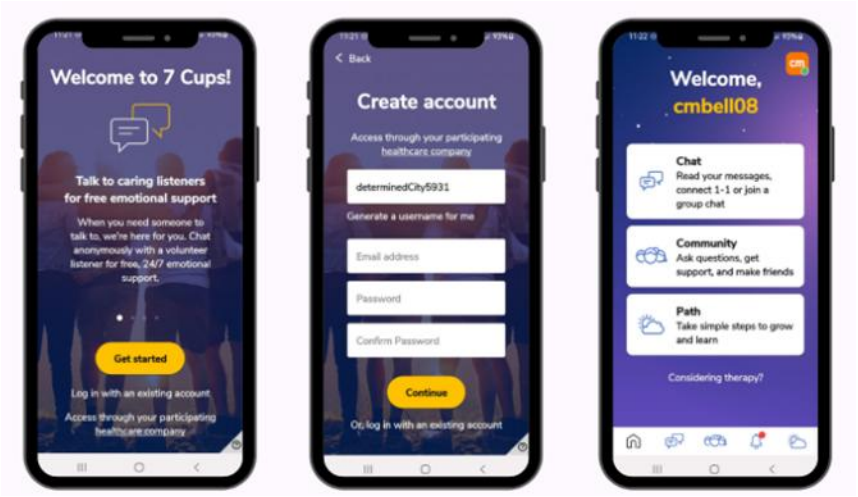


Figure 14: Kanban Board Structure (a)

5.9.2. TalkLife

Description

- TalkLife is an online peer-to-peer supports network for wellbeing. A global community that allows one to share the difficulties of life with people who face the same mental issues.

Advantages:

- Strong peer support community worldwide with a focus on emotional expression.
- They have integrated helpful safety systems to protect their community. AI enhanced moderation and real time monitoring.

- Clear message to users that they are not providing a crises service.
- Users have means of reporting content and have transparency into the moderation process.

Disadvantages:

- The app is not a substitute for professional mental health care, diagnosis, or crisis intervention, which is not sufficient for acute, immediate mental health crises.
- Community posts are often overwhelming for users and tend to focus heavily on venting.
- There is very little proactive guidance on what to do following emotional expression.
- Peer support systems may lack structure and clarity.

Translation to HelpEra

From the Figjam prototype design workshop, we determined that Help Era can leverage TalkLife's strong moderation systems in conjunction with developer community to improve structure.

To accomplish this, Helpera will:

- We can make our community more proactive by pairing posts with micro guides (e.g. grounding techniques when panic-related keywords are used).
- We can provide two user tracks "I am struggling" and "I am helping someone", reducing users' cognitive load.
- Implement clear labelling systems (e.g. personal experience, resource, or seek professional help).
- Create pathways for connecting with licensed professionals within the community experience.

  ("Peer Support Network for Mental Health - Support Group," n.d.)

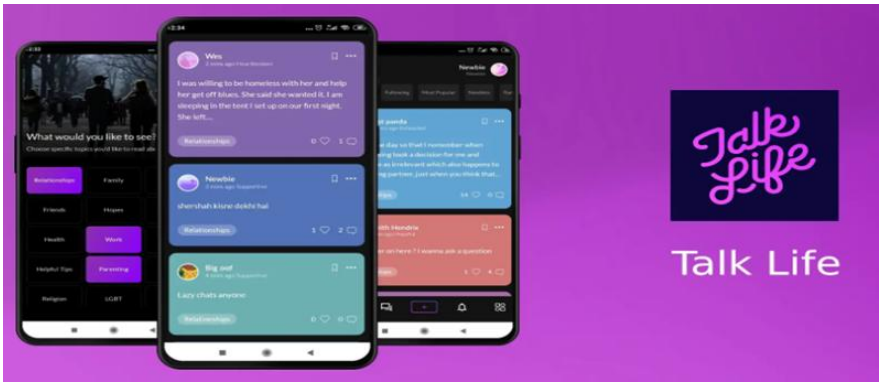


Figure 15: Kanban Board Structure (b)

5.9.3. HelpEra's competitive advantage compared to other apps

Through both competitive mapping of other apps and feature comparisons, Help Era's has identified a significant gap in this market, the current lack of properly integrated peer support, and verifiable continual connection to a professional.

Help Era provides the following differentiators:

- Peer support is moderated, along with guidance based on established standards for providing credible information.
- Professionals who are verified licensed practitioners, combined with identity-based filtering to assist in finding the right person.
- Encrypted "My Journey" profile to limit the risk of re-traumatization.
- Educational paths specific to who each supporter is supporting and what their needs are.
- Transparent data privacy systems as well as escalation protocols that focus on the safety of both the supporter and individual they are supporting.

This analysis indicates that while Help Era is also informed by existing sites, the focus here is to address the limitations of currently existing sites.

5.9.4. Best in world competitor analysis

To broaden our descriptive competitor analysis beyond direct mental health platforms, we ran a benchmarking workshop between industries using Figjam. We looked at top companies globally who are solving the same type of experience-related issues (e.g., uncertainty, engagement, tracking, development of trust) in the best way possible.

Instead of trying to copy features, we identified the underlying mechanisms and adapted them to the Help Era mental health context.

5.9.4.1. Uber

Feature to emulate: Real time status/ ETA.

Why it works:

By providing users with information about where their driver is located, how long it will take to get there, and what state the ride is currently in, Uber is able to reduce anxiety for users with a high level of transparency, which creates trust and reduces uncertainty.

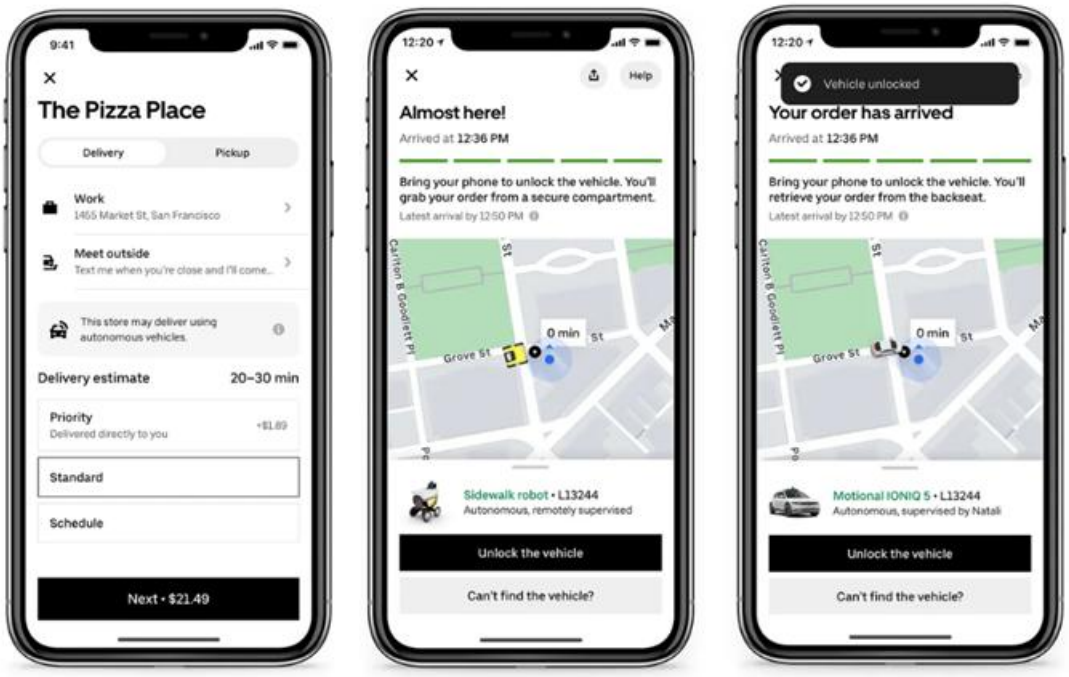


Figure 16 : Kanban Board Structure (c)

Application to HelpEra

Help Era will provide users with direct answers to:

- Where they are located on the waiting list to receive support from a professional
- What the estimated response time will be from a professional
- What the status of their appointment confirmation is

All of this will reduce anxiety while waiting for support and increase perception of reliability.

5.9.4.2. Deliveroo

Feature to emulate: Easier progress tracking.

Why it works:

Deliveroo's has a simple and visual way to track an order. At any given point, a customer will know what stage their order is currently at. Thus, the customer will have less of an unknown factor (uncertainty) of their order.

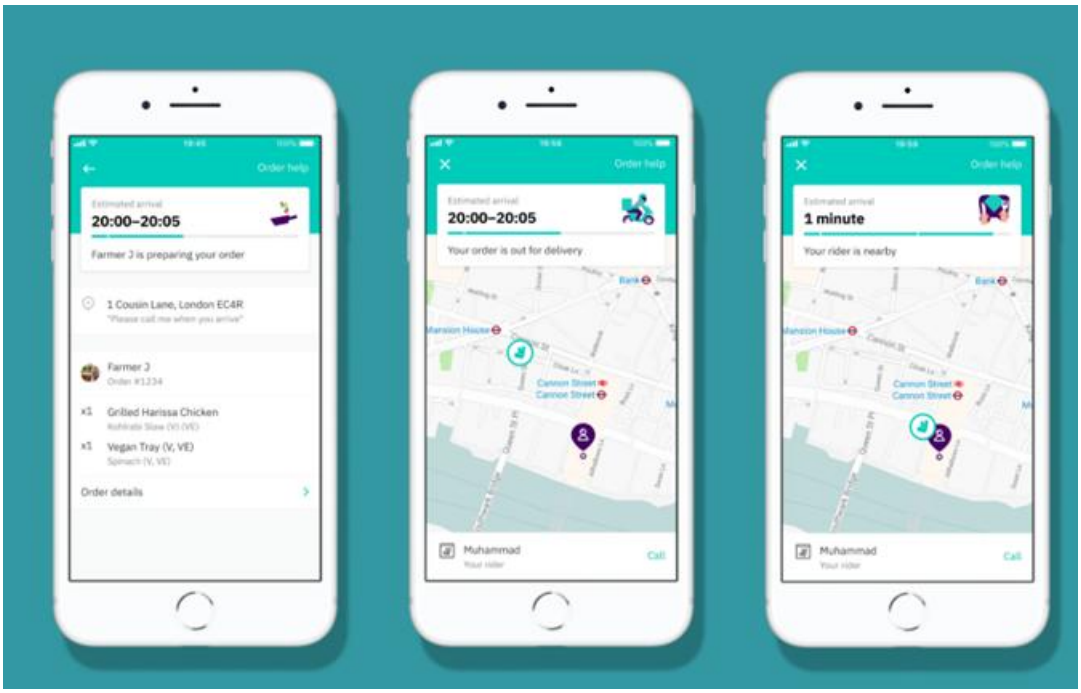


Figure 17: Kanban Board Structure (d)

Application to HelpEra:

HelpEra will have a clear indicator of the “Recovery journey” such as:

- Previously completed reflections
- Milestones(support)
- Progress made with every professional session.

All this supports forward movement and provides visual encouragement.

5.9.4.3. Duolingo

Feature to emulate: Micro-learning/Streaks

Why it works:

Duolingo’s method of using small, manageable daily tasks and streak systems that feel rewarding or engaging instead of feeling pressured to complete them, allows their users to continue to engage at a high level.

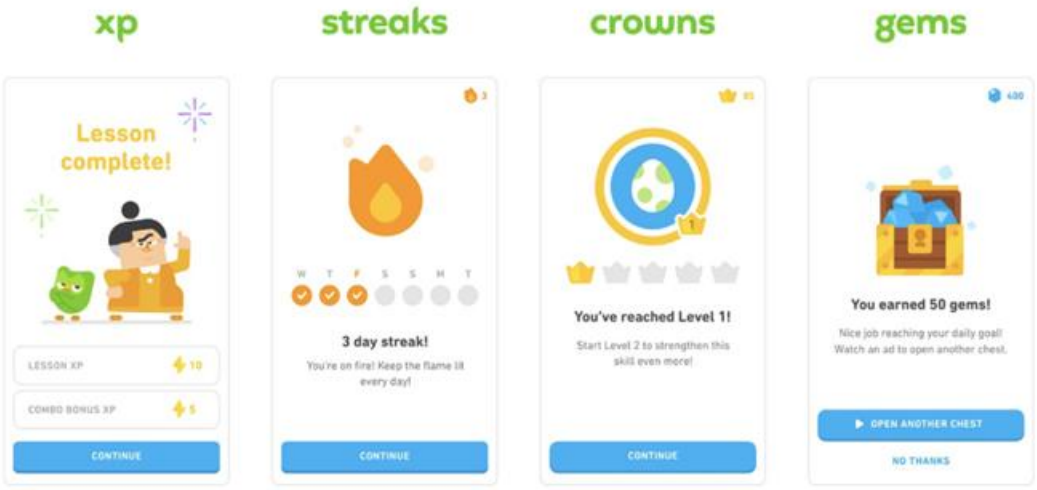


Figure *18*: Kanban Board Structure (e)

Application to HelpEra:

HelpEra will utilize several strategies to create a more consistent environment for journaling and check-ins, including:

- Light XP/streak systems.
- Positive reinforcement.

- Non-punitive tracking of engagement.

These methods will provide users with a consistent way to engage in their mental health without feeling ashamed or guilty for not completing tasks.

5.9.4.4. Airbnb

Feature to emulate: Personalized host profiles.

Why it works:

Airbnb has detailed host profiles with pictures, personality cues, and reviews that enable individuals to build trust in both the person and their interaction.



Figure 19: Kanban Board Structure (e)

Application to HelpEra:

HelpEra will create professional profiles that will consists of:

- A short introductory bio of the professional.
- Descriptive information about their preferred communication style.
- Tags denoting their area of specialization.
- Additional elements that help determine their ‘vibe/check’.

These components help users evaluate and identify professionals based on compatibility factors versus just qualification indicators.

5.9.4.5. Desing Thinking Translation

We created a visual representation of how each borrowed characteristic corresponds to identified issues (uncertainty, feeling overwhelmed, not trusting anything, and feeling disengaged). Following that, we took those characteristics and translated them into methods that would be appropriate for mental health, to ensure they fit within parameters of emotional safety and ethics.

This cross – industry analysis we did strengthen HelpEra's UX by emulating proven engagement and transparency mechanisms while adapting them responsibly for sensitive healthcare contexts.

5.10. Pain Points

Design thinking process

The team used Fig Jam to run a design thinking workshop to explore and establish the top challenges young adults may face when using mental health apps. Through user research and iterative discussion, insights were captured and organized using affinity mapping which helped group related pain points together to identify the main themes associated with the user experience.

Usability and content design:

Information overload

- Having too much text or content at once can be overwhelming to users.
- Key features and guides may be difficult to locate.
- Difficulty in prioritizing in which guides and articles to read.

Navigation difficulties

- Users struggle to find past journal entries or progress history.

- An unclear app design which negatively impacts users' continuation with the app.

Accessibility issues

- Fonts being small and poor contract making content difficult to read.
- Limited customizable settings for visual or cognitive needs.
- Content that's written in complex language limits understanding.

Social and peer interactions:

Community risks

- Risk of being exposed to content that may trigger an emotional reaction or conflict with other users on the app.
- Inappropriate advice that could be harmful given by peers.
- Difficulty in reporting any unsafe content.

Peer support challenges

- Support interactions may feel generic or unhelpful increasing emotional distress.
- Unclear guidelines on what to do during a crisis or resource(articles) are outdated.
- The risk of feeling isolated even in a community environment.

Psychological and emotional barriers:

Privacy

- Unable to determine what measure to be taken in protecting users' sensitive data from being shared or leaked.
- Uncertainty about how journal entries or reflections will be secured.
- Hesitant to engage fully because of confidentiality concerns.

Engagement

- Users feel guilty for missing daily reflection or exercise.

- Users not knowing their progress (through tracking) can hinder their motivation to continue using the app.
- Lack or reminders to maintain routine use.

Efficiency

- Does not provide certainty that the app offers the user a meaningful benefit.
- Limited number of resources available.
- Frustration when users expected outcomes does not match their expectations or the actual outcome.
- Hesitant in trusting automated AI-based advice.

Technical and performance:

Stability

- Apps crash or freezing during use, causing users to lose their entries and progress.
- Unexpected bugs interrupt sessions.

Speed

- Slow loading time when accessing features or content on the app.
- Delays that may occur on the app can be frustrating to users when trying to complete their tasks.

Notifications

- Inconsistent or delayed notifications reduces users' engagement.
- Users may miss reminders for reflections or support to check in.

Operational and professional Matchmaking:

Access to appropriate professionals

- Difficulty finding a professional that meets preferences.
- Limited availability of trained mental health experts at times of need.

- Continuously having to re-tell trauma with new professionals will lead to burnout.

Continuity of care

- Breaks in professional support when switching providers.
- Challenge in maintaining a consistent treatment plan

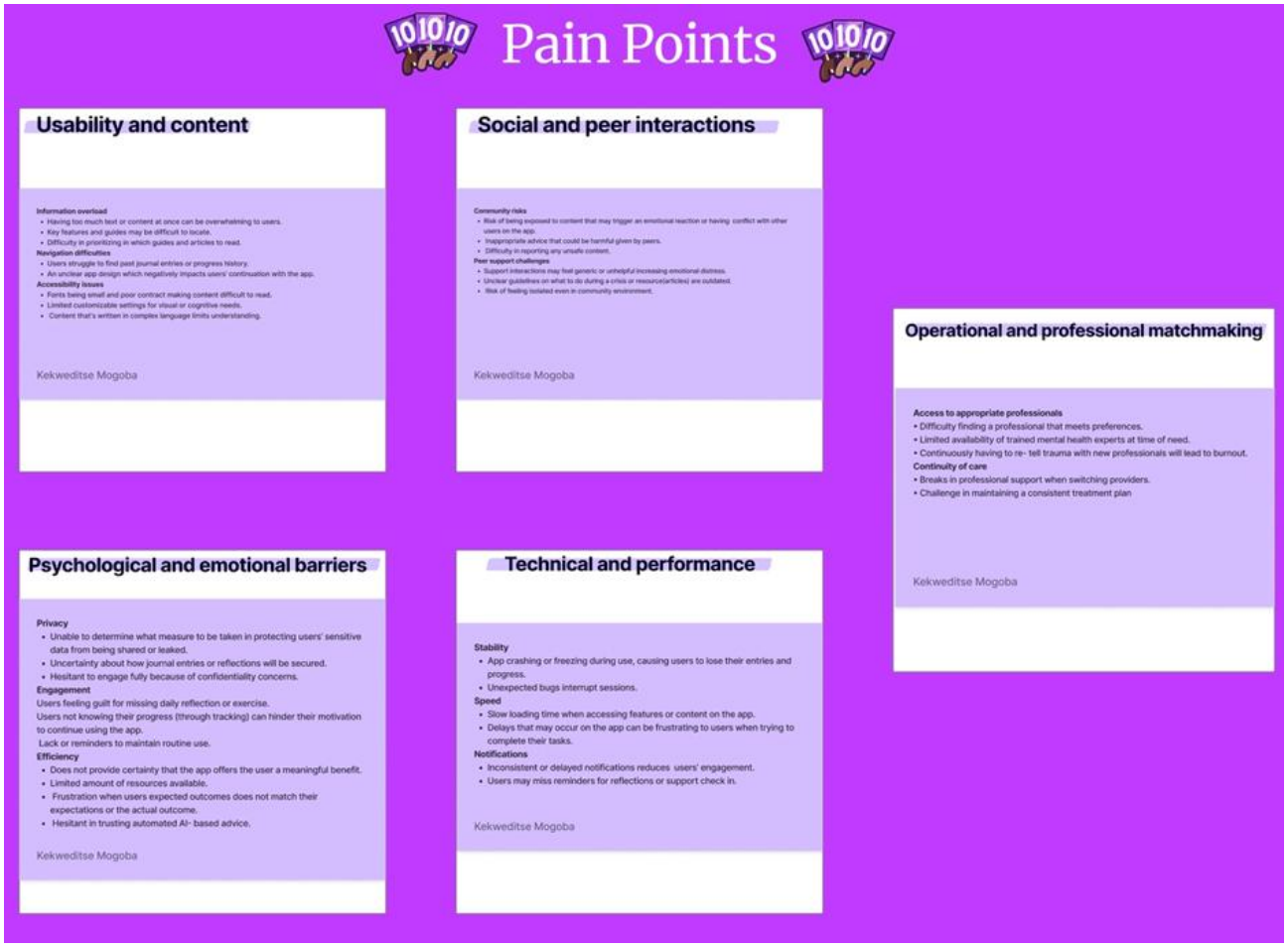


Figure 20: Kanban Board Structure (f)

5.11. Problem Statement

Based on the affinity mapping exercise done in FigJam, we identified recurring patterns across usability, technical, emotional, and operational challenges. These grouped pain points were refined into clear, structured problem statements that define the key issues our design aims to address.

1. Privacy and trust

Who: Users who will be sharing personal sensitive information within the app.

What: The app does not provide enough information about how personal data is stored, protected, or used, and as a result causes some users to feel uncertain and hesitant about using the app.

Where: Throughout many different areas of the app, primarily around the journal entries made or when users are in contact with other professionals via the app.

When: Anytime a user must input private or sensitive data into the app

Why: Trust in mental health support systems is very important. If a user does not receive clear ethical data practices and transparency, they may decide to not share that data with the app or stop using it.

2. Safety and stability

Who: Users using the journal and reflection feature.

What: Users may experience emotional risk due to technical crashes, lost entries, unreliable notifications, and uncertainty about data protection.

Where: In journal sessions, mood tracking, or using reflection feature.

When: When users are feeling vulnerable and trying to express their feelings or relying on reminders for mental health routines.

Why: Emotional safety and technical reliability are important for consistent engagement. Therefore, if users don't feel safe storing their personal entries or if

they become discouraged by the instability of the app, they may no longer want to use the app.

3. Supporter anxiety and content overload

Who: Friends and family members supporting someone experiencing mental health issues.

What: Supporters may feel overwhelmed by content heaving reading materials and generic advice making it difficult to provide meaningful help.

Where: Within educational sections, guidance tools, and support resources made for caregivers.

When: During times when immediate help/ guidance is needed to respond to someone in distress.

Why: Clear, actionable, and digestible guidance reduces anxiety for supporters and improves the quality of assistance provided

4. Accessibility barriers

Who: Users with disabilities, cognitive overload, or high emotional distress.

What: The app lacks accessibility features such as high contrast modes, adjustable text sizes, simplified layouts, and screen reader compatibility.

Where: Across all core features in the app, including journaling, navigation menus, and content resources.
When: During regular usage, specifically during emotionally overwhelming moments.

Why: Having an inclusive design ensures equal access to mental health support. Without accessibility and consideration, vulnerable users may be excluded from benefiting fully from the app.

5. Matchmaking and continuity friction

Who: Users who are looking for professional mental health support after previously relying on self-help tools and never reached out for help before.

What: Users may need to share personal history but may come across incompatible or unavailable professionals, which causes frustration and emotional exhaustion.

Where: During professional matching and appointment booking process

When: When users try to shift from self-guided support to professional mental health care support.

Why: A personalized and ongoing matching system allows for decreased traumatization to users, improved levels of trust with new providers, and an increased likelihood for users to continue seeking professional mental health support over time.

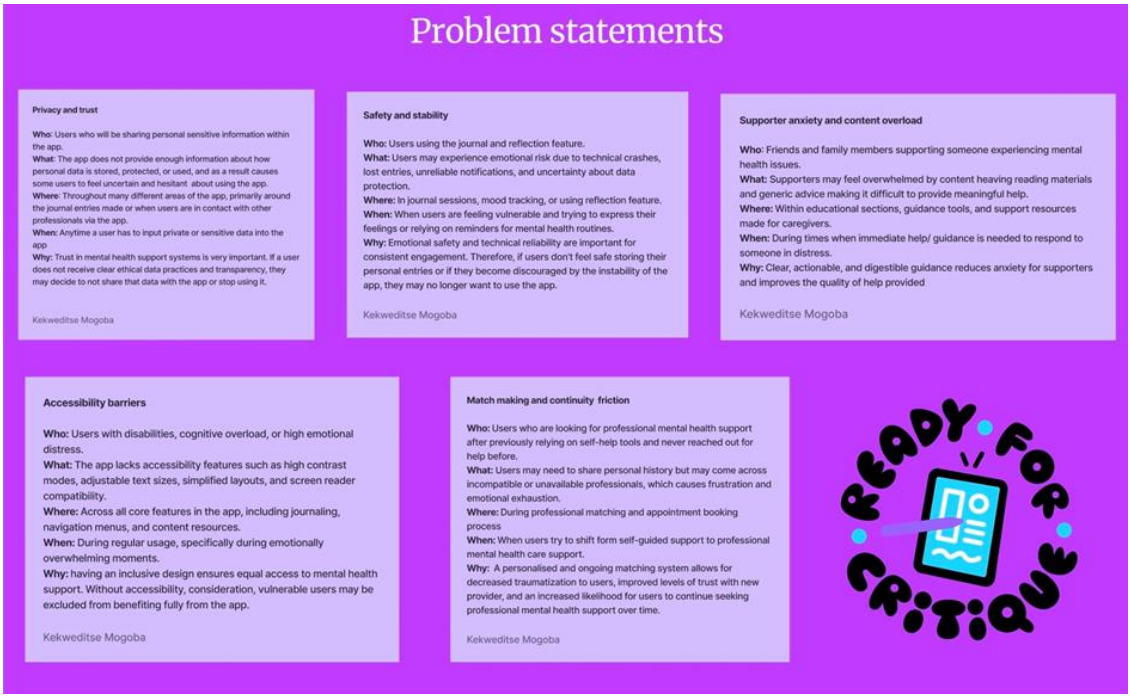


Figure 21: Kanban Board Structure (f)

5.12. Ideate Solutions

The team transformed the core challenges into focused HMW questions, which guided the team during ideation. Each HMW statement was created from the refined problem statements and allows for creative exploration while still being aligned to user's needs. HMW statements were grouped by the same thematic clusters established through affinity mapping to ensure consistency and strategic direction for development

5.12.1. How Might We Statements:

Gentle guidance and structured Access

- How might we create soft, non-clinical entry points that make first users feel safe and supported?
- How might we guide our users towards a clear starting point without overwhelming them with too much information?
- How might we let users use the app without having to make a commitment right away?
- How might we make the mental health content structures in a way that is reassuring to look at, as well as able to follow easily?

Match making and continuity

- How might we reduce the emotional burden of repeatedly sharing trauma with new professionals?
- How might we create a secure summary that allows users to determine when and how it will be shared with multiple providers on the app?
- How might we improve matching a professional to the user through various types of filters based on identity, language, and specialty?
- How might we ensure continuity of care when our users decide to transition between professionals?

Clear, Simplified support for others

- How might we help friends and family through stressful situations by providing them with guidance?

- How might we simplify complex mental health advice that we provide into easily understandable actionable steps?
- How might we present our support content to users in a way that reduces their chances of becoming overwhelmed with information
- How might we reduce anxiety felt by supporters, while continuing to provide responsible and safe advice for those needing help

Privacy and trust

- How might we let users know how their information is being collected, stored, and used?
- How might we provide visible cues that provide assurance to users that their information is private?
- How might we give users complete control over who has access to their shared content?
- How might we include transparency in the on boarding process, so that users trust in the system from the beginning?

Accessibility and Cognitive support

- How might we develop a simple user interface for users experiencing cognitive overload?
- How might we allow users to switch between standard mode and focus mode?
- How might we enhance readability using adjustable front sizes and contrasting themes?
- How might we ensure the system is compatible with assistive technologies like screen readers?



Figure 22: Kanban Board Structure (g)

5.12.2. Ideate Solutions

After completing the “How might we” sessions, a systematic brainstorming session using Figjam was conducted to create a variety of potential answers. Individual idea generation was first done to enhance creativity before sharing and categorizing them through an affinity map. This became the beginning of merging similar or duplicate ideas, eliminating impractical solutions and identifying high potential/impact answers based on their feasibility, user value, and alignment with problem statements.

Through discussion our team reached consensus on solutions possibilities that could result in realistic functional and non-functional requirements for the next phase of development. These resulted in the final generated solutions grouped according to the following themes:

Theme 1: Gentle guidance and structured access

Support first steps

1. Soft, non-clinical entry points for new users to feel less intimidated.
2. Optional guided pathways where to begin without the need for step-by-step guidance.
3. Clear staring points using supportive language instead of medical terminology to make users feel more comfortable.
4. Only presenting a limited amount of information initially and allowing users to explore more as they go further into the app.

User controlled exploration

1. Self-paced interaction without any upfront assessments.
2. Low stakes browsing that allows users to explore anonymously (use private features) before sharing personal information.
3. A Flexible navigation that allows users to control what features they choose to access first.

Theme 2: Matchmaking and continuity:

Encrypted passport

1. User-controlled summary of their mental health history in a secure manner.
2. Users select what they want to share with professionals.
3. Avoids users having to tell their trauma multiple times during consultations.
4. Supports continuity of care when changing providers.

Identity and vibe filtering

1. Professional profiles containing tags for gender, language, specialty, and therapeutic style.
2. Short descriptive information about health professionals is available to determine personality compatibility.
3. Advanced filtering options are available for better match accuracy and to address preferences.

Theme 3: Clear, simplified support for others

Progressive support cards

1. Prompts that include specific situations such as “What can I say when my friend is feeling anxious?”
2. Step-by-step guidance of a general nature, with some examples of how to help.
3. Clear examples of what to do and not do to encourage positive responses to your friends.

Progressive disclosure

1. Information provided in smaller sections instead of one large document.
2. Important information will be displayed first, with optional deeper explanations.
3. An organized format that decreases anxiety and cognitive overload.

Theme 4: Privacy and Trust

1. Transparent onboarding describes how data is collected, stored, and used.

2. Visual reassurances will include lock icons and “Private” labels to show the receiver that their information is safe.
3. Confirmation messages that provide real-time feedback as to whether the user's information can be viewed or not.
4. Micro-tutorials and FAQs that inform users on how to manage consent and permission rights.

Theme 5: Accessibility and cognitive support

Focused mode toggle

1. Simplified User Interface that has larger fonts & high contrast themes.
2. Minimal graphics and less dense content on screen will be helpful.
3. Ability to use either "Standard" Mode or "Focus" Mode depending on the user's needs.

Screen reader optimization

1. All buttons and icons are labelled descriptively, making it possible for people with assistive technology to read content.
2. The structure of the overall layout and the way items are displayed in the layout are compatible with the screen readers.
3. Accessibility compliance is built into the fundamental design of the application.

Through collaboration, these ideas created solutions to create a mental health platform that is safe, inclusive, and user-centered; addressing emotional, technical and accessibility barriers. These five themes will provide a cohesive system that enhances the credibility, usability, and long-term user engagement of the overall app. The themes also work together to enhance the ability of a system to be both functional as well as provide emotional support and be ethically responsible.

6. Requirement Specification

6.1. Functional Requirements

6.1.1. User Requirements

User Requirements	Description
Account Management	Users shall be able to create and manage a personal account
Login / Logout	Users shall be able to securely log in and log out
Supporter Tools	Supporters (friends or family) shall be able to view 'Crisis Action Cards' with step-by-step guidance for helping someone in distress
Daily Mental Health Tracking	Users shall be able to log daily mental health data (notes, mood)
Data Portability	Users shall be able to share a secure 'User Passport' with a chosen professional to avoid repeating their history
Self-Reflection / Journalling	Users shall be able to record daily journal entries and track their moods using a simplified 'vibe' selector
Content Access	Users must be able to access health content in a structured, non-overwhelming format (reduces cognitive overload)
Professional Connection	Users shall be able to browse a directory of verified mental health professionals and filter by preferences (language, gender, speciality)
Supporter Access	Supporters must be able to access clear, actionable guidance without professional

	help (reduces anxiety and misuse of information)

6.1.2. System Requirements

System Requirements	Description
Authentication Service ??	The system shall authenticate users via Firebase and provide password access for the 'Private Vault'
Auto-Save and Crash Recovery	The system shall automatically save journal entries and restore then after crashes
Search and Filter Logic	The system shall query the professional database and return matches based on user-defined tags and real-time availability
Data Encryption (need to od)	The system shall encrypt all personal mental health data
Local Data Caching ??	The system shall implement a local database to auto-save user keystrokes in the journaling module every 5 seconds
Emergency Trigger	The system shall automatically save journal entries and restore them after crashes
Content Management System (CMS)	The system shall categorize educational content into 'User' and 'Supporter' tracks and display based on role selection

6.2. Non-Functional Requirements

Category	Requirement	Description
Usability	Simplified Mode	Interface shall display no more than 3 primary actionable items at any time to reduce cognitive load
	Accessibility	App shall comply with WCAG 2.1 level AA standards, ensuring minimum contrast ratio of 4.5:1 for all text
	Learnability	First-time users shall find and open a 'Breathing Exercise' within 10 seconds of launching the app without prior training
	Intuitive UI	App shall have a simple, easy-to-use interface suitable for non-technical users
	Accessibility Features	App shall support large text, screen readers, and other accessibility options
	Task Efficiency	Key tasks shall be completed in under 1 minute
Performance	Response Time	Search results for professional matches shall display in under 2 seconds on standard 4G

	Launch Speed	Cold start time (from icon to dashboard) shall not exceed 3 seconds
	Concurrent Users	System shall support at least 10,000 concurrent users without performance degradation
	Data Synchronization	Synchronization shall complete within 5 seconds
Reliability	Availability	App shall have 99.9% uptime to ensure access to crisis resources anytime
	Data Integrity	System shall recover 100% of text in current journaling session via local cache in case of crash
Security	Encryption	All user-professional communications and personal journal entries shall be encrypted using AES-256 at rest and in transit
	Authentication	System shall protect user data via secure authentication
	Privacy / Guest Mode	Users shall be able to browse resources in ‘Guest Mode’ without submitting Personally Identifiable Information

6.3. Hierarchical Task Analysis

A Hierarchical Task Analysis (HTA) divides a user goal into smaller sub-goals and actions demonstrating how users accomplish the most important activities in the system. This assists in confirming the way the prototype facilitates the work efficiently and with a user-friendly interface, particularly when it comes to sensitive circumstances such as mental health assistance where the user might be stressed or overwhelmed. The report entails several key activities that are to be provided with HTAs and a written description of the activities.

In the case of HelpEra, the following HTAs are formulated on the real kickoff prototype flow and screens and are also informed by the way that the design was developed out of the broad "brainstormed functionality" of Worksheet 3 into a more defined and task-oriented navigation and mood-first entry experience. A broad range of features was initially listed in Worksheet 3 (e.g., account management, daily tracking, journaling, community chat, professional matching and My Journey). In the kickoff prototype, these features are divided into more apparent primary actions and a less emotional-entry point (e.g.; How are you feeling today?), which makes cognitive load fewer and more efficiently leads users to the correct task as soon as possible.

6.3.1. HTA Task 1: Fast Access to Emergency/hotline Support

User objective: The user wishes to access an emergency hotline without a lot of steps.

The importance of this task: Early walkthroughs revealed that the hotline search was somewhat hidden, so the design was changed to allow emergency access to become more visible on the opening screen. This alteration is mirrored by the kickoff prototype whereby it offers "Emergency/Hot-line Services itself, not as an extension of the Login/Sign Up.

0. Contact emergency/hotline assistance.

1. Open HelpEra
2. Sent To: Select Emergency/Hot-line Services.
3. See emergency/hotline (country/service list)
4. Select a hotline/service
5. Contact (call/message/redirect)

Plan 0: Do 1–2. In the case when the user is in urgent need, go straight to 35 without searching the features.

The difference between this and Worksheet 3: Worksheet 3 contained such a general feature list, with the inclusion of Support Access. This is reinforced in the prototype with emergency access becoming a first-screen action rather than an option buried in the nest, as actual user behavior in an emergency would be, and time-to-help would be minimized.

6.3.2. HTA Task 2: Fill out a Mood Check-In and Begin a Breathing Exercise

User objective: I want to use the app as an instant way of gaining emotional support when I am anxious/panicky.

The importance of this task: The survey results revealed that distress commonly occurs (most users feel under stress regularly/a week), and it is necessary to provide users with fast and low-effort assistance. The prototype focuses on the short-term coping behavior by beginning with a mood-check-in and directing to the basic tools, such as breathing.

0. Get immediate assistance with check-in + breathing.

1. Open HelpEra
2. View prompt: What is your mood today?
3. Please choose what you are feeling (e.g., Anxious / Panicky)
4. Select Breathing Exercise (tool entry)

5. Tap Start
6. Complete breathing instructions.
7. Go back to the main application or go on with other assistance.

Plan 0: Do 1–3. In case there is a high-distress state being selected by the user, do 4-6 immediately. Otherwise, the user can move on to journaling or learning material.

The difference between this and Worksheet 3: Worksheet 3 referred to the concept of Daily mental health tracking as the act of recording and seeing trends. The prototype puts the check-in as an instant point of decision (How are you feeling today?), which is more suitable in support of low-capacity moments.

6.3.3. HTA Task 3: Start a Healing Guide and Open Relevant Content using the Learn Section

User objective: Discover organized learning material without being overwhelmed.

The importance of this task: Within feedback, the “Learn” section was also said to be daunting when the number of categories presented simultaneously is too large, so the design shifted to more guided access. This is manifested in the kickoff prototype with a distinct path to start your healing guide and dividing the content into brief, easily read, modules with mini-read labels and a progress bar.

0. Discover information about mental health with the Healing Guide.

1. Open HelpEra
2. Select Learn as the main menu.
3. Choose Your Healing Guide.
4. Select a guiding subject (ex: Understanding Anxiety).
5. Read the choice of module (short format).
6. Or move on to the next module (e.g. Coping..., Helping Someone...).
7. Exit or return to Learn menu

Plan 0: Do 1–3. Then either:

- Do 4–6 to adhere to organized learning, or
- Click on Explore Articles when the user wants to browse.

The difference between this and Worksheet 3: Worksheet 3 demanded that the content access be organized and not intimidating. The prototype realizes that intent by substituting a massive category dump with a directed route (Healing Guide) and brief courses, which indicate effort/time (min read) and percentage of progress.

6.3.4. HTA Task 4: Reflect on Personal Progress by Creating a Journal

User objective: Journaling is to use journaling as a self-reflection tool and be consistent.

The importance of this task: In our study, journaling was rated among the most appreciated support features, and at the same time, it had been associated with the risk of losing text (e.g., through crashes). This was done in worksheet 3 through Secure Journaling and Auto-save and crash recovery. The prototype considers journaling as one of the main navigation items (My Journal), which is why it is an essential use case but not a secondary feature.

0. Write a journal entry

1. Open HelpEra
2. Navigate to My Journal
3. A new entry (select prompt/type)
4. Write reflection text
5. Save entry
6. View past entries (history view) optionally.
7. Return to home/menu

Plan 0: Do 1–5 for a new entry. In case the user desires to ponder, before leaving, do 6.

The difference between this and Worksheet 3: Worksheet 3 displayed the following requirements-level items: journaling, auto-save, and recovery. Journaling is also a top-level action in prototype navigation, just the same as Learn, Community, and Talk to a Professional, so it is easier to find and use daily.

6.3.5. Summary: What the HTAs Show about the Evolved Prototype

Comprehensively, such HTAs reassure that the kickoff prototype of HelpEra can assist with the most critical user goals including (1) quick access to emergencies, (2) mood-first redirecting to coping tools, (3) systematic learning that fosters a sense of relief, and (4) easy access to journaling as a fundamental feature. It is an improvement of the broad feature inventory of Worksheet 3 to more specific, task-oriented, flows, and particularly relevant to users who feel stressed and less attentive.

7. UI/UX Goals

7.1. Usability Goals

Easy access to professional Help (Learnability)

Through Helpera app design, new users can quickly understand how to access peer support, professional services, and learning resources without prior knowledge. This is facilitated by providing users with comprehensive onboarding instructions/guidance. Our app uses intuitive categorization and familiar interaction patterns which reduces learning curve.

Consistency and standards

Using consistent terminology, visuals design, and interaction patterns throughout the entire app. There is a consistent use of button styles, icons, color and labelling across the application, therefore making it easier for our users to navigate the application without any confusion or excessive cognitive burden. By using consistent visual cues, we make it easier for users to identify differences between professional support and peer support. Additionally, this builds a greater sense of familiarity with the application and increases confidence in being able to successfully navigate through the system.

Error prevention

Helpera's interface has been designed to guide users from performing unsafe and unintended actions. The design includes confirmation prompts prior to submitting any sensitive information/material, for example, sharing personal information or booking an appointment with a professional. Our application provides users with clear instructions or contextual cues to minimize the chance of making errors, while providing users with option to undo an action or the ability to recover from an error, these recovery pathways ensure that errors do not result in frustration or data loss. This is particularly important for users who are going through emotionally troubling situations.

Visibility of system status

At all times, users will know where they are in the app and which services are currently being accessed. Through clear page titles, navigation highlights, and progress indicators. Helpera's goal is to provide transparency by making users' location in the application clear. When accessing professional services or peer support via the application, the system will clearly communicate the type of support service being accessed. Immediate feedback messages confirm actions such as saving a journal entry or sending a message; this will let users know that their action has been successfully completed.

Accessibility and inclusivity

Accessibility and inclusivity are important usability goals for Helpera. Users with a range of abilities, in terms of cognitive, emotional, and physical, will find that our app meets their needs. Features include adjustable font sizes, high contrast color themes, simple layouts, speech to text support and works well with various assistive technologies to ensure inclusive access. We took web content accessibility guidelines into account when designing the app to ensure that all users can comfortably and effectively interact and use the app, to help with any mental issues they may be facing

7.2. User Experience Goals

Empowerment:

Our app helps users build their confidence to manage their own mental health or to assist someone else with their mental health. HelpEra provides a structured way to receive guidance, tools and access to professional support. This gives our users more decision-making control in how they feel and what they can do. Ultimately, we designed the app to promote informed and active engagement with no passive consumption.

Respectful:

Ensuring respectful interactions is important for HelpEras effectiveness. All topics that could be viewed as sensitive are handled in a respectful and professional manner. Clear content warnings, language and boundaries to differentiate between a peer's guidance and a professional's guidance are provided. We incorporated an empathetic and non-judgmental tone throughout the app, so users will feel respected throughout their journey.

Emotional safety:

HelpEra's visual design is focused towards establishing a calm layout, predictable interactions, and supportive micro copy that will help reduce the user's stress. The color palette and/or structured information flow is designed so that the user will not feel overwhelmed while using the app. The app does not provide unexpected or unsolicited prompts, therefore the environment created by the app will provide an emotionally safe experience for the user.

User control and direction:

HelpEra aims to allow users to control their support options. They have the choice of using self-guided tools, peer support, or professional services. Users can do so without any pressure. Additionally, privacy settings give them the ability to determine how much information is shared about themselves and with whom. This control increases user engagement and decreases anxiety associated with using these resources.

Trust and credibility:

Building trust and credibility is a critical goal for HelpEra, particularly around mental health support. The app provides a clear distinction between content generated by professionals versus peers. Licensed professionals are authenticated, and their credentials are visible to all users. There are transparent explanations of all privacy practices and procedures related to data security and ethical behavior. These elements, in combination, create a sense of credibility and trust that users will continue to have over time.

8. UI/UX Design Principles

Our high-fidelity prototype was designed with both functionality and user experience in mind. This analysis examines how Norman's design principles and visual design principles, layout, hierarchy, color, typography, imagery and copy choices work together to create an interface that is intuitive, accessible, and emotionally supportive for users.

8.1. Design Principles

Explanation: Norman's design principles guide how an interface should be structured to be usable, intuitive, and aesthetically pleasing. They focus on creating experiences that meet user goals while minimizing confusion or frustration. In high-fidelity prototypes, these principles influence decisions such as what features to highlight, how interactions behave, and how feedback is presented. Applying design principles ensures that there is a reduction of cognitive load and improving satisfaction.

How we incorporated it: Our high-fidelity prototype applies Norman's design principles to ensure the interface is intuitive, safe, and emotionally supportive. Key features such as the SOS button and emergency hotline access are highly visible, ensuring users can quickly access urgent support without searching. Clear feedback is provided throughout the app for example; users receive confirmation messages after account creation, email verification, password setup, and when users want to exit the breathing exercises, reassuring them that their actions were successful. Constraints are used in the sign-up process through password requirements and verification of codes, preventing errors, and enhancing security. Consistency is maintained across navigation elements, such as the fixed bottom navigation bar and sidebar menu, while affordances are reinforced through clear buttons, toggles, and interactive filters that visually indicate how they should be used.

8.2. UI/UX Design Principles and Visual Design Principles

Explanation: UI/UX design principles focus on usability, accessibility, and interaction, while visual design principles deal with aesthetics, layout, and visual hierarchy. Together, they ensure that the interface not only looks good but also works well for the user. These principles also include clarity, consistency, affordance, and feedback in UX, as well as alignment, contrast, balance, and spacing in visual design. High-fidelity prototypes use these principles to create a smooth and satisfying experience that aligns with user expectations. When implemented correctly, they improve navigation, reduce errors, and communicate meaning visually.

How we incorporated it: The app integrates both UX and visual design principles to create a balanced, user-centered experience. From a UX perspective, features such as password reset, two-factor authentication, private mode toggling, and filtering professionals by specialization or language prioritize usability, flexibility, and user control. Recognition rather than recall is supported through visible menu labels like “Learn,” “Community,” “Talk to a Professional,” and “My Journal,” reducing cognitive load. Visual design principles are expressed through the calming purple background with yellow hues, consistent placement of sidebar images depicting serene landscapes and centered, clear layouts for content such as “Daily Reminders,” “Did You Know,” facts, and cognitive reflections. The interface avoids clutter by presenting structured sections and guided navigation, supporting both minimalism and emotional clarity.

8.2.1. Layout

Explanation: A well-planned layout of groups for related items highlights priority actions and creates a predictable flow that supports usability. It directly impacts visibility, navigation, and the user’s ability to complete tasks efficiently. Layout decisions also affect hierarchy and overall readability, ensuring that users can “scan” the interface naturally. In high-fidelity prototypes, layout choices are often tested to confirm they both support user goals and aesthetics.

How we incorporated it: The layout of the app is designed to guide users naturally through both emotional support and practical features. The welcome page presents essential actions such as login, sign-up, sidebar access, and emergency services in a clean, predictable arrangement that minimizes overwhelm. After logging in, the home page emphasizes supportive content such as daily affirmations, facts, and “Kinder Take” reflections, while sidebar navigation gives clear access to more features. Within the learn page, content is organized logically as the topic selection (e.g., Anxiety, Depression) appears first, followed by supportive text, calming images, reading material, and interactive breathing exercises. The bottom navigation bar, with the home icon on the left, SOS icon in the center, and profile icon on the right, ensures users can access core features consistently, while grouping related elements maintains clarity and intuitive flow.

8.2.2. Hierarchy

Explanation: Hierarchy includes functional ordering of elements to indicate importance and guide user attention. High-priority actions should be immediately noticeable, often through size, color, or placement. Visual hierarchy supports cognitive processing by helping users understand what to focus on first. It also reinforces usability principles like visibility and mapping, making the interface more intuitive. In prototypes, hierarchy is crucial for directing users to complete key tasks efficiently.

How we incorporated it: The SOS button is centrally positioned and visually emphasized to communicate urgency. Supportive messaging on the home page appears prominently above secondary content like daily facts and cognitive reflections. Sidebar menus and headings within the learn page, such as the topic titles, “You are not alone” message, are visually prioritized through size, placement, and spacing, while calming images accompany content without distracting it. This hierarchy reduces cognitive load and helps users navigate through the app confidently.

8.2.3. Color

Explanation: Proper contrast improves legibility and accessibility, while consistent color usage shows branding and usability. Color choices can influence user emotions and highlight system status. In high-fidelity prototypes, color must serve both aesthetic and functional purposes rather than decorative. Effective color use enhances clarity, hierarchy, and user engagement.

How did we incorporate it: HelpEra's color palette is chosen to promote emotional calm and tranquility, while yellow hue streaks add warmth and subtle visual interest. Sidebar images with low opacity, home page boxes, bottom navigation bars, and learn page visuals use complimentary soft colors to differentiate content without overwhelming the user. Color is also used functionally, such as toggle buttons and animations in the breathing exercise to use soft transitions to guide attention and promote relaxation.

8.2.4. Typography

Explanation: Typography affects readability, hierarchy, and the overall tone of the interface. Legible fonts, consistent sizes, and proper spacing make text easy to scan and understand. Typography also supports hierarchy by differentiating headings, subheadings, and body conte.t Poor typography can confuse users or make content difficult to read. In high-fidelity prototypes, typography choices should align with both brand identity and functional clarity.

How did we incorporate it: Typography is consistent and legible, supporting hierarchy, clarity, and user comfort. We used Inter for headings and ABeeZee for both headings and body text, ensuring a clean, modern feel. The Headings are larger and bold to establish hierarchy, while body text remains readable at a standard size. Across all screens, consistent font choice and size reinforce a cohesive and accessible interface.

8.2.5. Imagery and Copy

Explanation: Imagery and copy play a crucial role in conveying meaning, setting tone, and supporting navigation. Images can illustrate concepts, provide context, or create emotional connection, while copy ensures instructions, labels, and messaging are clear and concise. In prototypes, imagery and copy are tested to ensure they support the user experience rather than distract from it.

How did we incorporate it: Imagery and copy are intentionally used to create a calm and supportive experience. Serene environments are depicted in sidebar menus, learn pages, etc. to depict emotional safety. Copy is concise, empathetic, and instructional, from supportive phrases. Images are centered with sufficient spacing around text, ensuring readability and docus. Together, the visual and textual elements guide users gently, providing reassurance while maintaining clarity and engagement throughout the application.

9. Usability Heuristics

Following the expert review conducted by other teams, we analyzed HelpEra using Nielson's heuristics to identify both strengths and areas for improvement.

- **Visibility of System Status:** Reviewers highlighted that certain system responses, such as chatbot replies and emergency call actions, lacked clarity. In response, we improved feedback mechanisms by adding confirmation messages and clarifying emergency call-to-action wording. The SOS button was also standardized and visually emphasized to ensure users always know where to access urgent support.
- **Consistency and Standards:** Feedback indicated inconsistences in navigation across screens. To address this, we implemented a fixed bottom navigation bar (Home, SOS, Profile) visible across all primary screens. Button styles, spacing, and layout structure were applied to reduce confusion and promote predictability.
- **Error Prevention:** High-severity feedback pointed out the absence of visible input validation during login and sign-up. We introduced real-time email

validation, password strength requirements, and logout confirmation dialogs to prevent user errors before they occur.

- **Recognition Rather Than Recall:** Reviewers noted that users could not easily track previous moods and had to rely on memory. We resolved this by incorporating mood history and progress tracking within the journal section, allowing users to visually review past entries instead of recalling them.
- **Flexibility and Efficiency of Use:** The professional search filters were initially overwhelming. To improve usability, we introduced suggested professionals by default and clearer filter categories (therapy style, specialization etc.), allowing both new and experienced users to navigate efficiently.
- **Aesthetic and Minimalist Design & Accessibility:** Concerns about low contrast and limited visual hierarchy were addressed by refining typography, spacing, and color contrast. The purple background with warm yellow accents was balanced with clear text contrast to improve readability while maintaining emotional calmness.
- **User control and Freedom:** Features such as Private Mode, optional journal sharing with professionals, and logout confirmation dialogs reinforce user autonomy. Users can choose their level of anonymity and revoke permissions at any time, strengthening trust and safety.

By systematically applying Nielsen's heuristics to the feedback received, we refined HelpEra into a more consistent, accessible, and emotionally supportive high-fidelity prototype. The revisions demonstrate how heuristic evaluation guided practical design improvements, reducing usability risk and ensuring the app better supports users experiencing mental health challenges.

10. Wireframing

Before developing the high-fidelity protype in Figma, we created a low-fidelity wireframe using Balsamiq Wireframes software. This allowed us to plan the app's structure, layout, and user flow without being distracted by color, fonts, or detailed visuals. Wireframing helped us map essential features such as sidebar navigation, learning modules, community chats, journaling pages, and profile pages in a logical order. It also made it easy to test and iterate on positioning, grouping, and hierarchy of content early in the design process. By establishing the framework with wireframes first, we ensured a smoother transition into high-fidelity design while maintaining a focus on usability and accessibility.

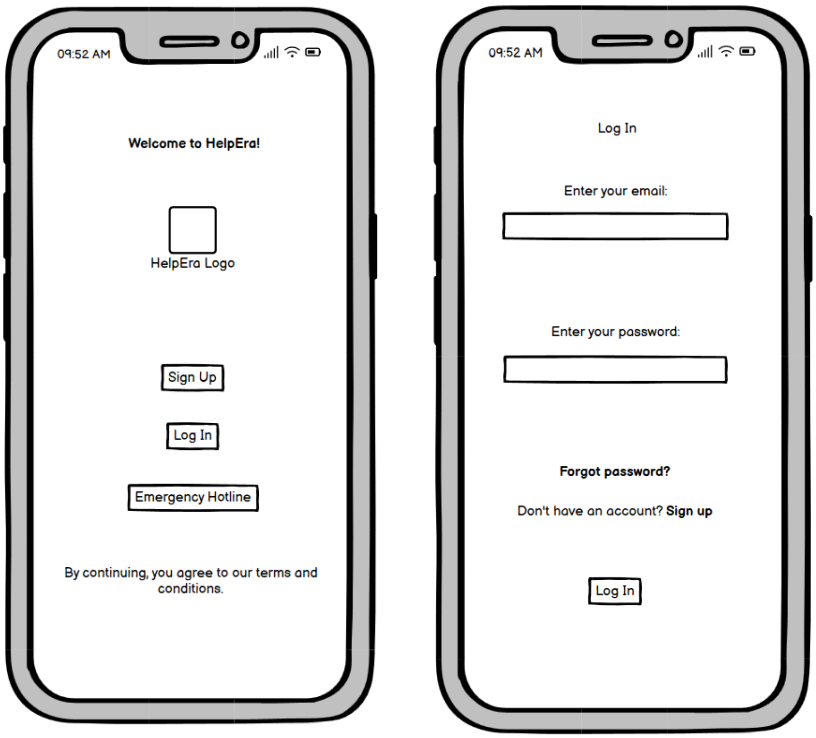


Figure 23: Wireframe Prototype (a)

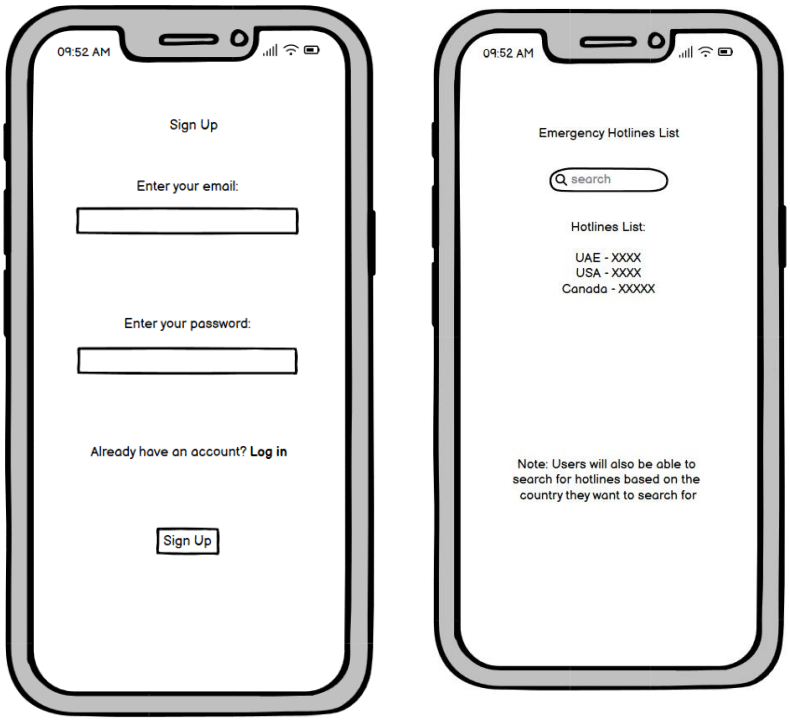


Figure 24: Wireframe Prototype (b)

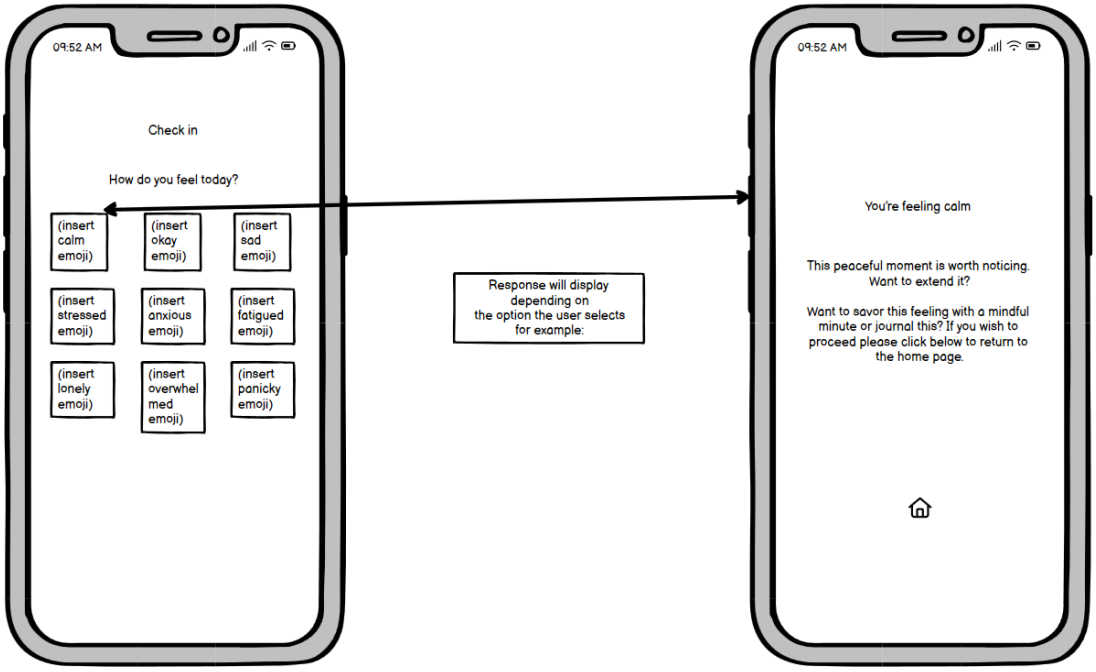


Figure 25: Wireframe Prototype (c)

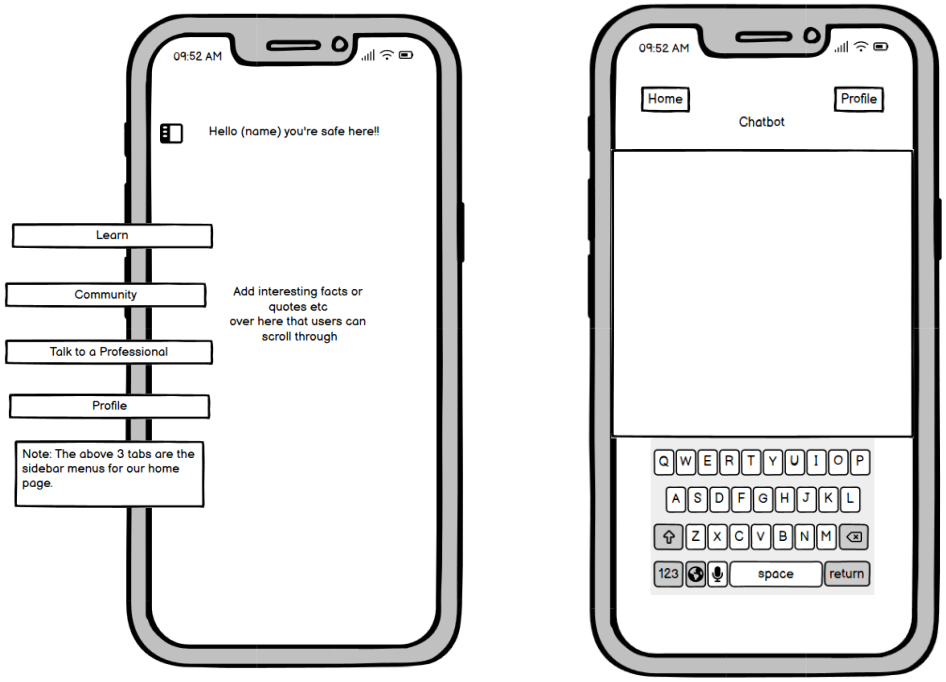


Figure 26: Wireframe Prototype (d)

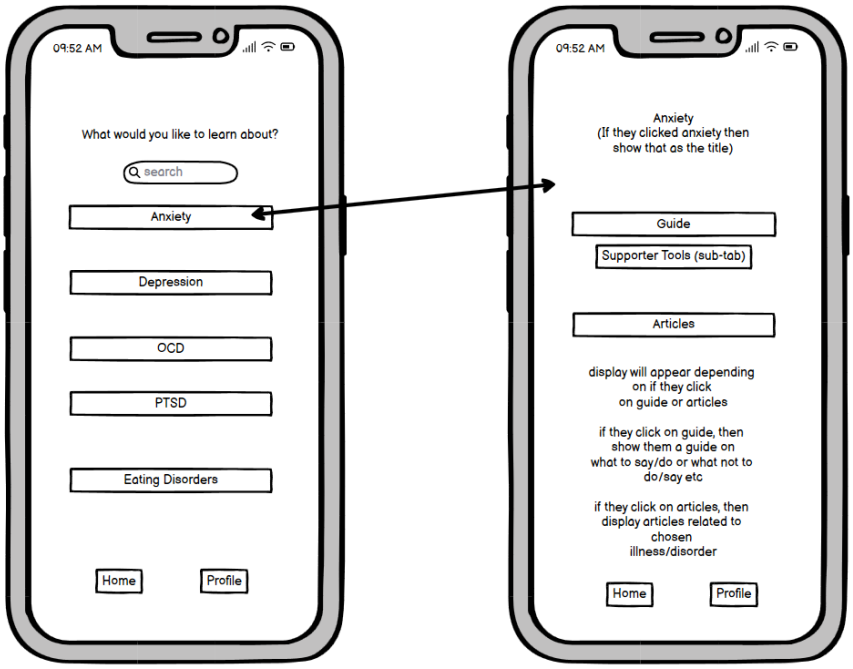


Figure 27: Wireframe Prototype (e)

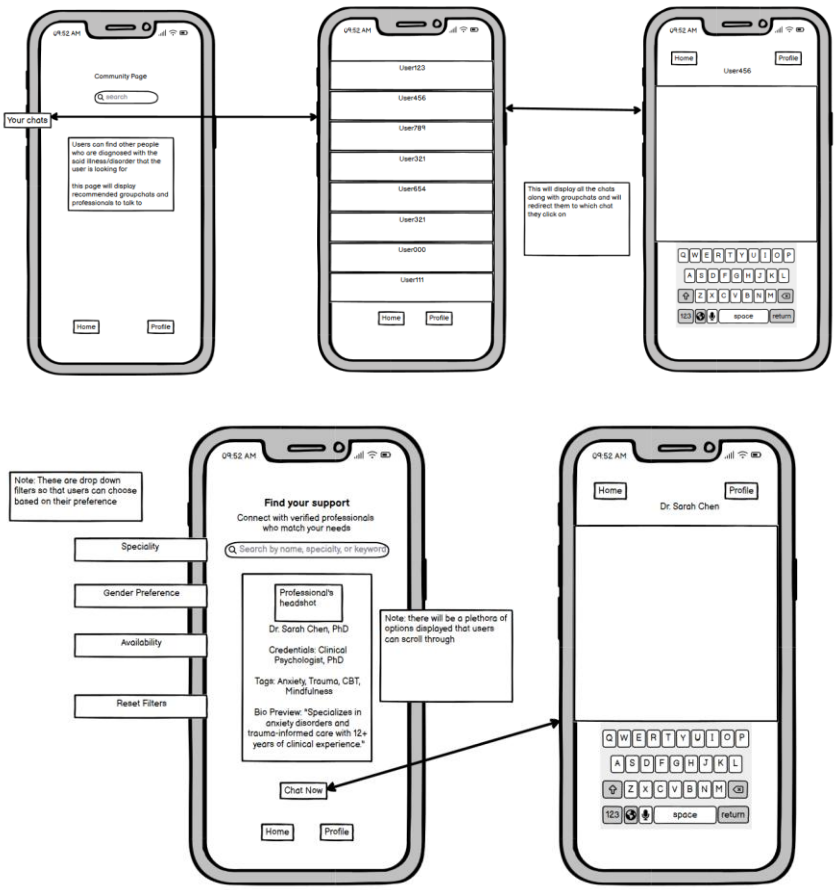


Figure 28: Wireframe Prototype (f)

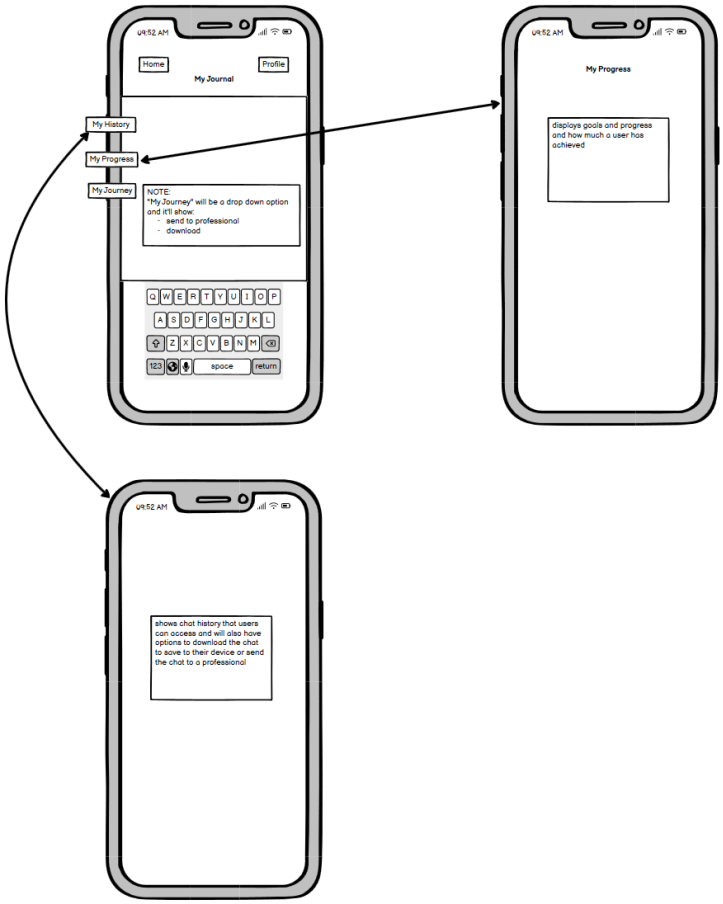


Figure 29:Wireframe Prototype (g)

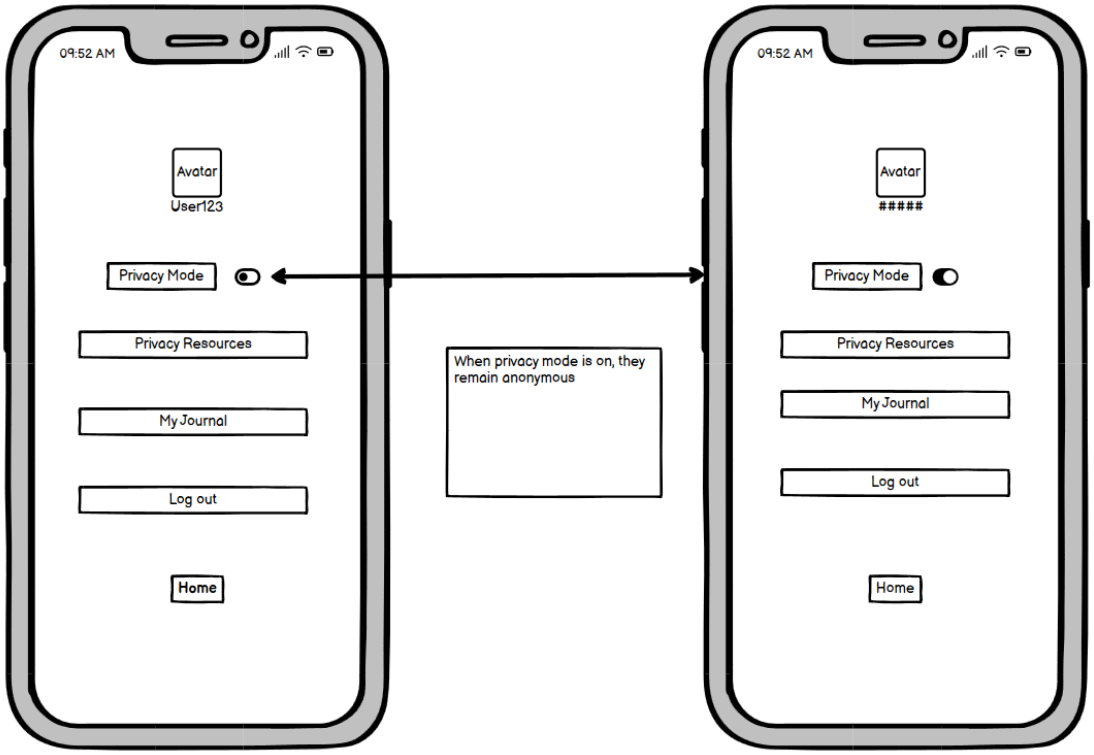


Figure 30:Wireframe Prototype (h)

11. Low-Fidelity Prototype

11.1. Design Process Description and Implementation

Our design process began with user research and functional requirements, which were gathered from previous findings, such as identified pain points and use cases. We mapped out core user journeys such as accessing emergency resources and tracking wellbeing etc.

We created a low fidelity prototype using Balsamiq, which allowed us to quickly visualize the app structure and user flows without focusing on visual design details.

The main screens that we designed are:

- **Startup page, Login, and Sign-up pages:** Streamlining initial access
- **Emergency hotline page:** Enabling country-based search for crisis support
- **Check-in page:** For daily wellbeing tracking
- **Learn page:** With categorized mental health information
- **Disorder-specific guide pages:** Offering tools and support resources
- **Community page:** Facilitating user connections with professionals and other people who are also struggling.
- **Chatbot page:** For immediate support when offline
- **Journal track page:** For personal reflection
- **Profile page:** For user customization

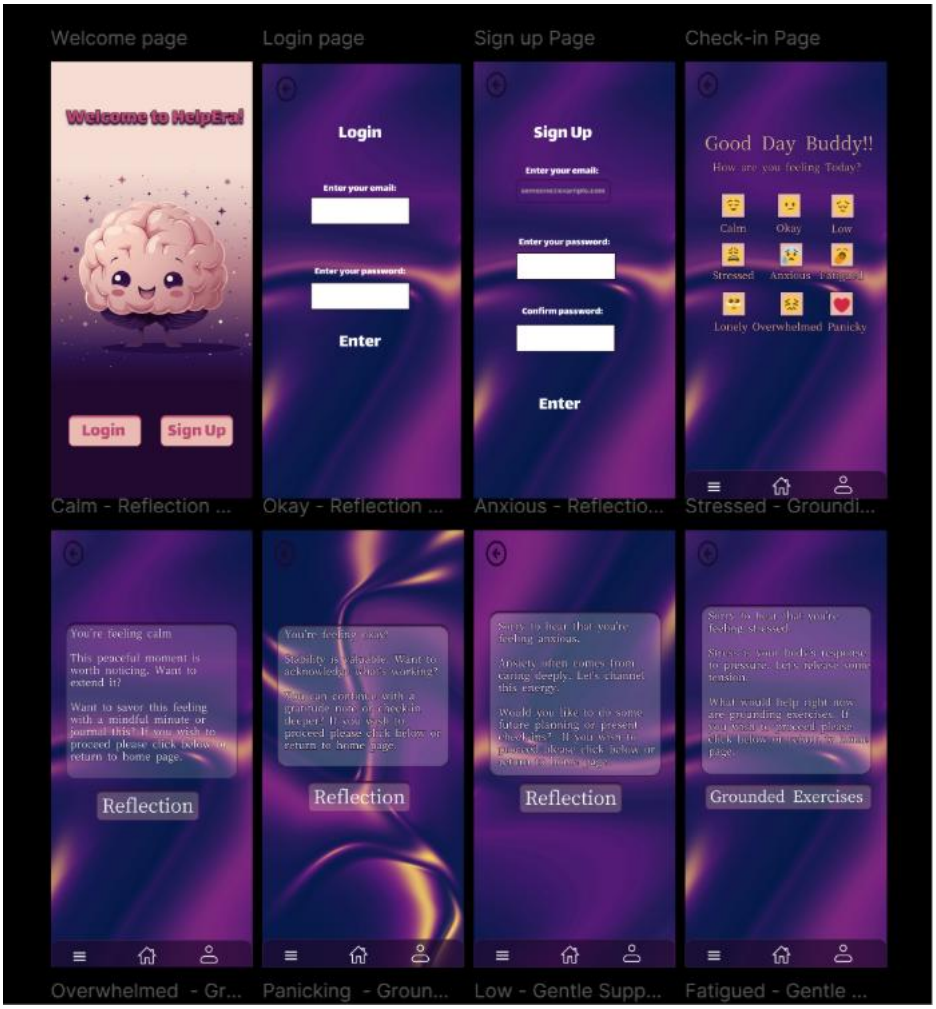


Figure 31: Design Process (a)

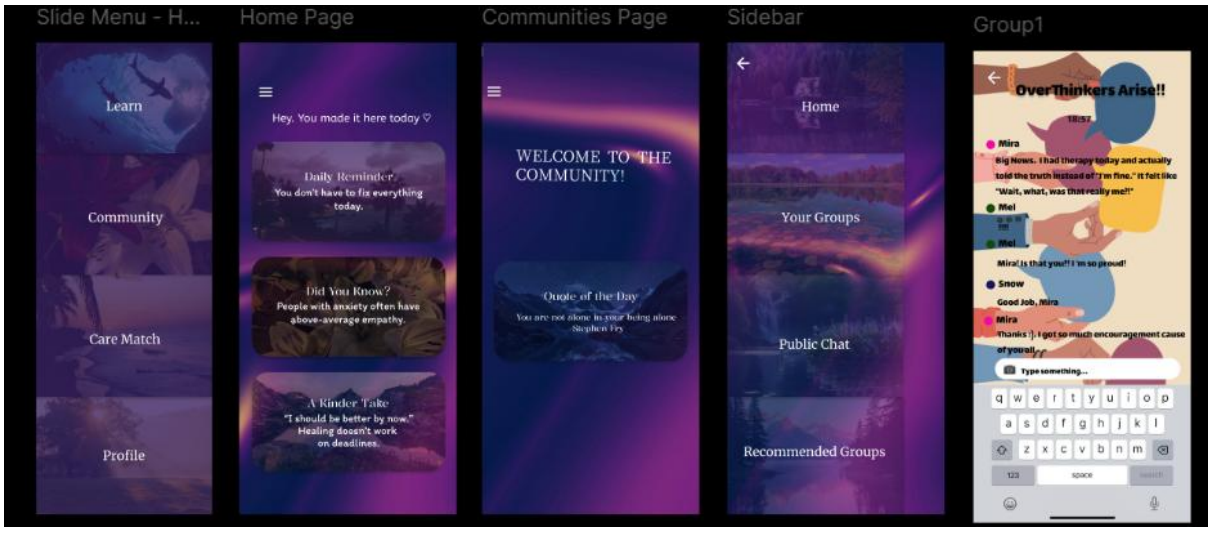


Figure 32: Design Process (b)

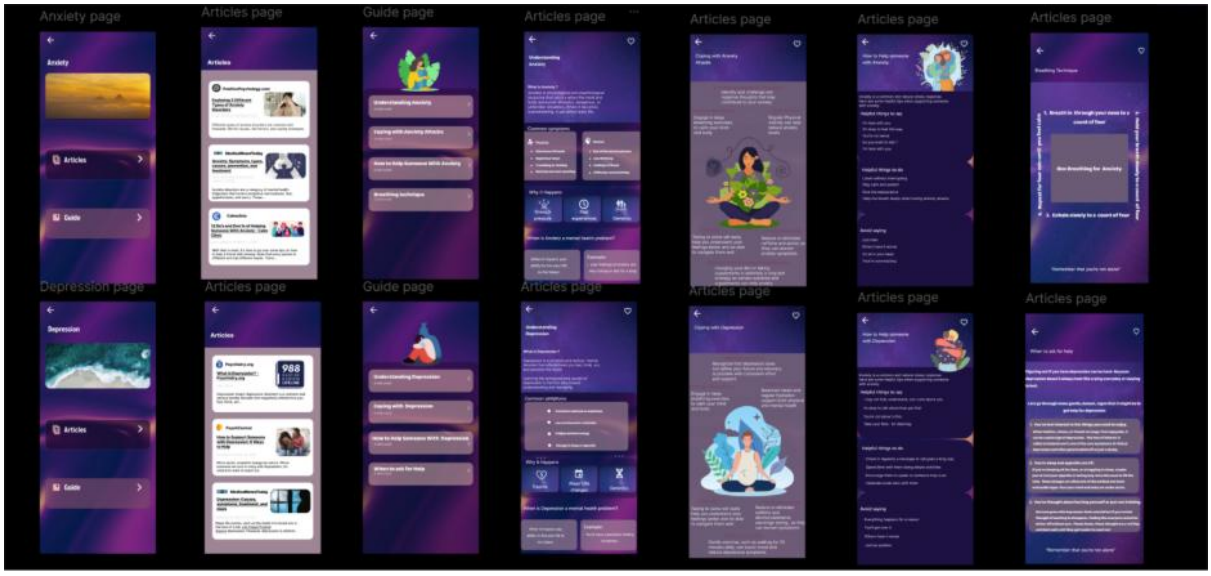


Figure 33: Design Process (c)

11.2. Feedback & Iteration

Since our prototype is in the early low fidelity stage, we focused on internal and peer feedback to refine the structure and flow before external user testing. Feedback was gathered through:

- **Team design reviews:** Regular check ins where each member reviewed wireframes and suggested improvements.
- **Walkthroughs with other students not in our team:** To simulate a first-time user's perspective.
- **Guided navigation tasks:** Asking teammates to complete specific tasks (e.g., "Find the hotline for UAE") to test intuitiveness.

11.3. Feed Received & How we Incorporated it

1. Feedback: "The emergency hotline search felt hidden." **Change:** We moved the hotline access to a prominent button on the startup screen and added a search bar button as well for efficient use.

2. Feedback: "The learn page felt overwhelming with too many categories at once." **Change:** We introduced expandable sections per disorder category to keep content accessible.

3. Feedback: "Journaling can feel repetitive when users need to recount their experiences to a mental health professional, leading to emotional exhaustion." **Change:** We added a secure 'Send to Professional' button in the journal, allowing users to share entries directly. This is complemented by a goal-tracking system and a visual progress dashboard, creating a cohesive loop between self-reflection and professional support.

4. Feedback: "Some testers had trouble switching between the 'Community' and 'Chabot' as they expected the chatbot to be inside the Community tab. **Change:** We made the chatbot access more prominent by placing it in the profile page as users can use the chatbot for when professionals aren't available as the user is offline.

12. Expert Review

12.1. Performing Expert Review

To evaluate the usability of HelpEra, we conducted an expert review where multiple teams assessed our application using Nielson's usability heuristics and general UX best practices. The reviewers identified several strengths, particularly in areas such as visibility of system status, user control and freedom, and match between the system and the real world. For example, the emergency hotline feature, anonymous mode, and structured learning categories were praised for aligning with user needs in stressful situations. The step-by-step check in flow and supportive messaging were also highlighted as effective in guiding users through emotional reflection.

However, the review also revealed important weaknesses. Key concerns included lack of visible input validation during login and sign-up, insufficient system feedback in the chatbot, low contrast and limited visual hierarchy, and absence of mood history tracking. Reviewers also recommend adding safety layers within the community and chatbot features including disclaimers.

12.2. Revision Post Feedback

12.2.1. Team Deadline Survivors

Following the expert review conducted by team Deadline Survivors, several refinements were made to improve consistency, clarity, and accessibility within HelpEra. To address navigation inconsistencies, we standardized the bottom navigation bar across all the pages, ensuring home, SOS, and profile remain fixed and visually consistent. In response to concerns about error prevention, we introduced confirmation dialogs and strengthened input validation in login and sign-up screens, including password requirements and real-time feedback prompts.

Accessibility concerns regarding low contrast and limited visual hierarchy were addressed by refining spacing, increasing contrast ratios, and strengthening heading differentiation. Additionally, professional search filters were simplified by introducing suggestion professionals by default, reducing cognitive load for first-time users. (Refer to Appendix C for more information.)

12.2.2. Team Softmint Engineers

Based on the feedback from team Softmint Engineers, we implemented improvements related to error prevention, minimalist design, and system status visibility. High-severity concerns regarding login and sign-up validation were addressed by incorporating real-time email verification and a password strength indicator to prevent user mistakes. This directly strengthens error prevention and enhances user confidence during account creation.

To reduce emotional, overwhelm on the check-in page, symptom selection was reorganized into clearer categories and structured in a more progressive format, minimizing cognitive load. Chatbot interaction was improved by introducing clearl system response indicators to reassure users that their input is being processed. (Refer to Appendix C for more information.)

12.2.3. Team Talon

Following the review report from team Talon, we focused on improving emergency clarity, navigation consistency, and safety features. To address concerns regarding inconsistent navigation and unclear labeling, we reinforced one bottom navigation system visible across all the pages. The emergency hotline section was redesigned to include clearer call-to-action messaging and more explicit emergency instructions to eliminate confusion during crisis.

In response to feedback regarding privacy and safety expectations within the chatbot and community features, we incorporated clearly privacy explanations. This includes outlining expectations, reinforcing anonymity controls, and ensuring that users understand their level of control. These strengthen user control and freedom while maintaining a safe and supportive environment. (Refer to Appendix C for more information.)

12.2.4. Team BobTheBuilders

The final expert review highlighted opportunities to enhance flexibility, personalization, and system transparency. To improve flexibility and efficiency of use, we refined the chatbot experience by structuring responses more dynamically and clarifying expectations of its functionality. We also expanded the mood tracking system to include history tracking, allowing users to view previous emotional check-ins and progress over time.

To address the “too low fidelity” critique, we significantly enhanced the visual quality of the prototype in Figma by incorporating consistent typography, calming imagery, consistent spacing, and refined interface components. Furthermore, we clarified pathways for users seeking help for themselves versus others by making support flows more explicit. These revisions improved system visibility, user confidence, and overall professional polish of the high-fidelity prototype. (Refer to Appendix C for more information.)

13. High-Fidelity Prototype

The final high-fidelity prototype of HelpEra was developed in Figma as a fully interactive and visually refined version of the application. This version builds upon our wireframes and integrates all revisions from expert feedback, ensuring consistency, accessibility, and emotional sensitivity. The prototype includes fully designed flows for onboarding, login and sign-up, home navigation, learning modules, community interaction, professional matching, journaling, emergency, and profile access.

Overall, the high-fidelity prototype reflects a cohesive integration of Norman's principles, Nielsen's heuristics, and our core UX goals: emotional safety, accessibility, clarity, and supportive guidance.



Figure 34: High-fidelity Prototype (a)

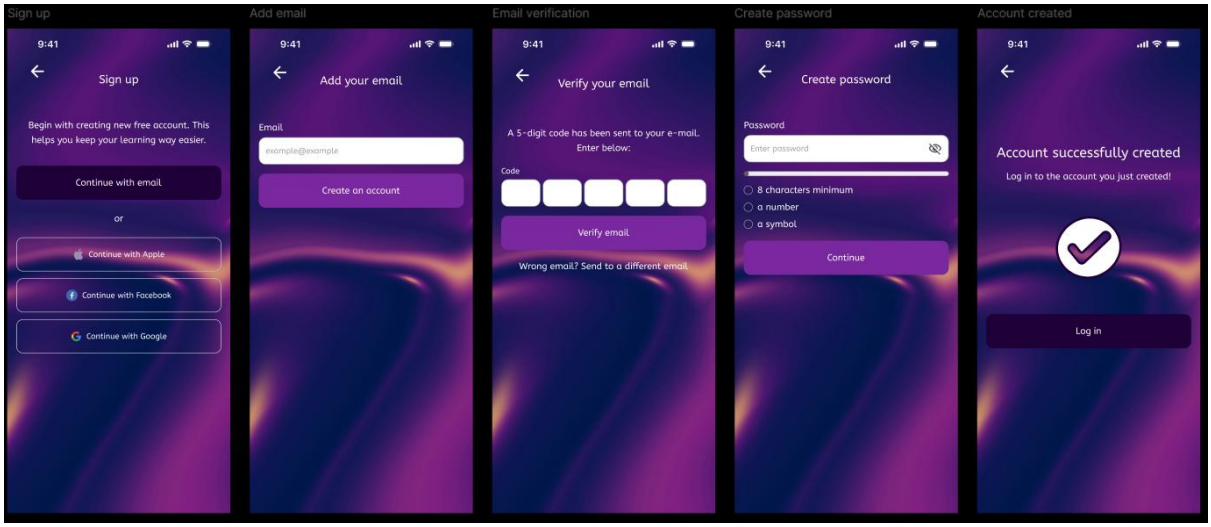


Figure 35: High-fidelity Prototype (b)

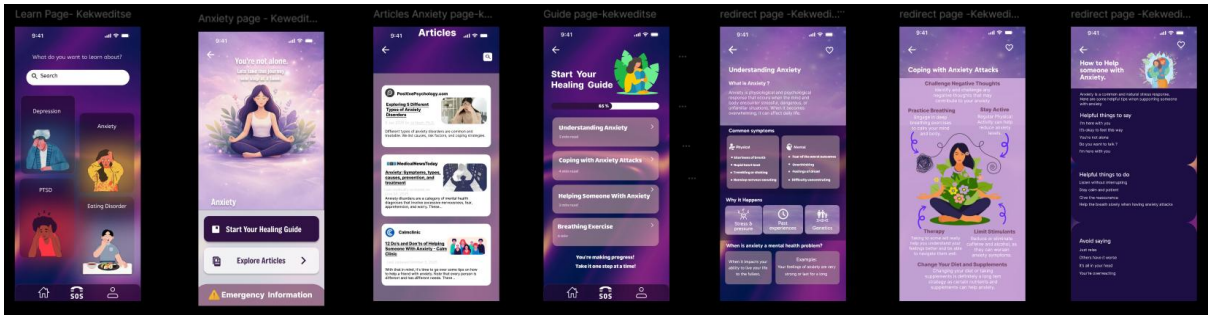


Figure 36: High-fidelity Prototype (c)

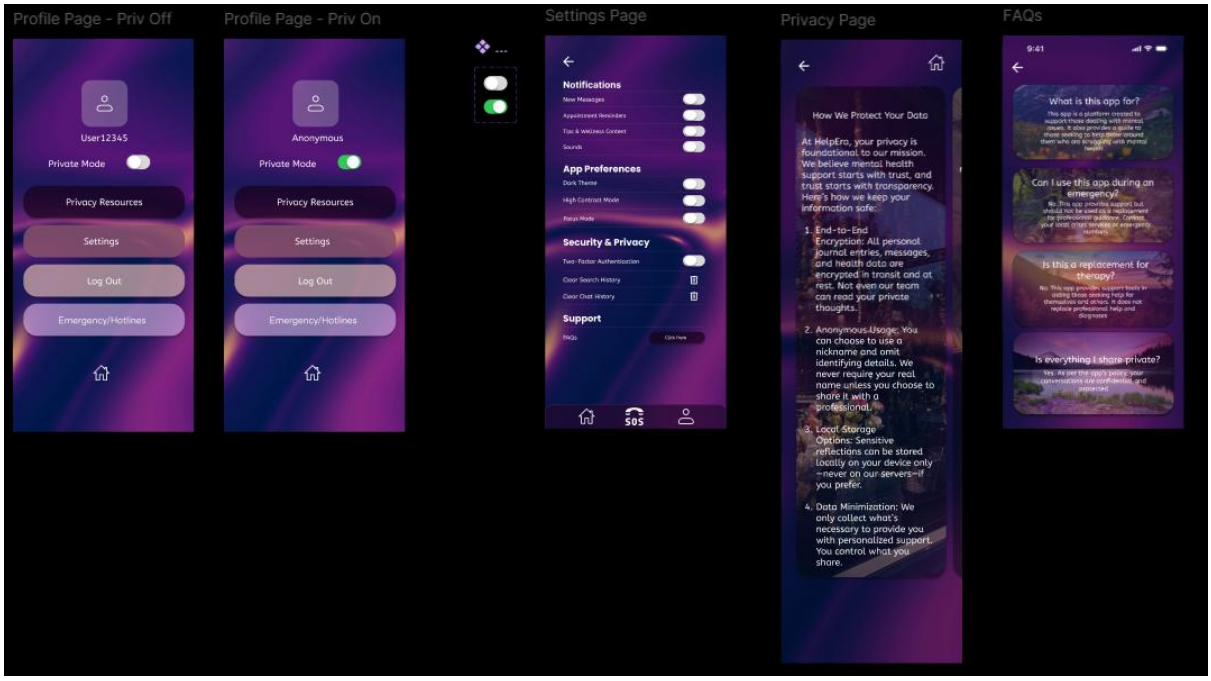


Figure 37: High-fidelity Prototype (d)

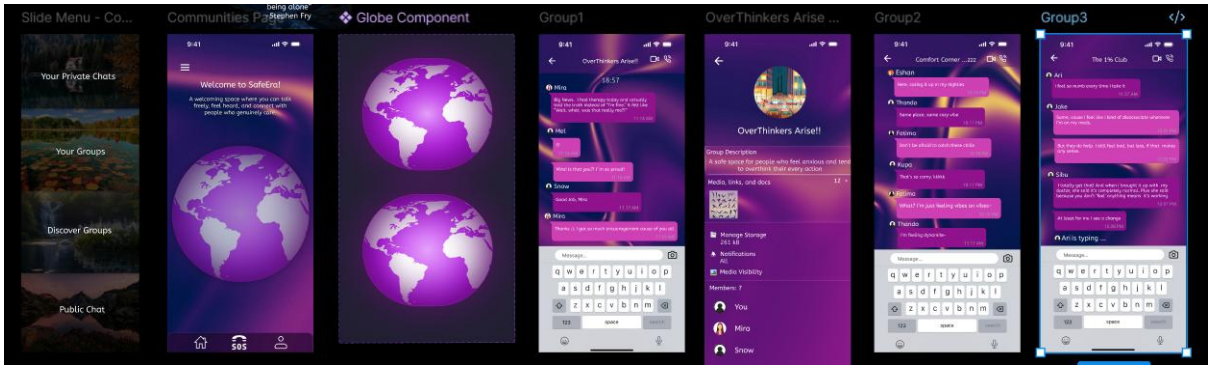


Figure 38: High-fidelity Prototype (e)

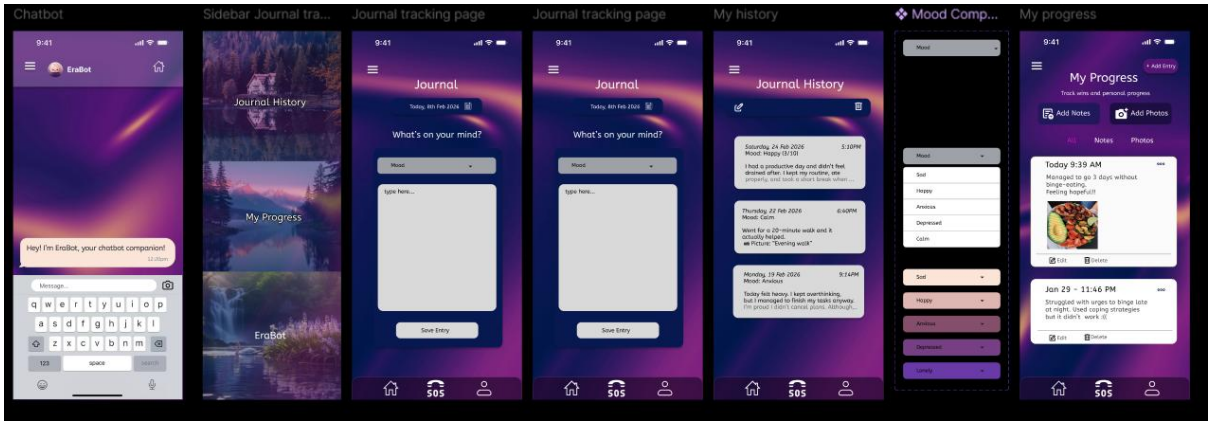


Figure 39: High-fidelity Prototype (f)

13.1. Design Specifications for Handoff

To ensure consistency and scalability, a simple style guide was developed for HelpEra to support design-to development handoff.

Primary Colors:

- **Primary Background:** Deep calming purple to promote calmness and emotional safety.
- **Accent Highlight:** Soft yellow hue streaks to add warmth.
- **Neutral Colors:** White for text backgrounds and content sections for readability.

Typography:

- **Headings:** Inter
- **Primary Body Font:** AbeeZee

Button Styles:

- **Primary Buttons:** Rounded corners, solid purple background, white text
- **Secondary Buttons:** Outlined style with purple border and transparent background.
- **Emergency Button (SOS):** Purple background with high contrast white outlined icon.

- Confirmation Buttons: Filled with white colour background, black text, and rounded corners for clarity.

Icons:

- Home icon (Bottom left navigation)
- SOS icon (Center bottom navigation)
- Profile icon (Bottom right navigation)
- Search icon (Used in learn and professional pages)
- Filter icon (Professional matching section)

Imagery Guidelines:

- Use calming, nature-based imagery (sea, flowers, meditation scenes).
- Images should be soft-toned and emotionally neutral to avoid triggering content.
- Maintain consistent image placement (centered with spacing above and below).

Spacing and Layout Rules:

- Consistent margins across all screens.
- Clear vertical spacing between content sections.
- Centered alignment for reflective and emotional content.
- Fixed bottom navigation across all primary images.

14. Project Management

14.1. Meetings and Communication

Team UXplorers maintained regular communication throughout the project lifecycle using multiple synchronous and asynchronous channels.

Synchronous Meetings:

- Weekly tutorial sessions (Tuesdays 9:00 AM to 11:00 AM) with Ms. Shahra.
- Additional team meetings via Microsoft Teams for focused collaboration.
- Design thinking workshops conducted in FigJam during scheduled sessions.

Asynchronous Meetings:

- WhatsApp group chat for quick coordination and updates.
- Collaborative document editing in Shared OneDrive Folder and MS Word.
- Figma comments for design-specific feedback.

Meeting minutes were documented for all formal sessions using Toggle, capturing decisions made, tasks assigned, and deadlines established.

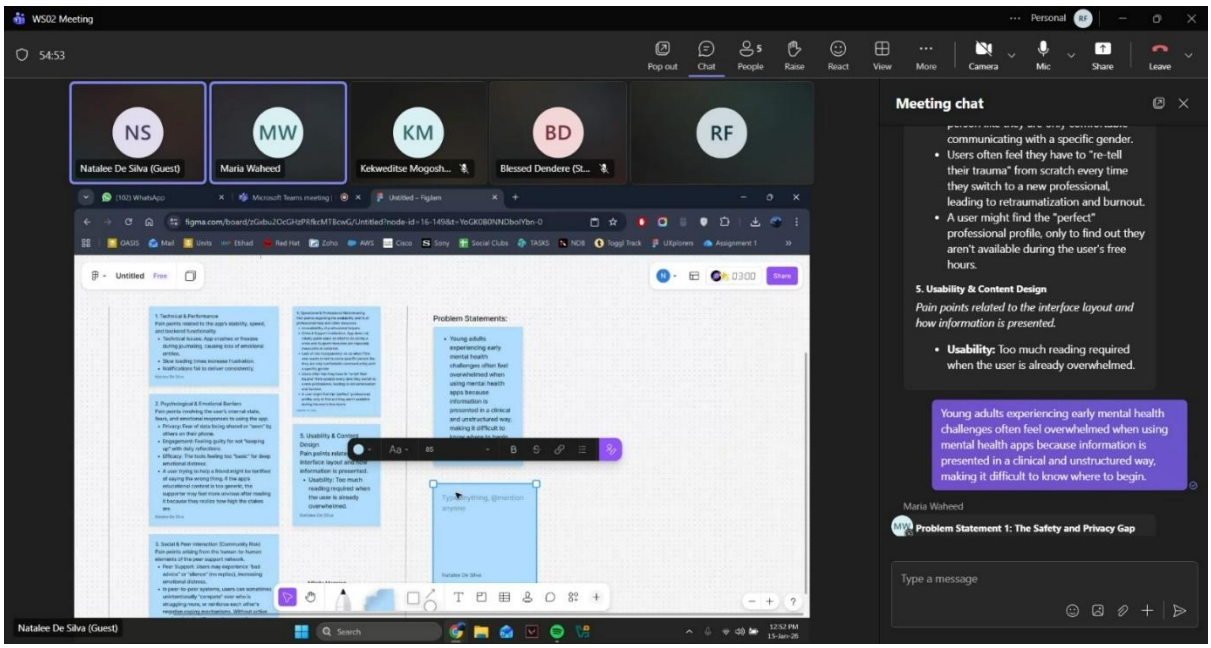


Figure 40: MS Teams Meeting

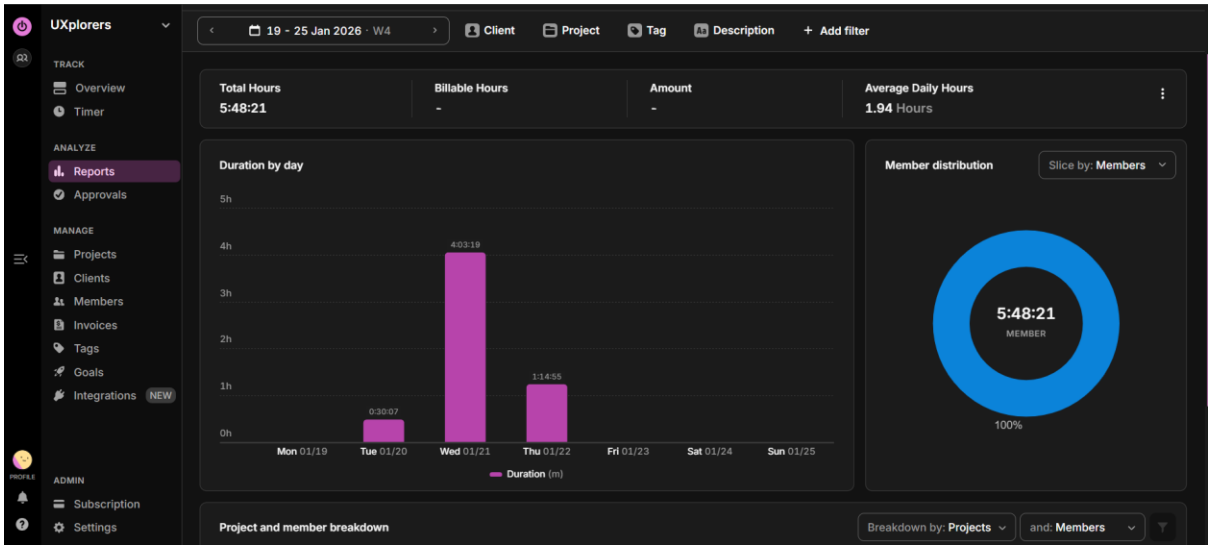


Figure 41: Toggl Screenshot

14.2. Task Tracking and Time Management

The team utilized a Kanban board (as detailed in Section 4) to visualize workflow and track progress against milestones. Individual time tracking was implemented using Toggl to ensure equitable contribution and provide evidence of effort expended (in Appendix D, E, F)

14.3. Risk Management

The following risks were identified and managed during the project:

Risk	Likelihood	Impact	Mitigation Strategy
Team member unavailability	Medium	High	Cross training on tasks, regular check-ins, clear documentation
Sensitive topic management	Medium	Medium	Respectful language protocols, content warnings, ethical research practices
Scope creep	High	Medium	Regular milestone reviews, PM oversight, feature prioritization
Inconsistent participation	Low	High	Clear role allocation, meeting minutes,

			contribution tracking
Technical difficulties with Figma	Low	Medium	Early exploration, version control, regular exports

Table 6: Risk Management

14.4. Milestones Achieved

Milestone	Description	Target Date	Completion Date
Project Setup	Roles assigned and Kanban board created	15/01/2026	15/01/2026
User Research Complete	Personas, pain points, affinity mapping finalized	15/01/2026	15/01/2026
Design Ideation Compete	HMW statements and ideated solutions grouped	15/01/2026	15/01/2026
Prototype Development	Low-fidelity prototype created and reviewed	18/01/2026	18/01/2026
Evaluation Complete	Expert review and revisions finalized	30/01/2026	15/02/2026
High-Fidelity Prototype and Handoff	Hi-fi prototype and style guide ready	20/02/2026	
Final Report Submission	Complete report submitted	23/02/2026	

Table 7: Milestones Achieved

14.5. Problems Encountered

Problem	Impact	Resolution
Initial survey response low	Delayed user research	Extended collection period, targeted outreach
Feedback on emergency hotline visibility	Usability concern	Moved hotline to prominent startup screen position
Navigation confusion between Community and Chatbot	User confusion	Relocated chatbot to profile page for clarity
Expert review feedback on other teams app	Learning opportunity	Applied heuristic proactively to our own design

14.6. Collaboration Tools

The team leveraged the following tools to support collaboration and documentation:

1) **Figma/FigJam:** Design thinking workshops, prototyping, persona development
2) **Microsoft Teams:** Synchronous meetings, file sharing, chat
3) **OneDrive Folder:** Collaborative document editing and sharing
4) **Balsamiq:** Low-fidelity wireframing
5) **WhatsApp:** Rapid asynchronous communication
6) **Toggle:** Time tracking and meeting minutes

15. Optional: Development Technology Stack

While HelpEra is currently a design concept, if developed into a fully functional application, the following technology stack would be recommended:

15.1. Frontend Development

Flutter (by Google) is proposed as the frontend framework. As a cross-platform development tool, Flutter enables simultaneous deployment on both iOS and Android platforms from a single codebase, significantly reducing development time and maintenance overhead. Flutter's widget-based architecture supports the creation of custom, visually consistent UI components that align with our design specifications (Flutter, n.d.).

15.2. Backend Infrastructure

Firebase is recommended for backend development due to its comprehensive suite of services:

- **Authentication**: Secure user sign-up, login, and account management with support for multiple authentication providers.
- **Cloud Functions**: Serverless compute for handling complex operations like professional matching algorithms.
- **Cloud Firestore**: Scalable, real-time NoSQL database for storing user data, journal entries, and professional directories.
- **Cloud Storage**: Secure storage for user-generated content.

Firebase's built-in security features, including data encryption and configurable security rules, align with the privacy requirements essential to mental health applications ("Cloud Functions for Firebase | Run Backend Code without Managing Servers" 2024).

15.3. Data Security and Privacy

Given the sensitive nature of the mental health data, the following security measures would be implemented:

- AES-256 encryption for all personal mental health data at rest (Kananda 2022).
- Granular user controls for data sharing.
- Anonymous authentication options where appropriate.
- TLS (Transport Layer Security) 1.3 for data in transit ("What Is Transport Layer Security (TLS)?," n.d.).
- Compliance with relevant regulations including GDPR and local data protection laws.

15.4. Design and Prototyping

As demonstrated throughout our project, Figma would continue to serve as the primary design tool, facilitating ongoing UI/UX refinement and developer handoff through features such as:

- Component libraries
- Developer handoff with code snippets and asset export
- Design system management
- Interactive prototyping

16. Conclusion

This report has documented the comprehensive user-centered design process undertaken by our Team UXplorers for our mental health support app “HelpEra”.

16.1. Project Summary

Beginning with user research involving surveys of the target demographic, the team developed a deep understanding of user need, pain points, and preferences. Key insights included the paramount importance of privacy and security, the need for accessible information that does not overwhelm users in distress, and the value of providing separate pathways for individuals seeking help and those supporting others.

These insights informed us of the development of two representative personas, which guided subsequent design decisions. Competitor analysis of TalkLife and 7 Cups revealed opportunities for differentiation, including enhanced safety systems, structured peer support, and dedicated supporter resources.

Through iterative design thinking workshops, the team identified core problem statements and generated How Might We questions that drove ideation. Solutions were grouped into themes including Gentle Guidance, Matchmaking and Continuity, Clear Support for into Others, Privacy and Trust, and Accessibility.

Functional and non-functional requirements were specified, and usability and UX goals were established to guide design execution. Low-fidelity prototyping in Balsamiq enabled rapid visualization and testing of core user flows, with feedback incorporated through team reviews and peer walkthroughs.

Expert review of a peer team’s application provided valuable learning about usability heuristics, which were proactively applied to HelpEra’s design. The final high-fidelity prototype, developed in Figma, embodies the team’s design principles and requirements specifications.

16.2. Key Outcomes

The HelpEra app's design delivers:

- Transparent privacy controls and data management.
- A secure, private platform for mental health self-management.
- Progressive support cards provide actionable guidance for friends and family.
- Dual pathways for individuals seeking help and supporters seeking guidance.
- Focus mode to reduce cognitive load for users experiencing overwhelm
- "My Journey" passport functionality to prevent trauma repetition during professional matching.

16.3. Next Steps

Given additional time and resources, the following next steps would be pursued:

1) **Accessibility Audit:**

   Comprehensive WCAG 2.1 compliance testing with assistive technologies (W3C 2025).

2) **Usability Testing:**

   Conduct formal testing with representative users to validate design assumptions and identify areas for improvement.

3) **Pilot Testing:**

   Deploy minimum viable product for controlled pilot testing with mental health professionals and support groups.

4) **Developer Handoff:**

   Prepare complete design specifications for development team.

5) **Iterative Refinement:**

   Incorporate usability testing findings into design iterations.

17. Acknowledgments

Team UXplorers wishes to express sincere gratitude to the following individuals and groups who contributed to the successful completion of this project:

- Ms. Shahra Jafar Ali, our tutor, for her guidance, feedback, and support throughout the design process, and for acting as our client representative.
- Teams BobTheBuilders, Deadline Survivors, Team Talon, and Softmint Engineers for providing us with their expert reviews for our low-fidelity prototype and for allowing us to review each of their applications as well, which provided valuable learning about usability heuristics.
- The anonymous survey participants who shared experiences and perspectives on mental health support, providing the foundational user insights that shaped HelpEra.
- Our fellow teams who participated in the walkthroughs provided feedback on the low-fidelity prototype.

18. References

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19. Glossary

Word	Definition
Accessibility	Designing products to be usable by people with a wide range of abilities, including those with disabilities, ensuring equal access and experience.
Affinity Mapping	A method used to group research findings into themes to identify patterns and insights.
Affordance	A design property that suggests how an object should be used or interacted.
Airbnb	An American founded global online marketplace that allows users to book short term stays in various countries and regions.
Anxiety	A metal health condition that causes excessive fear or worry that affects daily life. Often accompanied by a rapid heartbeat and muscle tension which can cause a shortness of breath.
Article Page	Users can access articles on mental health conditions
Breathing Exercise	A short exercise to regulate the user's emotional state in cases of heightened emotions
Cognitive Behavioural Therapy	A credible psychotherapy study on the changing patterns of negative thoughts.
Community Page	A feature that allows the user to interact with other users on the app
Check-In	A daily interaction by user to record their emotional state.
Cognitive Load	The mental effort required to process information; high cognitive load can make apps difficult to use when users are stressed or overwhelmed.
Crisis Mode	State of the app when the user's emotional state is critical

Deliveroo	A London-based food delivering service operating in 9 countries
Duolingo	A free educational app designed to learn languages through short daily lessons.
Depression	Mood disorder that causes a persistent feeling of sadness and loss of interest
Eating Disorder	A mental health disorder where ones' intake of food is influenced by their mood i.e. anorexia, bulimia and binge-eating.
Emergency/Hotline Contacts	Page providing list of emergency hotlines for distress calls
Guide Page	A page user can get a guide on how to tackle a mental health condition
How Might We (HMW) Statement	An open-ended question that reframes a problem into a design opportunity.
HTA	An evidence-based process used to determine the impact of health technologies on medical, social, economic and ethical fields.
Iterative Design	A process of continuously refining designs through testing and feedback.
Learning Rate	Rate of how much the user has learned in the guide page
Mood Tracking	User record of their emotional state over the course of time.
Notification	Alert from the app to prompt use engagement
Pain Points	A specific problem or frustration experienced by users when interacting with an application.
Persona	A fictional detailed representation of a target user based on research, which helps designers empathize with user needs, behaviours, and goals.
Post Traumatic Stress Disorder (PTSD)	A mental health condition caused by an extremely stressful or terrifying event.

Problem Statement	A concise description of a key user issue that the design aims to address.
Progressive Disclosure	An interactive design pattern to simplify applications and make them less error prone.
Uber	An American app-based transport company that provides ride-hailing services.
Usability	The degree to which the app can be used.
Use Case	A description of the interaction between the user and the application to reach a goal.
User Persona	Model of a target audience from real-world data
User Journey	The path followed by a user to use a feature.
User Story	A short, description of the app's desired functions from a user's perspective.
User Experience (UX)	The interactions a user has with a product or service.
Wireframe	A simplified blueprint to outline the team's requirements and shows the look and function of the product

Table 8: Glossary

20. Appendix

Appendix A: User Survey Responses

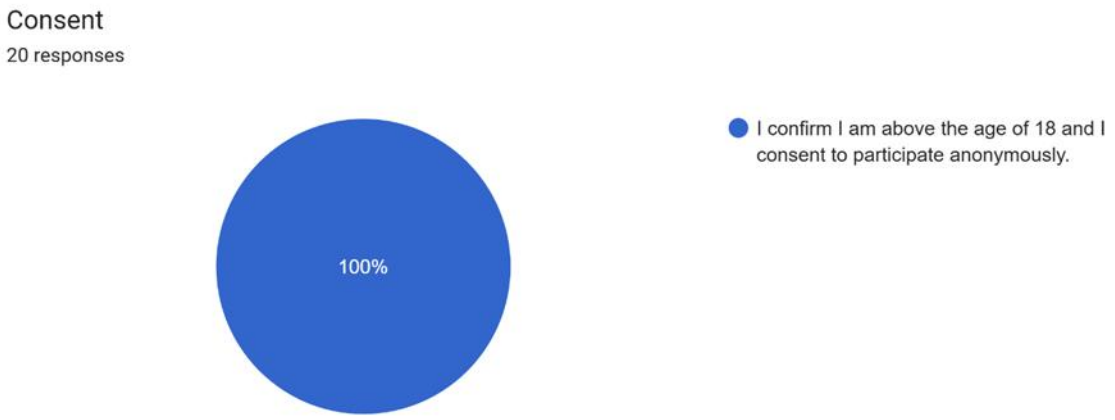


Figure 42: Survey Response (a)

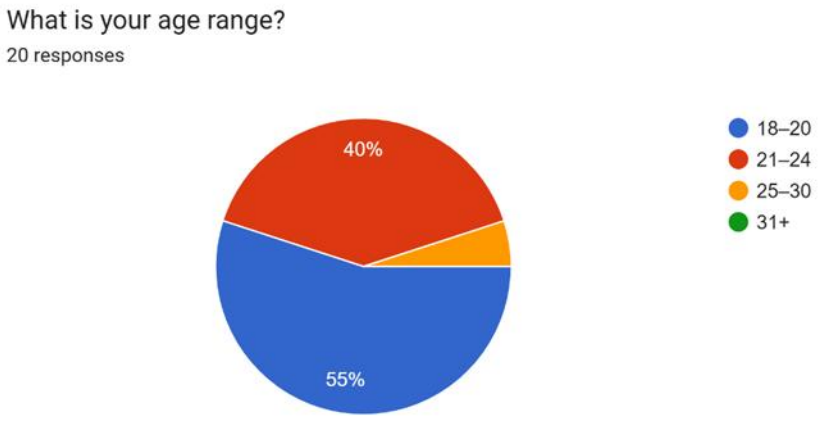


Figure 43: Survey Response (b)

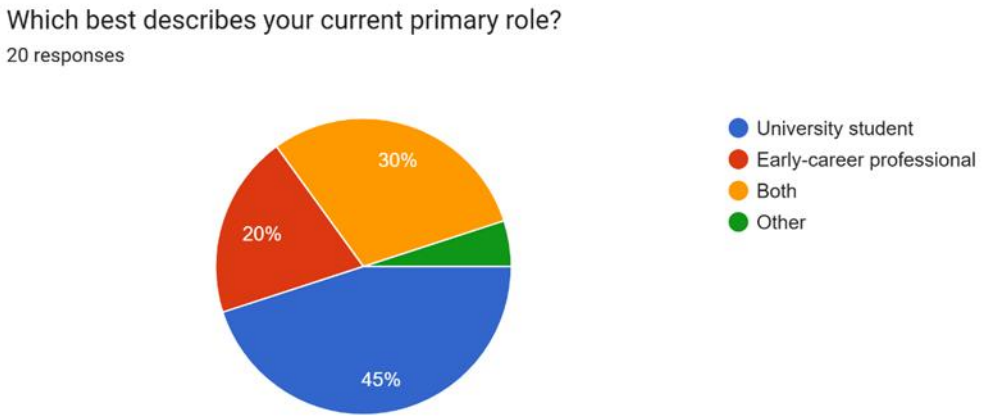


Figure 44: Survey Response (c)

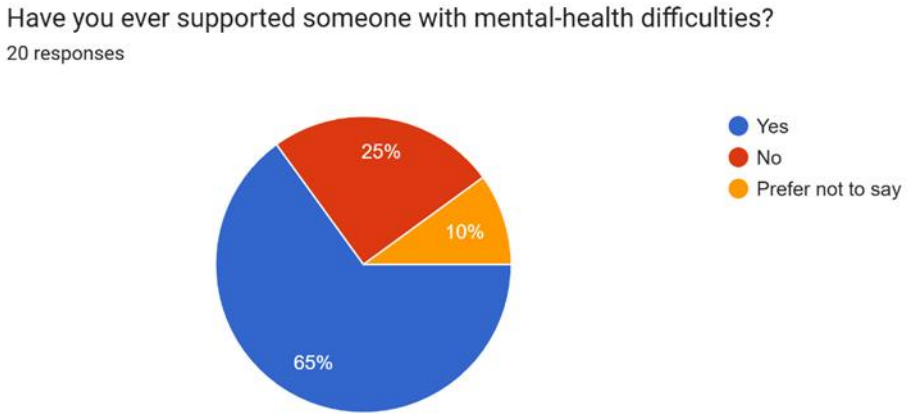


Figure 45: Survey Response (d)

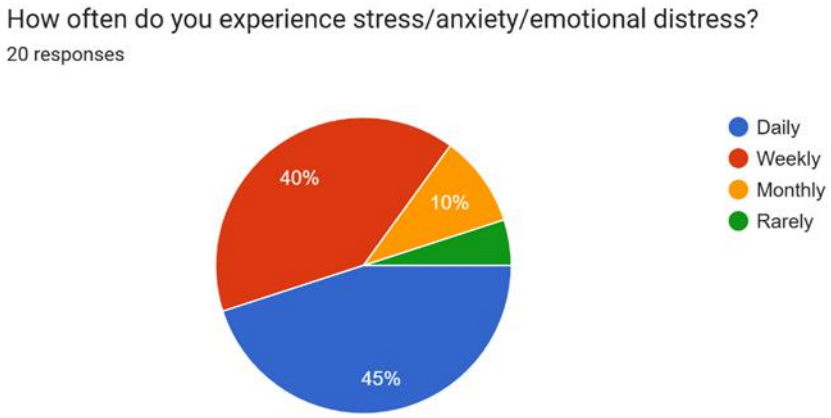


Figure 46: Survey Response (e)

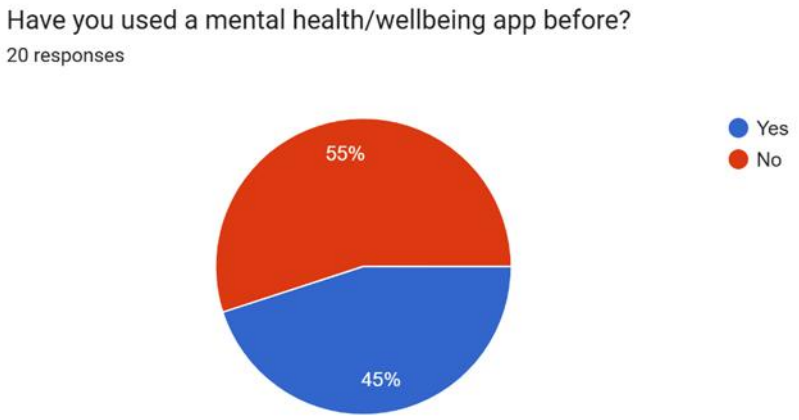


Figure 47: Survey Response (f)

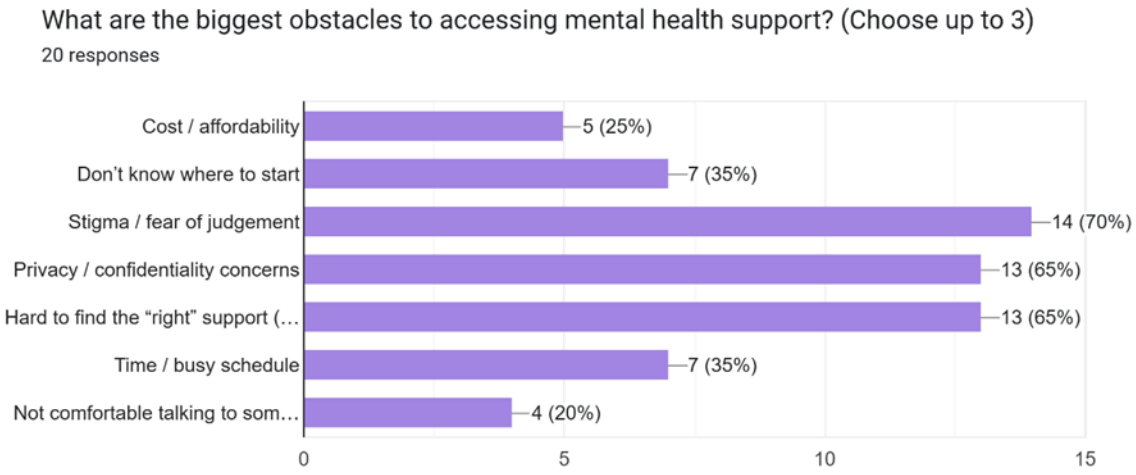


Figure 48: Survey Response (g)

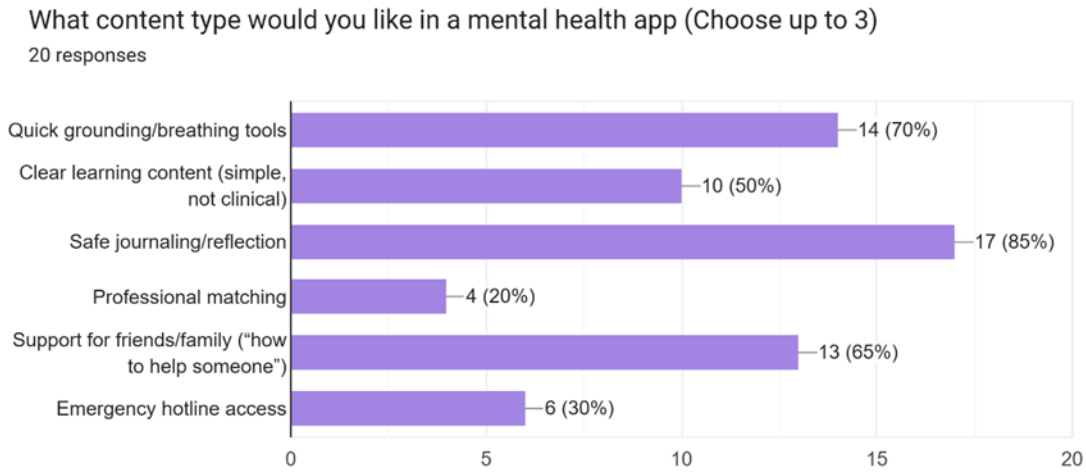


Figure 49: Survey Response (h)

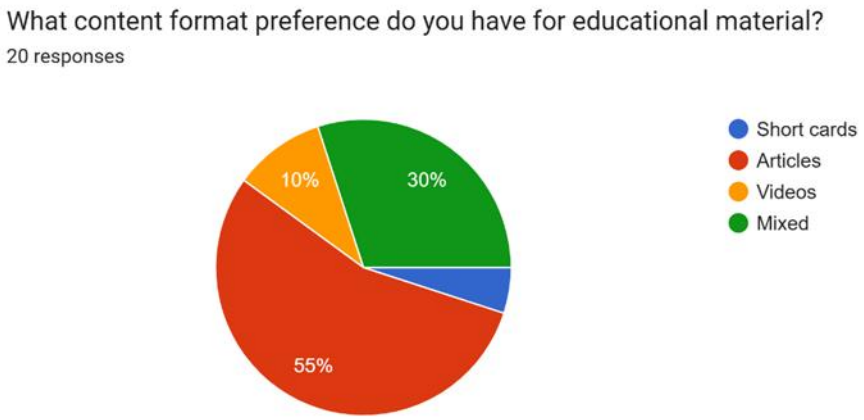


Figure 50: Survey Response (i)

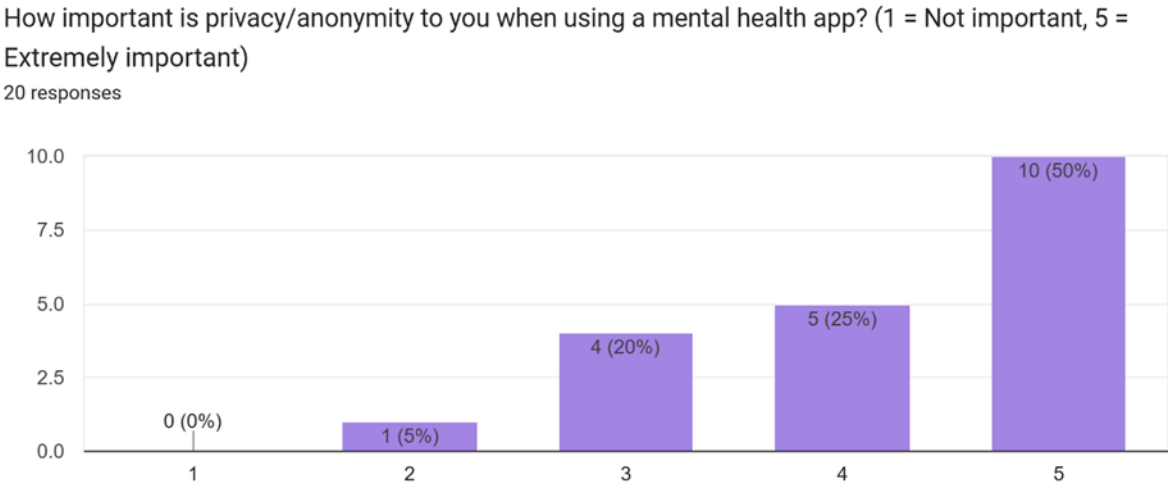


Figure 51: Survey Response (j)

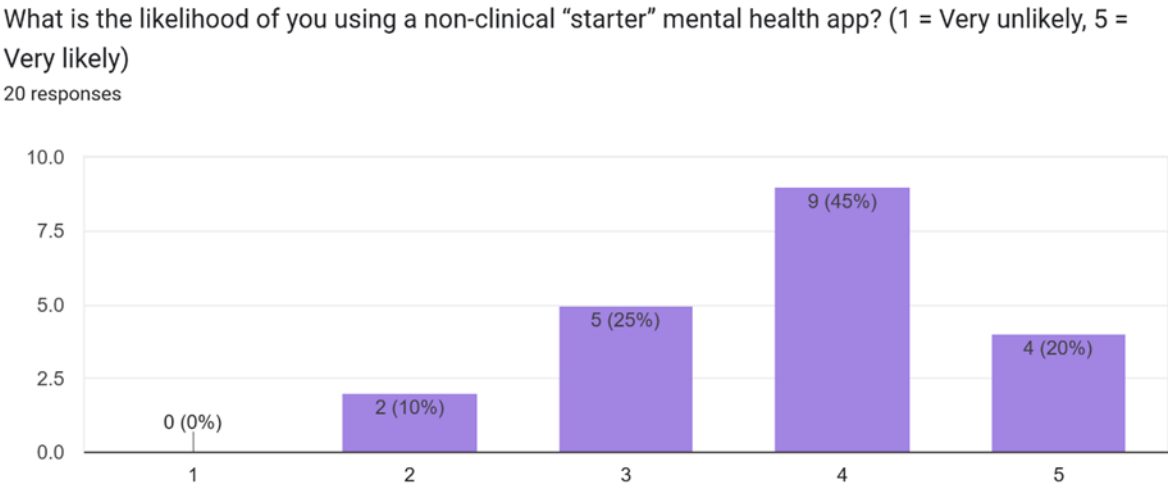


Figure 52: Survey Response (k)

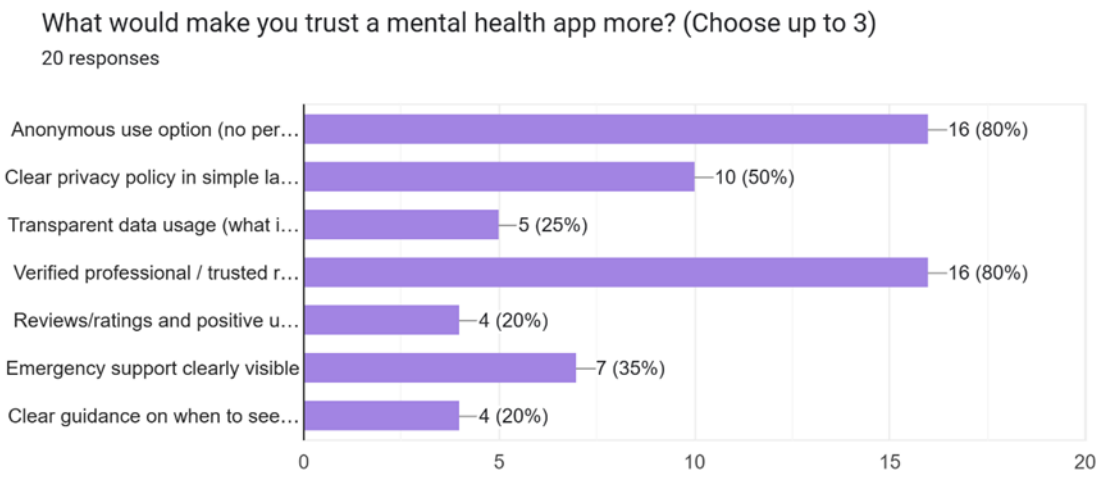


Figure 53: Survey Response (l)

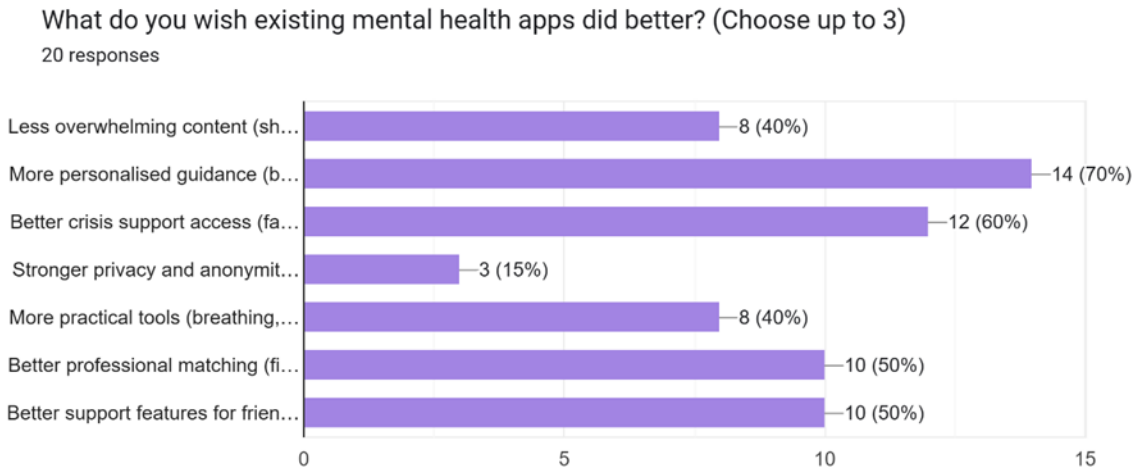


Figure 54: Survey Response (m)

Appendix B: Expert Review

Expert Review for Team BobTheBuilders' App "Helm"

Strengths

What type of heuristic is applicable?	Describe the issue you are reviewing	Severity	Recommendation	Best Practise Example
Usability Heuristics	Flexibility and Efficiency: The inclusion of an "Atlas" voice/hands-free mode is a sophisticated feature for users in high-activity environments (such as construction sites) where manual input is difficult.	Low	Maintain: Ensure the voice trigger "Hey Atlas" is clearly visible and easy to exit.	[1]
Visual Design Fundamentals	User Interface and Experience: The user interface and user experience are designed well, reflecting a minimalistic aesthetic that shows visual appeal and ease of use.	Med	Investigate: Add a loading state or a "Success" notification once the "Continue" button is pressed.	[2]
Other (Content/Social)	Diversity in Sharing Options: The design shows extra thought by allowing users	Low	Maintain: Keep the "Share" interface intuitive to encourage viral growth and collaboration.	[3]

	to share projects via contacts and email to people who are not currently using the app.			
Usability Heuristics	Consistency and Standards: The app follows a consistent layout structure with a similar top bar and bottom navigation pattern across different screens.	Low	Maintain: This improves usability as users don't have to relearn the navigation for every new screen.	[4]
Usability Heuristics	Export and Import Data: The ability to export and import data makes switching devices seamless, allowing users to pick up exactly where they left off.	Low	Maintain: This feature and ensure data export/import remains reliable across devices.	[5]

Weaknesses

What type of heuristic is applicable?	Describe the issue you are reviewing	Severity	Recommendation	Best Practise Example
Design Principles	Lack of Status Confirmation: On the “Add Your First Project” screen, there is no progress indicator. If the project takes time to upload, the user may think the app has frozen.	Med	Investigate: Add a loading state or a “Success” notification once the “Continue” button is pressed.	[6]
Usability Heuristics	The project page lacks insight like subtasks, deadlines, priorities and mainly shows a status of completion.	Med	Add interactive elements to view subtasks and dependencies, track priorities and deadlines.	[7]
Usability Heuristics	User Control and Freedom: Once an option is selected, the user is unable to go back to the previous page. There is no clear ‘back” path once a selection is made.	High	Fix: implement a “Back” button or a breadcrumb trail so users can retreat from a selection without restarting the flow	[8]
Usability Heuristics	Navigation Trapping: In the search area, the bottom navigation icons become unresponsive leaving the user “stuck” on the search page.	High	Fix: Ensure the global navigation bar remains interactive or provide a clear “Exit Search” button to return to the previous state.	[9]
Other (Content)	Ambiguous Labelling:	Med	Investigate: Add short explanations or	[10]

	The term “Knowledge Graph” is vague and may not be clear to non-technical users, making the feature feel inaccessible.		tooltips to clarify the feature or rename it to something more descriptive like “Document Connections”.	

Expert Review for Team Softmint Engineers

Strengths

What type of heuristic is applicable?	Describe the issue you are reviewing	Severity	Recommendation	Best Practise Example
Usability Heuristics (Visibility of system status)	Progress Indicators: The "Personal Care" and "Personal Details" flows use clear step indicators (e.g., "Step 1 • • •") and progress bars.	Low	Maintain these indicators to help users understand how much effort is remaining in a task.	[11]
Usability Heuristics (Help and documentation)	Comprehensive FAQ & Support: The design includes a dedicated FAQ section with search functionality and categorized "Common Topics," making self-service easy.	Low	Keep the "Contact Support" button highly visible at the bottom for issues that self-service cannot solve.	[12]
Other (Content)	Informative description on what information and data the AI in the app uses and has access to. The app allows users to select the frequency of AI suggestions.	Low	Notify first time users of the AI involvement in the application.	[13]

Usability Heuristics (User control and freedom)	Users can edit details, update password, adjust preferences and modify their wardrobe items, this indicates strong support for account customisation and control.	Low	Ensure that you include a “Cancel” option and that its visible in all edit flows.	[14]
Visual design fundamentals and design principles	The Home/Dashboard screen presents key content in clear sections (e.g., “Today’s Outfit”, “Quik Actions”, “upcoming Events”, “Trending Looks”, “Suggested Items”, “Personal Care”), which supports fast scanning and makes the main options easy to spot.	Low	Keep this structured layout. In hi-fi, maintain spacing and heading contrast so the hierarchy stays obvious and doesn’t become cluttered.	[15]
Design principles (Flexibility & efficiency of use) + Other (Content / feature integration)	The app integrates multiple lifestyle factors (calendar events, weather context, wardrobe items, and personal preferences) into the outfit recommendation flow. This ecosystem approach reduces the need for users to manually coordinate information across apps (e.g., checking weather separately before choosing clothing). It	Low	Continue strengthening contextual intelligence (e.g., showing why an outfit was suggested: weather, event type, preferences). This increases trust and transparency.	[16]

	supports efficient decision-making and increases perceived value because recommendations feel context-aware rather than generic.			

1.

Weaknesses

What type of heuristic is applicable?	Describe the issue you are reviewing	Severity	Recommendation	Best Practise Example
Visual Design Fundamentals (Accessibility)	Low Contrast Interactive Elements: In the "Preferences" and "Privacy" screens, several buttons and toggles use very thin borders or light grey backgrounds that may be hard to distinguish.	Med	Fix: Increase the border weight or use higher contrast background colours to ensure all interactive elements meet accessibility standards.	[17]
Design Principles (Error Prevention)	Destructive Actions Proximity: In the "Calendar Settings," the "Reset Settings" button is prominently placed in red without a clear warning or confirmation step shown.	High	Fix: Add a confirmation modal that appears when "Reset" is clicked to prevent accidental data loss.	[18]
Usability Heuristics	In creating a new password there is no option to confirm new password or option to view the password that has been typed. If user accidently inputs an incorrect character in making the new password, they will not be able to correct it in time and will ultimately be unable to log in using their 'new' password.	High	Fix: Implementing an option to Confirm the new password, and both passwords must match, before user is allowed to update the password.	[19]

Search and filtering efficiency	The filter system is very detailed, and cam be potentially overwhelming if many options are visible at once. Users may struggle to quickly locate specific clothing.	Med	Fix: Implement more presets for example, “Work”, “Summer”, “Formal”. T his will be helpful for faster selection.	[20]
Usability heuristics (Recognition rather than recall)	The bottom navigation icons rely heavily on symbols without strong labels or differentiation, and some screens (e.g., Closet, Calendar, Home) contain overlapping concepts. Users may need to remember where features live rather than immediately recognizi ng them. This increases cognitive load, particularly for new users, and could slow task completion when trying to switch between wardrobe management and planning functions.	Med	Test icon comprehension with first-time users. Consider adding persistent text labels, clearer icon metaphors, or restructuring navigation around user goals (Plan, Closet, Care, Profile).	[21]
Usability heuristics (Feedback & system status) + Design principles (Consistency)	In the “Today’s Outfit” generation and editing flows, the system provides action buttons like “Regenerate” and “Edit Outfit,” but there is little visible feedback explaining what changed after regeneration or why a new outfit was produced. Without explanatory feedback, users may perceive results as random or lose confidence in the recommendation system.	Med	Add micro-feedback such as: “Updated based on weather change” Highlighted differences between versions Loading or processing indicators during regeneration	[22]

Expert Review for Team Deadline Survivors' App "ProjectPilot"

Strengths

What type of heuristic is applicable?	Describe the issue you are reviewing	Severity	Recommendation	Best Practise Example
Other	The editor provides a profile of each member behind the creation and scene of the application making it more humanized and providing more accountability to how the app is operated.	Low	Keep the profiles up to date, providing factual and accurate information.	[23]
Design Principles + Visual Design Fundamentals	The dashboard screen groups key student needs in one place (projects list, upcoming deadlines, and calendar), which supports quick scanning and helps users understand "what to do next" without digging through multiple pages.	Low	Keep this layout structure. When moving to hi-fi, maintain clear headings and spacing so the hierarchy stays obvious.	[24]
Usability Heuristics	Consistency and standards – the prototype maintain a very good layout pattern across all pages. The navigation bar appears structures similarly on each page, which improves familiarity with the app.	Low	Maintain consistent spacing, typography hierarchy, and button styling in your high-fidelity.	[25]
Usability Heuristics (User control and freedom)	Integrated Workspace Flexibility: The editor provides a "split view" allowing users to see their project dashboard and live preview simultaneously while editing.	Low	Maintain this layout as it reduces the need for users to switch tabs or windows to check context.	[26]

Usability Heuristics (Visibility of system status)	AI Progress & Feedback: The “Review with AI Hub” screen provides clear scoring metrics (e.g., “8.5/10”) and confidence percentages to explain AI analysis results	Low	Ensure these metrics are updated in real-time as the user makes edits to their document	[27]
Usability Heuristics	The prototype structures projects around academic workflows rather than software features (e.g., sections for drafting, task breakdowns, deadlines, AI review, and export). This mirrors how students already think about assignments, reducing the learning curve and making the system feel intuitive even for first-time users.	Low	Keep aligning terminology and structure with academic mental models (e.g., “Sections,” “Deadlines,” “Review,” “Export”) rather than introducing technical or system-centric language in later iterations.	[28]
Usability Heuristics	The prototype frequently give s users clear options to undo or reverse actions, such as easy access to *Cancel, Back, Exit, or Save Later* throughout complex flows (e.g., new project setup, settings, text editor). This supports exploration, which is especially important in academic tools where users may interrupt tasks or revise work multiple times.	Low	Retain or improve these exit options in the high-fidelity version and add clear confirmation dialogs so users feel safe exploring without fear of losing progress.	[29]

Weaknesses

What type of heuristic is applicable?	Describe the issue you are reviewing	Severity	Recommendation	Best Practise Example
Usability Heuristics	There is a lot of information on the starting page and the option to start a new project does not encourage users to sign up for the app.	Medium	Limit the accessibility of features of users can access without an associated account.	[30]
Usability Heuristics + Design Principles	The left sidebar navigation uses icon-only buttons. For new users, icons can be ambiguous, forcing them to guess or remember what each icon means. Which slows navigation and increases errors.	Med	Add text labels (or tooltips on hover) and make the “current section” clearly highlighted. Consider keeping the most important destination visible, not hidden behind icons only.	[29]
Usability Heuristics	There are no loading states, progress bars, or feedback for users’ actions given in the prototype, example after clicking save, submit or subscribe (for payment). Users may be unsure if their action registered.	High	Add success notifications or progress indicators. This will help users know if their actions were registered. These indictors communicate that the system is working and reduce confusion.	[31]
Usability Heuristics	Navigation Trapping: In the search area, the bottom navigation icons become unresponsive leaving the user “stuck” on the search page.	High	Fix: Ensure the global navigation bar remains interactive or provide a clear “Exit Search” button to return to the previous state.	[32]
Visual Design Fundamentals (Layout)	Information Density in Dashboard: The Student Dashboard contains a high volume of text, calendars, and lists in a single view. Which may	Medium	Investigate Usability Testing: Test if users can quickly find the “Create New Project” button amidst the dense project lists.	[33]

	lead to cognitive overload.			
Usability Heuristics (Error Prevention)	Destructive “Delete” Proximity: In the Project Dashboard, “Delete” buttons are placed immediately next to section titles without high visual distinction or clear confirmation steps.	High	Add a secondary confirmation dialog (e.g,. “Are you sure you want to delete this section?”) to prevent accidental data loss.	[34]
Usability Heuristics	The prototype lacks in-context guidance for complex features such as the AI Review, split workspace, and task hub. While these features appear powerful, first-time users may not understand how or when to use them without external explanation, increasing initial friction.	Medium	Add lightweight onboarding cues such as short tooltips, inline hints, or a guided first-time walkthrough. Test whether new users can successfully complete a full project flow without prior instruction.	[34]

Expert Review for Team Talon's App "NutriWise"

Strengths

What type of heuristic is applicable?	Describe the issue you are reviewing	Severity	Recommendation	Best Practice Example
Usability Heuristics (user control and freedom)	clear navigation: every onboarding screen includes a "Back" button and a clear "Continue" primary action, allowing users to move fluidly through the flow.	Low	Maintain this pattern throughout the app to prevent users from feeling "trapped" in a flow.	[35]
Visual Design Fundamentals (Hierarchy)	Progressive Disclosure: The onboarding breaks complex data collection (goals, diet, weight) into bite-sized, single-topic screens, preventing cognitive overload.	Low	Continue using this "one-task-per-screen" approach for complex features like meal logging.	[36]

Appendix C: Meeting Minutes

Meeting Minutes – Worksheet 1

UXplorers – Minutes of Meeting

Name of Organisation/Committee/Board: UXplorers Project Team – HelpEra

Day & Date: Tuesday, 8th January 2026

Time: 12:00 PM – 1:00 PM

Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

MINUTES

PRESENT:

Resham Furqan

Maria Waheed

Blessed Dendere

Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba

Natalee De Silva

APOLOGIES:

None

ABSENT:

None

1. CALL TO ORDER / OPENING REMARKS

The meeting was called to order at 12:00 PM by the Project Manager, Resham Furqan.

Resham welcomed all team members and outlined the objective of the meeting, which was to:

- Finalise the application concept
- Confirm roles and responsibilities
- Review initial user research planning
- Begin competitor analysis discussion

- Align on usability and UX goals

She emphasized the importance of collaboration, meeting deadlines, and maintaining consistent documentation for assessment purposes.

2. APPROVAL OF THE MINUTES FROM (No Previous Meeting)

As this was the first official project meeting, there were no previous minutes to approve.

3. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

None

4. APPROVAL OF THE AGENDA

Motion: To approve the agenda as circulated and amended.
Motion By: Resham Furqan
Carried

Resolution: The agenda was approved unanimously.

5. BUSINESS ARISING OUT OF THE PREVIOUS MEETING

Not applicable (first formal meeting).

6. ITEM #1: Project Idea Finalisation – HelpEra

a. Summary of Discussion

Natalee discussed the increasing need for accessible mental health support among young adults. It was presented that the application, HelpEra, would focus on:

- Non-clinical mental health support
- Educational resources
- Self-reflection tools
- Support pathways for both individuals struggling and those supporting others

The team agreed and that the app would prioritize emotional safety, simplicity, and accessibility.

b. Motion

HelpEra - UXplorers

No formal motion required.

c. Follow-Up

Each team member confirmed their designated role within the project.

d. Action:

- All members to refine their assigned sections before next meeting.
- Completion deadline: 14th January 2026

7. ITEM #2: User Research Planning

a. Summary of Discussion

Maria presented the plan to conduct an anonymous online survey using Google Forms targeting young adults aged 18–30.

The team reviewed and approved the seven draft survey questions focusing on:

- Stress frequency
- Previous app usage
- Barriers to accessing support
- Desired features
- Privacy importance

The team agreed that anonymity is critical due to the sensitive nature of mental health topics.

b. Motion

Motion: To proceed with the online survey as primary research method.
Motion By: Blessed Dendere
Seconded By: Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Carried

c. Follow-Up

Maria to finalize and distribute the survey.

d. Action:

- Maria Waheed to distribute survey and collect 15–20 responses by 26 February 2026.

8. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

8.1 Competitor Analysis

a. Summary of Discussion

Kekweditse presented initial findings on competitors:

- **TalkLife** – Strong peer support model but lacks professional guidance.
- **7 Cups** – Provides active listening but has inconsistent support quality and safety concerns.

The team identified opportunities for HelpEra to:

- Provide structured peer sharing templates
- Clearly separate professional and peer advice
- Include better safety prompts and intervention reminders
- Offer separate tracks: “I am struggling” and “I am supporting someone”

b. Motion

No formal motion required.

c. Follow-Up

Kekweditse to complete written competitor comparison section.

d. Action:

- Competitor analysis draft due by 26th February 2026.

9. ADJOURNMENT

The meeting was adjourned at **12:00 PM** by Resham Furqan.

10. NEXT MEETING

HelpEra - UXplorers

Next Meeting Date: Tuesday, 15th January 2026

Time: 12:00 PM – 1:00 PM

Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

DISTRIBUTION OF MINUTES

These minutes were prepared by Natalee De Silva (Figma and Documentation Leader).

The minutes will be:

- Reviewed by the Project Manager before distribution
- Shared with all team members within one week
- Saved as part of the official project documentation record

Meeting Minutes – Worksheet 2

UXplorers – Minutes of Meeting

Name of Organisation/Committee/Board: UXplorers Project Team – HelpEra

Day & Date: 15th January 2026

Time: 12:00 PM – 2:00 PM

Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

MINUTES

PRESENT:

Resham Furqan

Maria Waheed

Blessed Dendere

Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba

Natalee De Silva

APOLOGIES:

None

ABSENT:

None

1. CALL TO ORDER / OPENING REMARKS

The meeting was called to order at **12:00 PM** by the Project Manager, Resham Furqan.

Resham stated that the purpose of this meeting was to:

- Finalise identified pain points
- Confirm problem statements and HMW questions
- Align on ideated solutions
- Confirm lifecycle model selection
- Review Kanban board progress
- Discuss Figma progress and logo creation

She emphasized the importance of aligning all design decisions with user emotional safety and usability goals.

2. APPROVAL OF THE MINUTES FROM 25 January 2026

Motion: To approve the minutes of 8th January 2026 as circulated.
Motion By: Resham Furqan
Carried

Resolution: The minutes of 8th January 2026 were approved without amendments.

3. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

The following item was added:

- Logo concept finalisation discussion

4. APPROVAL OF THE AGENDA

Motion: To approve the agenda as amended.
Motion By: Resham Furqan
Carried

Resolution: The amended agenda was approved unanimously.

5. BUSINESS ARISING OUT OF THE PREVIOUS MEETING

- Survey findings were reviewed and incorporated into affinity mapping.
- Initial competitor analysis insights were confirmed and used to refine pain points.

No outstanding actions remained.

6. ITEM #1: Pain Points & Affinity Mapping

a. Summary of Discussion

The team discussed and grouped pain points identified through user research. These were organized into five key themes:

- Technical and Performance Issues
- Social and Peer Interaction Risks
- Usability and Content Overload
- Psychological and Emotional Barriers
- Operational and Professional Matchmaking Challenges

The team discussed how technical instability (e.g., crashes or lost journal entries) can cause emotional harm and reduce trust. Privacy concerns were highlighted as a major barrier to engagement.

The group agreed that supporter anxiety and dense reading materials increase cognitive overload, especially during moments of distress.

b. Motion

Motion: To adopt the five themed pain point categories as the official foundation for problem statements.
Motion By: Maria Waheed
Seconded By: Blessed Dendere
Carried

c. Follow-Up

Blessed to refine the wording of the final problem statements for clarity and alignment.

d. Action

Blessed Dendere to finalize problem statements by **6 February 2026**.

7. ITEM #2: Problem Statements & HMW Questions

a. Summary of Discussion

The team reviewed and approved three core problem statements:

- Safety and Stability
- Privacy and Trust
- Supporter Anxiety and Content Overload

The team then refined the “How Might We” (HMW) questions to ensure they were open-ended and solution focused.

Special attention was given to:

- Professional matching without repeated trauma storytelling
- Flexible interface modes (Standard vs Simplified)
- Structured support guidance for friends and family

b. Motion

Motion: To adopt the revised HMW statements as the official ideation framework for HelpEra.
Motion By: Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Carried

c. Follow-Up

Ensure HMW statements align clearly with ideated solutions in documentation.

d. Action

Team to update Worksheet 2 documentation by **22nd January 2026**.

8. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

8.1 Ideated Solutions & Feature Themes

a. Summary of Discussion

The team reviewed solutions grouped into five themes:

1. Gentle Guidance and Structured Access
2. Matchmaking and Continuity
3. Clear, Simplified Support for Others
4. Privacy and Trust
5. Accessibility and Cognitive Support

Key solution highlights included:

- Encrypted “My Journey” Passport
- Identity and vibe filtering for professionals
- Progressive Support Cards
- Transparent onboarding
- Focus Mode toggle for cognitive overload
- Screen reader optimization

The team agreed that all features must reinforce emotional safety and trust.

b. Action

Natalee to begin reflecting these themes visually in low-fidelity wireframes by **22nd January 2026**.

8.2 Lifecycle Model & Kanban Structure

a. Summary of Discussion

The team formally adopted an **Agile (Kanban-based Iterative Design Process)** lifecycle model.

It was agreed that Kanban supports:

- Flexibility
- Clear task visibility
- Incremental progress
- User-centred refinement

The Kanban board structure was confirmed with the following columns:

- To Do
- In Progress
- Review
- Completed

Work-in-progress limits will be applied to avoid overload.

b. Motion

Motion: To officially adopt the Kanban-based Agile lifecycle model for the HelpEra project.
Motion By: Maria Waheed
Carried

c. Resolution

The Agile Kanban lifecycle model was formally adopted for project management.

9. ADJOURNMENT

The meeting was adjourned at **12:00 PM** by Resham Furqan.

10. NEXT MEETING

Next Meeting Date: Tuesday, 21st January 2026
Time: 12:00 PM – 1:45 PM
Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

DISTRIBUTION OF MINUTES

These minutes were prepared by Natalee De Silva (Figma and Documentation Leader).

The minutes will:

- Be reviewed by the Project Manager prior to distribution
- Be shared with all team members within one week
- Be stored as part of the official project documentation record

Meeting Minutes – Worksheet 3

UXplorers – Minutes of Meeting

Name of Organisation/Committee/Board: UXplorers Project Team – HelpEra

Day & Date: Tuesday, 21st January 2026

Time: :12:00 PM – 1:30 PM

Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

MINUTES

PRESENT:

Resham Furqan

Maria Waheed

Blessed Dendere

Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba

Natalee De Silva

APOLOGIES:

None

ABSENT:

None

1. CALL TO ORDER / OPENING REMARKS

The meeting was called to order at 12:00 PM by the Project Manager, Resham Furqan.

Resham stated that the purpose of this meeting was to:

HelpEra - UXplorers

- Finalise the app's core functionality
- Confirm functional and non-functional requirements
- Review user flow and hierarchical task analysis
- Align system requirements with UX goals
- Discuss competitor-inspired feature adaptations

She emphasized that requirements must clearly reflect previously identified pain points and HMW statements.

2. APPROVAL OF THE MINUTES FROM 15th January 2026

Motion: To approve the minutes of 15th January 2026 as circulated.
Motion By: Resham Furqan
Carried

Resolution: The minutes of 15th January 2026 were approved without amendments.

3. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

None

5. BUSINESS ARISING OUT OF THE PREVIOUS MEETING

- Ideated solutions were successfully mapped to FigJam.
- Kanban board was updated to reflect movement into the "Requirements Specification" phase.

6. ITEM #1: Brainstormed Functionality Confirmation

a. Summary of Discussion

In this meeting, we brainstormed the core functionality of our prototype based on the "How might we…" problem statement. We discussed key features, user flow (login, security, personalisation), and initial UI/UX design decisions.

We defined two main functional requirements to focus on within the limited timeframe. We also began planning low-fidelity wireframes, highlighting the need for iteration and improvement.

A brief competitor analysis was conducted, looking at platforms to identify best-practice design and user experience elements.

Next steps included finalising functional and non-functional requirements and developing a Hierarchical Task Analysis for key user activities.

b. Motion

Motion: To formally adopt the listed core features as the official functionality baseline for HelpEra.
Motion By: Resham Furqan
Carried

c. Action

Natalee to reflect finalised features in low-fidelity prototype by **22nd January 2026**.

7. ITEM #2: Best-in-World Competitor Feature Adaptation

a. Summary of Discussion

The team reviewed inspiration from leading platforms:

- **Uber** – Real-time status visibility to reduce uncertainty
- **Deliveroo** – Simplified visual progress tracking
- **Duolingo** – Micro-learning and streak engagement
- **Airbnb** – Humanised professional profiles

The team agreed to adapt:

- Waitlist progress indicators for professional responses
- Recovery journey progress bars
- Gentle streaks without guilt-based reinforcement

- Warm, human-centred professional profile layouts

b. Motion

Motion: To integrate selected competitor-inspired features into the HelpEra system requirements.

Motioned By: Blessed Dendere

Carried

c. Action

Maria to document final competitor-feature mapping in Worksheet 3 by 22nd January 2026.

8. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

8.1 Functional Requirements Finalisation

a. Summary of Discussion

The team reviewed and confirmed user and system functional requirements, including:

- Secure account management
- Mood logging and journaling
- Supporter access tools
- Professional directory filtering
- Data portability via User Passport
- CMS role-based content display

System requirements discussed included:

- Authentication
- Auto-save every 5 seconds in journaling module
- AES-256 encryption
- Emergency trigger system
- Professional database filtering logic

b. Motion

Motion: To approve the functional requirements as documented with encryption clarified.

Motion By: Maria Waheed

Carried

8.2 Non-Functional Requirements Confirmation

a. Summary of Discussion

The team reviewed measurable system performance expectations, including:

- 99.9% uptime
- <2 second search response time
- <3 second cold start launch
- 10,000 concurrent users
- WCAG 2.1 Level AA compliance
- Simplified Mode limiting cognitive load

Special attention was given to accessibility and guest mode privacy.

b. Action

Resham to ensure measurable metrics are clearly formatted in final submission by **28th February 2026**.

8.3 Hierarchical Task Analysis (HTA)

a. Summary of Discussion

The team reviewed the high-level Hierarchical Task Analysis for key tasks such as:

- Logging daily mood
- Finding a professional
- Accessing crisis support
- Sharing User Passport

The HTA was refined to ensure logical task breakdowns aligned with actual user flows in Figma.

b. Action

Resham to update HTA diagram to match prototype flow by **21st January 2026**.

9. ADJOURNMENT

The meeting was adjourned at **12:00 PM** by Resham Furqan.

10. NEXT MEETING

Next Meeting Date: Tuesday, 22nd January 2026

Time: 4:15 PM – 5:30 PM

Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

DISTRIBUTION OF MINUTES

These minutes were prepared by Natalee De Silva (Figma and Documentation Leader).

The minutes will:

- Be reviewed by the Project Manager prior to distribution
- Be shared with all team members within one week
- Be saved as part of official project documentation

Meeting Minutes – Worksheet 4

UXplorers – Minutes of Meeting

Name of Organisation/Committee/Board: UXplorers Project Team – HelpEra
Day & Date: 22nd January 2026
Time: 4:15 PM – 5:30 PM
Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

MINUTES

PRESENT:

Resham Furqan
Maria Waheed
Blessed Dendere

Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Natalee De Silva

APOLOGIES:

None

ABSENT:

None

1. CALL TO ORDER / OPENING REMARKS

The meeting was called to order at 4:15 PM by the Project Manager, Resham Furqan.

Resham stated that the purpose of the meeting was to:

- Review the Low-Fidelity Prototype
- Evaluate core screen structure and navigation flow
- Discuss peer and internal feedback
- Confirm iterations before transitioning to high-fidelity design

She emphasized that the focus at this stage was usability, clarity, and logical structure, but not visual polish.

2. APPROVAL OF THE MINUTES FROM 21st January 2026

Motion: To approve the minutes of 21st January 2026 as circulated.
Motion By: Resham Furqan
Carried

Resolution: The minutes of 21st January 2026 were approved without amendments.

3. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

None

4. APPROVAL OF THE AGENDA

None

5. BUSINESS ARISING OUT OF THE PREVIOUS MEETING

- Functional and non-functional requirements were finalized.
- Hierarchical Task Analysis was updated to reflect accurate task flows.
- Core features were mapped into wireframe planning.

6. ITEM #1: Low-Fidelity Prototype Overview

a. Summary of Discussion

Natalee presented the low-fidelity prototype developed using Balsamiq Wireframes software.

The prototype focused on structure, layout, and navigation without detailed visual styling.

The main screens presented included:

- Startup page
- Login and Sign-Up pages
- Emergency Hotline page (country-based search)
- Check-In page (daily wellbeing tracking)
- Learn page (categorized mental health information)
- Disorder-specific guide pages
- Community page (peer and professional interaction)
- Chatbot page (immediate offline support)
- Journal Track page (personal reflection)
- Profile page (user customization)

The team reviewed user flow logic between key journeys such as:

- Accessing emergency resources
- Logging daily mood
- Finding a professional
- Sharing journal entries

b. Motion

Motion: To approve the low-fidelity prototype structure as the foundation for iteration.
Motion By: Natalee De Silva
Carried

c. Action

Natalee to incorporate approved structural adjustments before high-fidelity design by **14th February 2026**.

7. ITEM #2: Feedback & Iteration Discussion

a. Summary of Feedback Received

The team discussed feedback gathered through:

- Internal team design reviews
- Walkthroughs with non-team students
- Guided navigation tasks (e.g., “Find the hotline for UAE”)

The following feedback and changes were documented:

Feedback 1: Journaling Felt Emotionally Repetitive

Issue: Users feared retelling trauma to professionals repeatedly.
Change Implemented:

- Added secure "Send to Professional" button
- Integrated journaling with goal-tracking dashboard
- Created cohesive loop between reflection and support

Feedback 2: Chatbot Placement Confusion

Issue: Users expected chatbot inside Community tab.
Change Implemented:

- Chatbot access repositioned prominently within Profile page
- Clarified purpose as offline/backup support tool

b. Motion

Motion: To approve the documented design iterations and proceed toward high-fidelity refinement.
Motion By: Natalee De Silva
Carried

8. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

8.1 Prototype Readiness for High-Fidelity Transition

a. Summary of Discussion

The team confirmed that:

- Core user flows are logically structured
- Major usability barriers identified through peer feedback were addressed
- Emergency access and journaling safeguards align with initial pain points

It was agreed that the prototype is ready to transition to visual refinement in Figma.

b. Action

Team to begin high-fidelity prototype design in Figma by 10th February 2026.

9. ADJOURNMENT

The meeting was adjourned at 12:00 PM by Resham Furqan.

10. NEXT MEETING

Next Meeting Date: 10th February 2026
Time: 9:30 AM – 10:30 PM
Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

DISTRIBUTION OF MINUTES

These minutes were prepared by Natalee De Silva (Figma and Documentation Leader).

The minutes will:

- Be reviewed by the project manager prior to distribution
- Be shared with all team members within one week
- Be stored as part of the official project documentation record

Meeting Minutes – Worksheet 5

UXplorers – Minutes of Meeting

Name of Organisation/Committee/Board: UXplorers Project Team – HelpEra
Day & Date: 10th February 2026
Time: 9:30 PM – 10:30 PM
Location: Microsoft Teams (Virtual Meeting)

MINUTES

PRESENT:

Resham Furqan
Maria Waheed
Blessed Dendere
Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Natalee De Silva

APOLOGIES:

None

ABSENT:

None

1. CALL TO ORDER / OPENING REMARKS

The meeting was called to order at **9:30 PM** by the Project Manager, Resham Furqan.

The purpose of the meeting was to:

- Conduct structured expert reviews of peer teams' applications
- Apply usability heuristics and design principles
- Identify strengths, weaknesses, and severity levels

Resham emphasized that feedback must be constructive, evidence-based, and grounded in UX principles rather than personal preference.

2. APPROVAL OF THE MINUTES FROM 18 February 2026

Motion: To approve the minutes of 22nd January 2026 as circulated.
Motion By: Resham Furqan
Carried

Resolution: The minutes of 22nd January 2026 were approved without amendments.

3. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

None

4. BUSINESS ARISING OUT OF THE PREVIOUS MEETING

- Low fidelity to high-fidelity prototype transition was confirmed.
- Feedback loop integration from Worksheet 4 was documented.
- Heuristic framework agreed upon for expert evaluation.

5. ITEM #1: Expert Review – Team BobTheBuilders' App "Helm"

a. Summary of Discussion

The team conducted an expert review of Helm using usability heuristics and design principles.

Key Strengths Identified:

- Flexibility and efficiency through voice mode ("Atlas")
- Clean and minimal interface
- Consistent layout structure
- Data export/import functionality
- Inclusive sharing options

Most strengths were rated **Low severity** as they required maintenance rather than correction.

Key Weaknesses Identified:

- Lack of visible progress indicators
- Limited task detail visibility
- No clear "Back" navigation in some flows
- Navigation trapping within search
- Ambiguous terminology ("Knowledge Graph")

Navigation trapping and lack of user control were rated High severity, as they significantly impact usability.

6. ADDITIONS TO THE AGENDA

None

7. ADJOURNMENT

The meeting was adjourned at 9:30 PM by Resham Furqan.

8. NEXT MEETING

Next Meeting Date: TBA
Time: TBA
Location: TBA

DISTRIBUTION OF MINUTES

These minutes were prepared by Natalee De Silva (Figma and Documentation Leader).

They will be:

- Reviewed before distribution
- Circulated within one week
- Archived as part of the official HelpEra documentation record

Appendix D: Record Keeping

Toggl Time Tracking

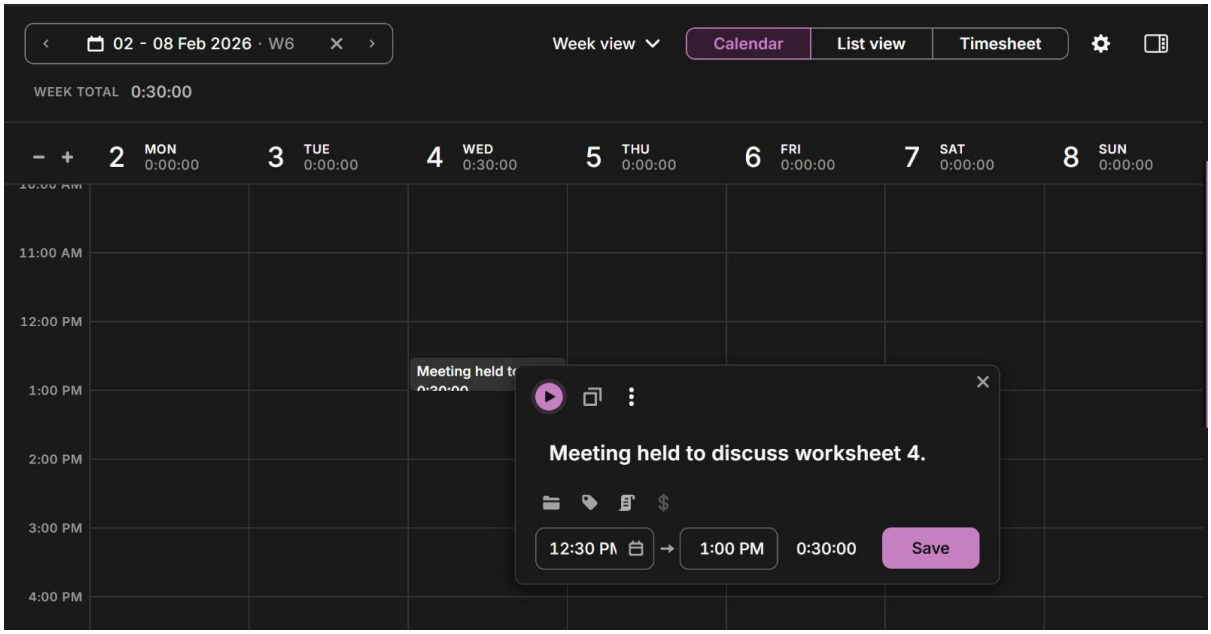


Figure 55: Toggl Track (Natalee)

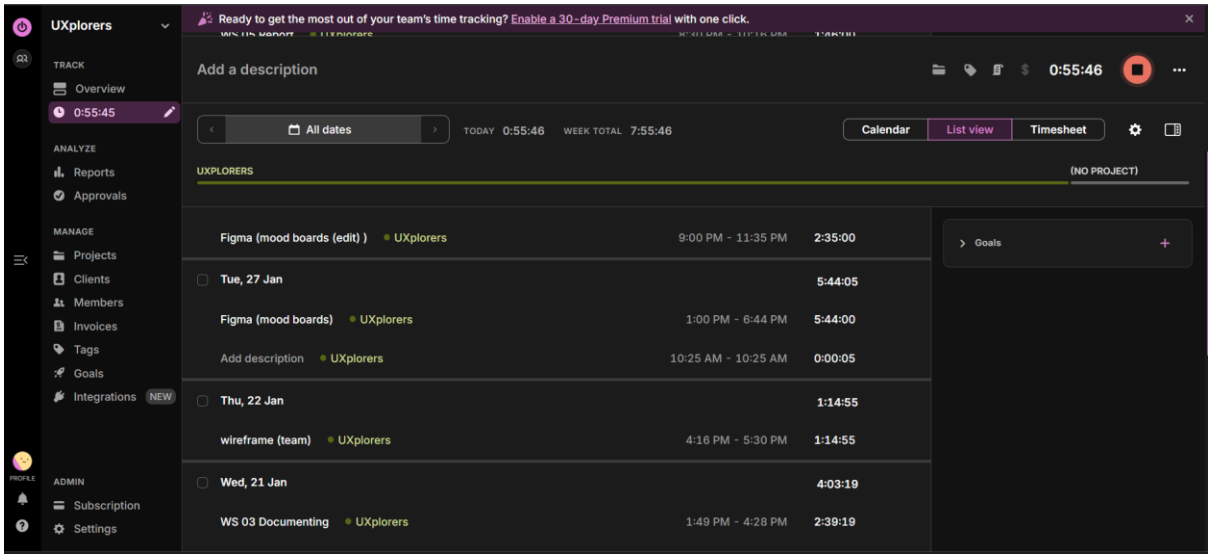


Figure 56: Toggl Track (Resham)

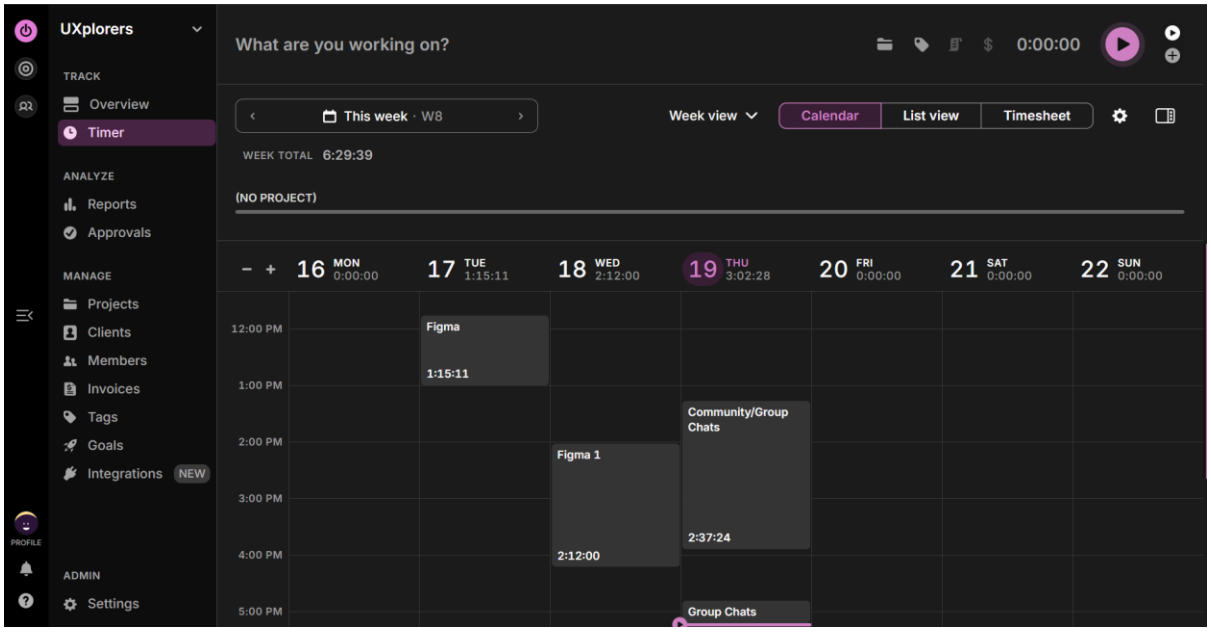


Figure 57: Toggl Track (Blessed)

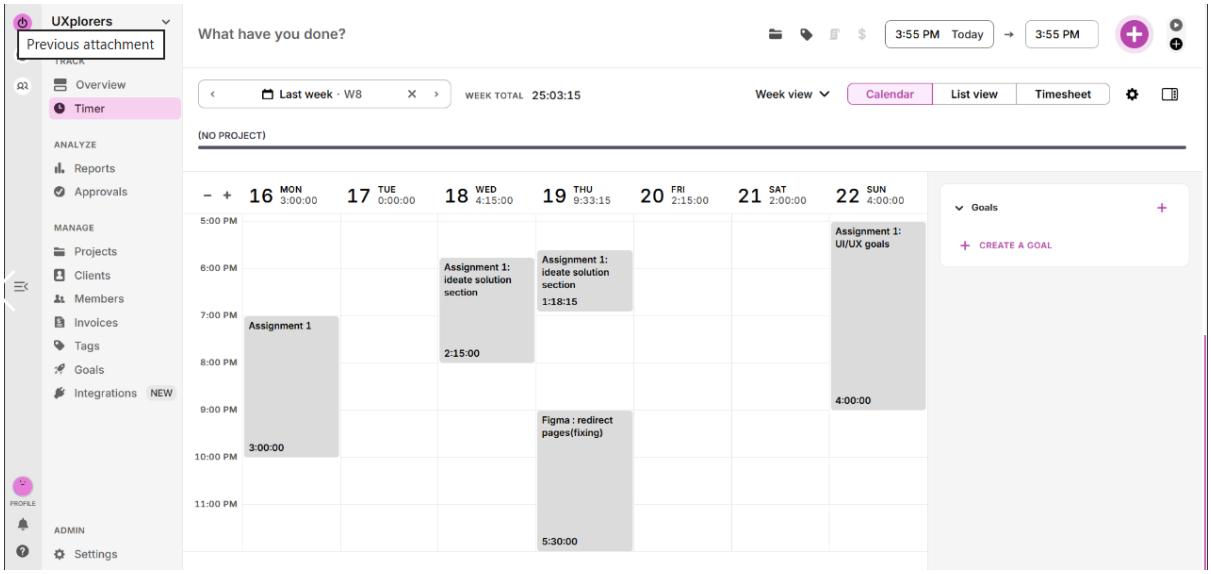


Figure 58: Toggl Track (Kekweditse)

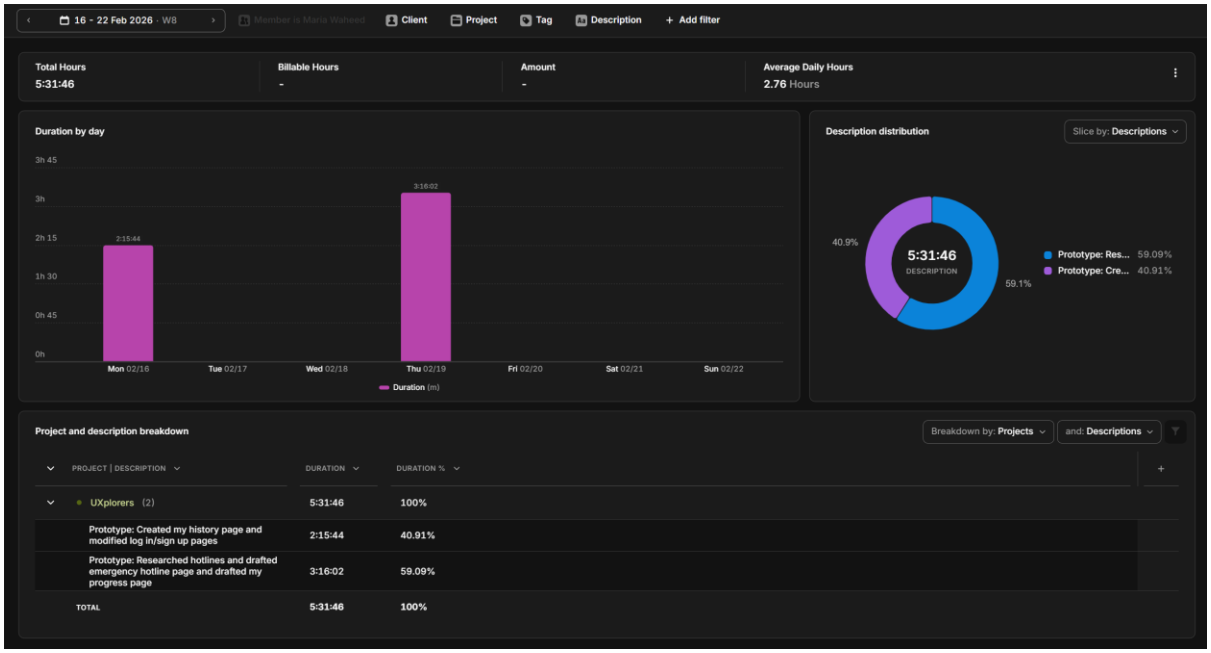


Figure 59: Toggl Track (Maria)

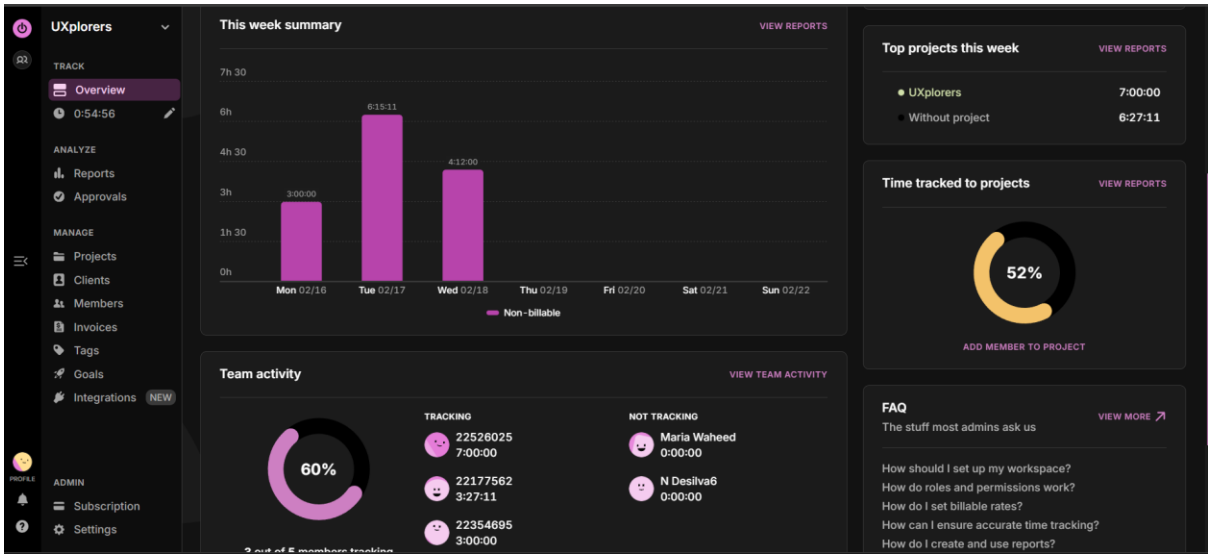


Figure 60: Toggl Track

Team Collaboration

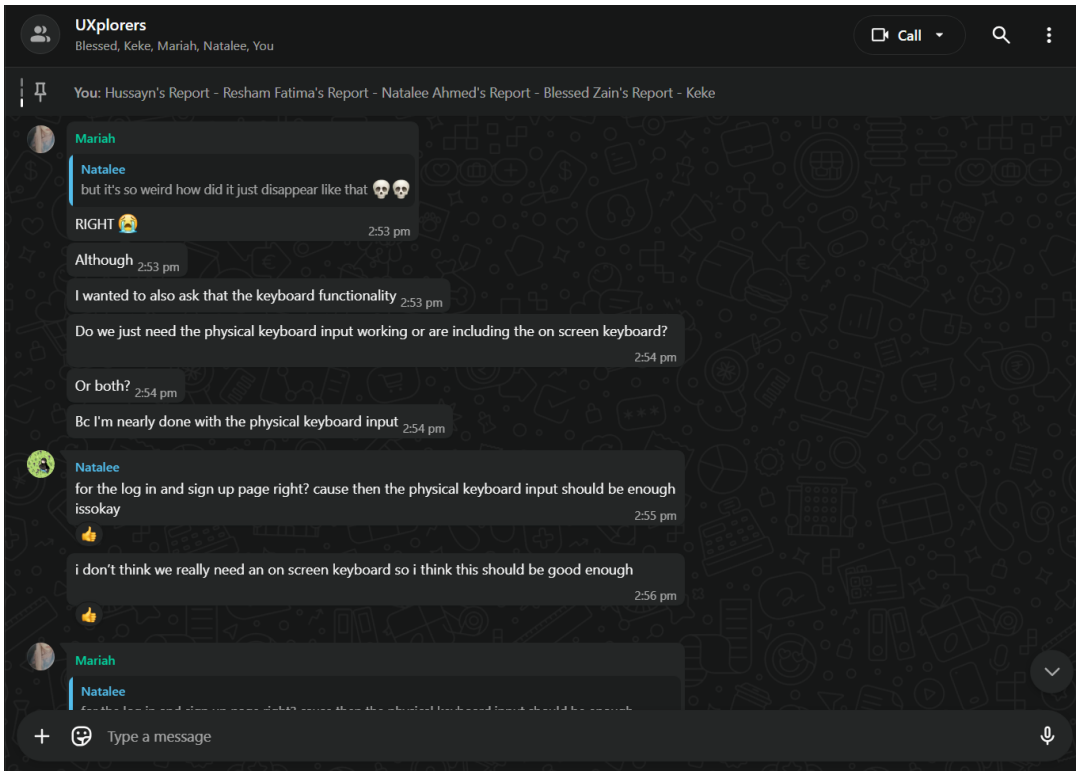


Figure 61: Team WhatsApp Communication (a)

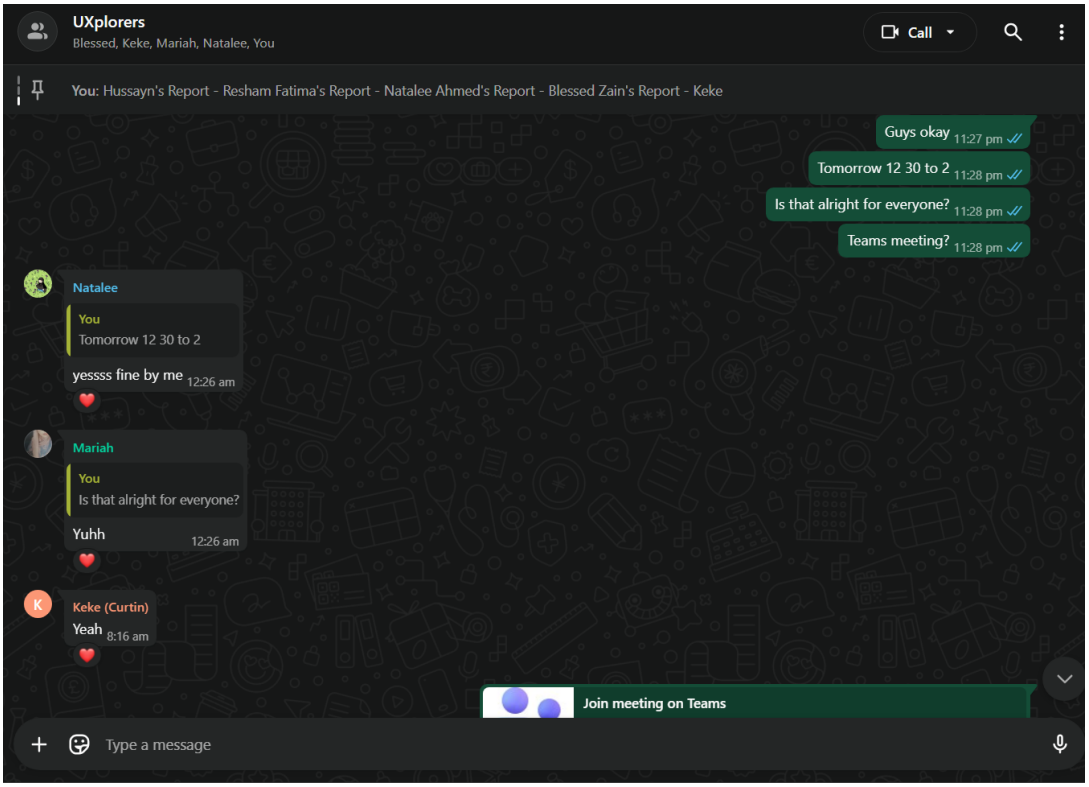


Figure 62: Team WhatsApp Communication (b)

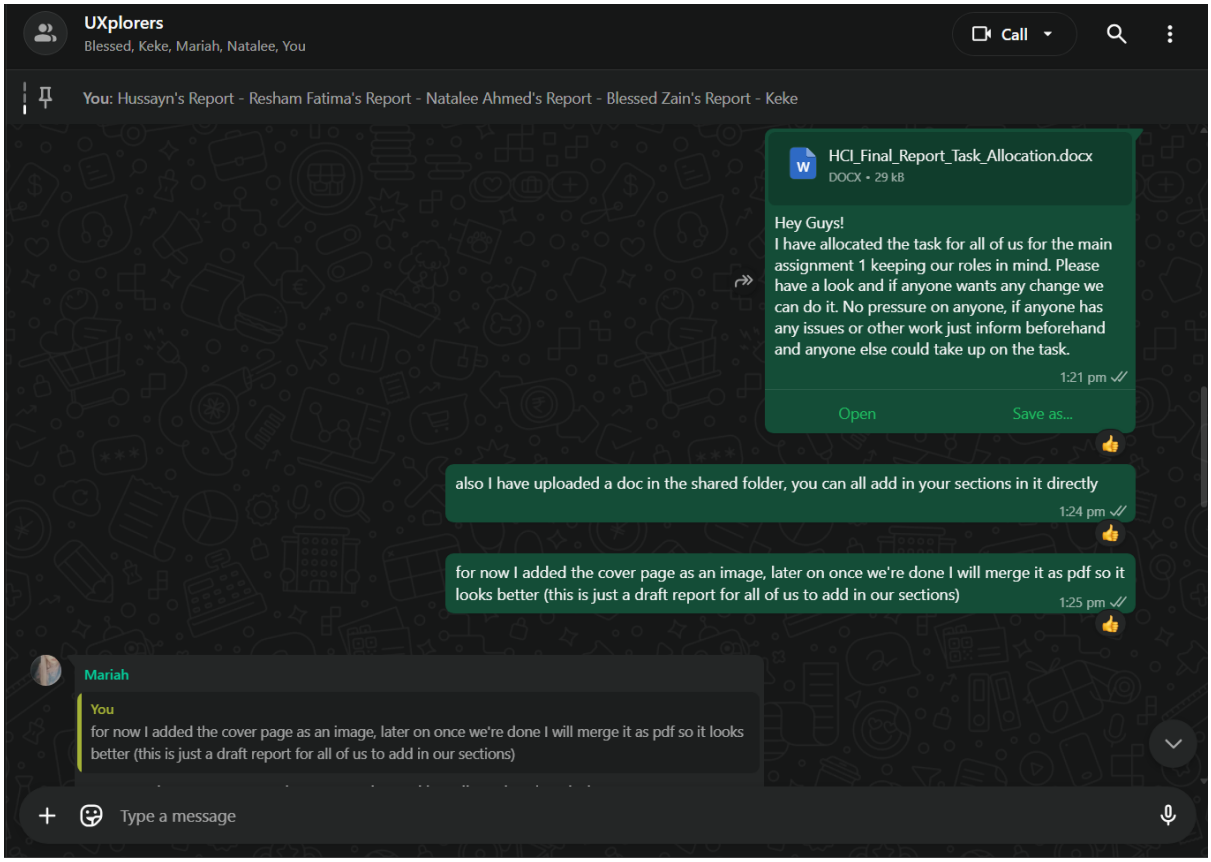


Figure 63: Team WhatsApp Communication (c)

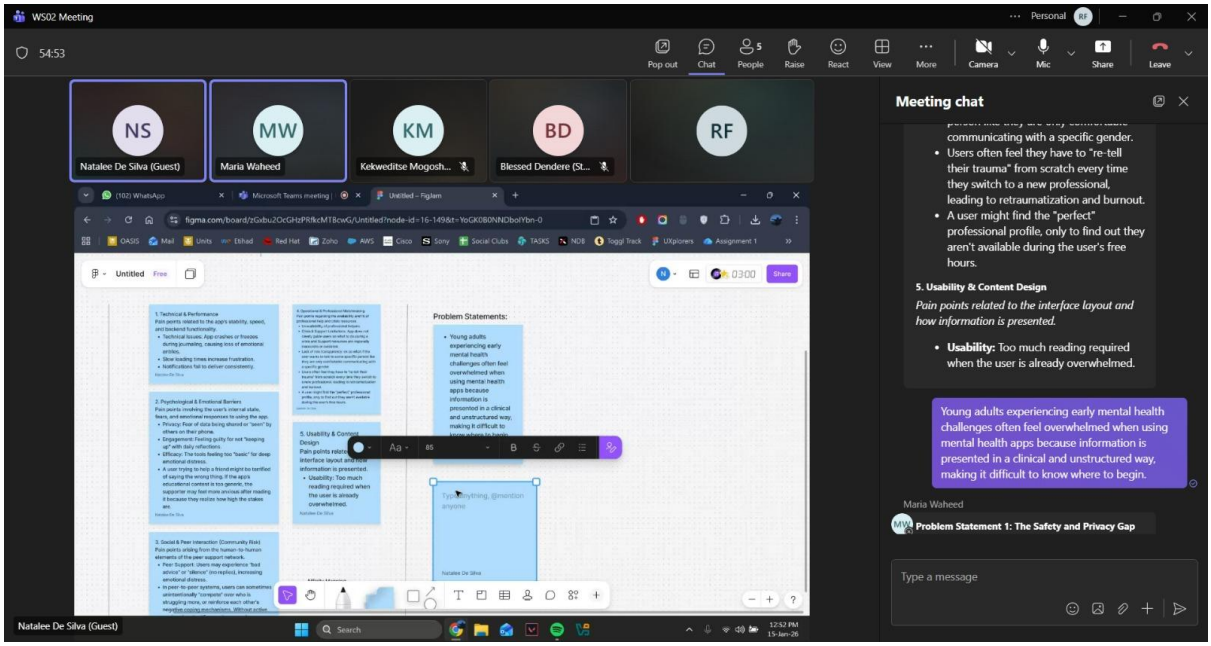


Figure 64: Working Together on Teams

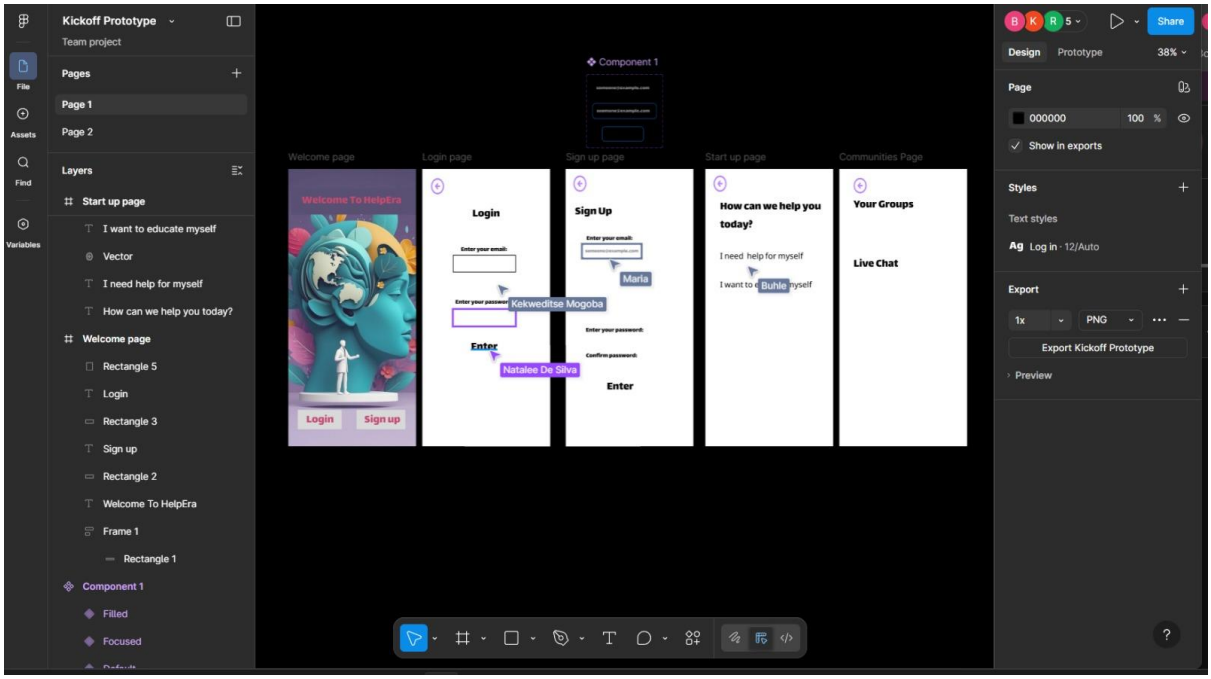


Figure 65: Working Together on Figma

Conversation with other Teams

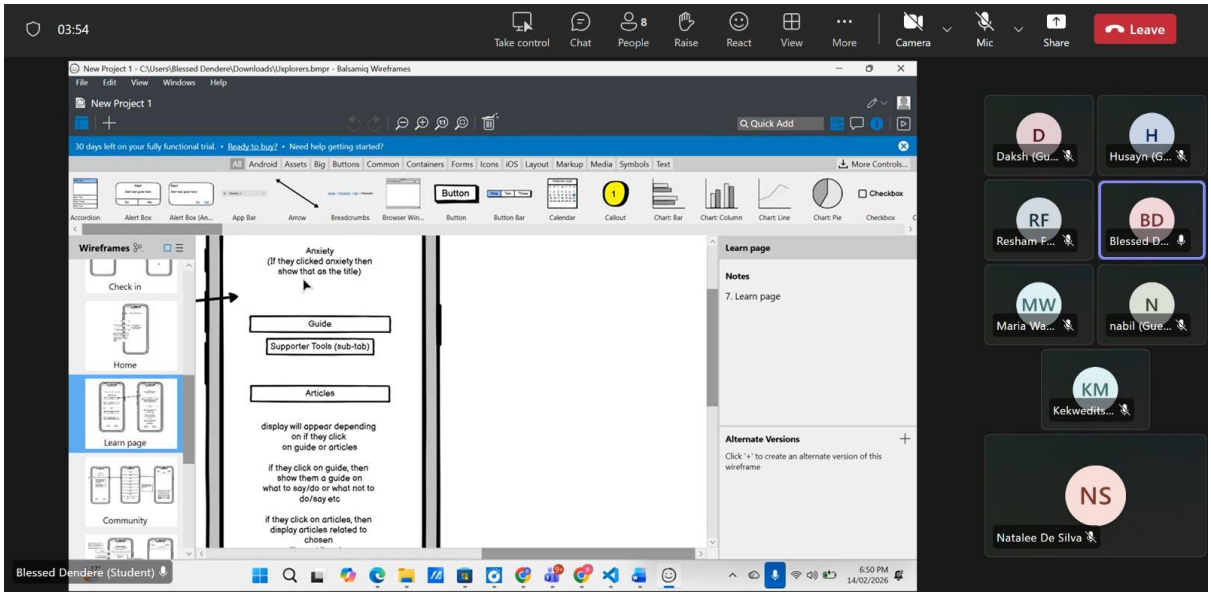


Figure 66: Walkthrough with BobTheBuilders (a)

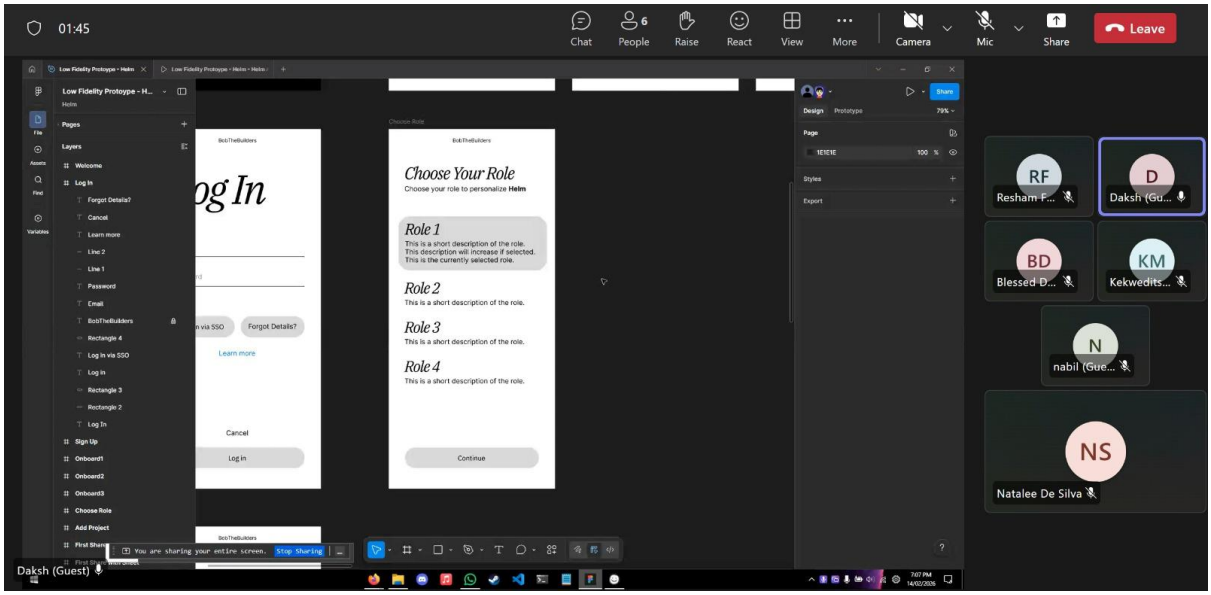
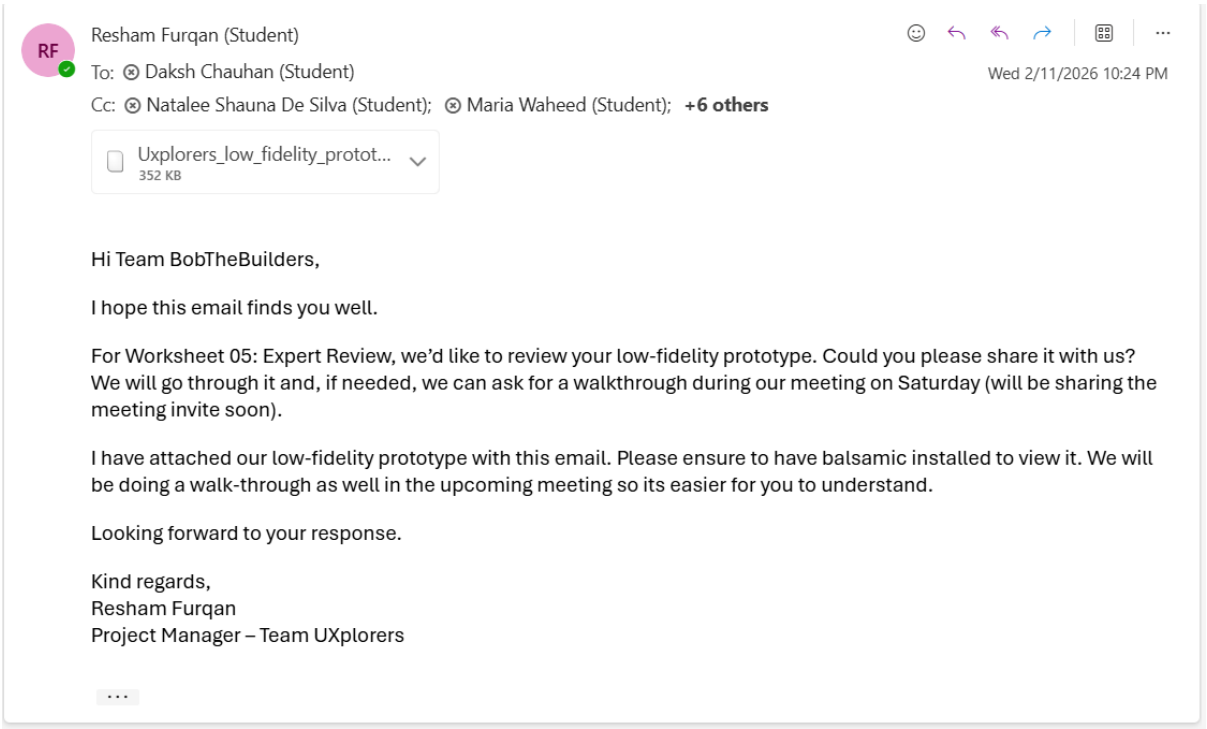


Figure 67: Walkthrough with BobTheBuilders (b)



Resham Furqan (Student)

To: Daksh Chauhan (Student)

Cc: Natalee Shauna De Silva (Student); Maria Waheed (Student); **+6 others**

Wed 2/11/2026 10:24 PM

Uxplorers_low_fidelity_protot...
352 KB

Hi Team BobTheBuilders,

I hope this email finds you well.

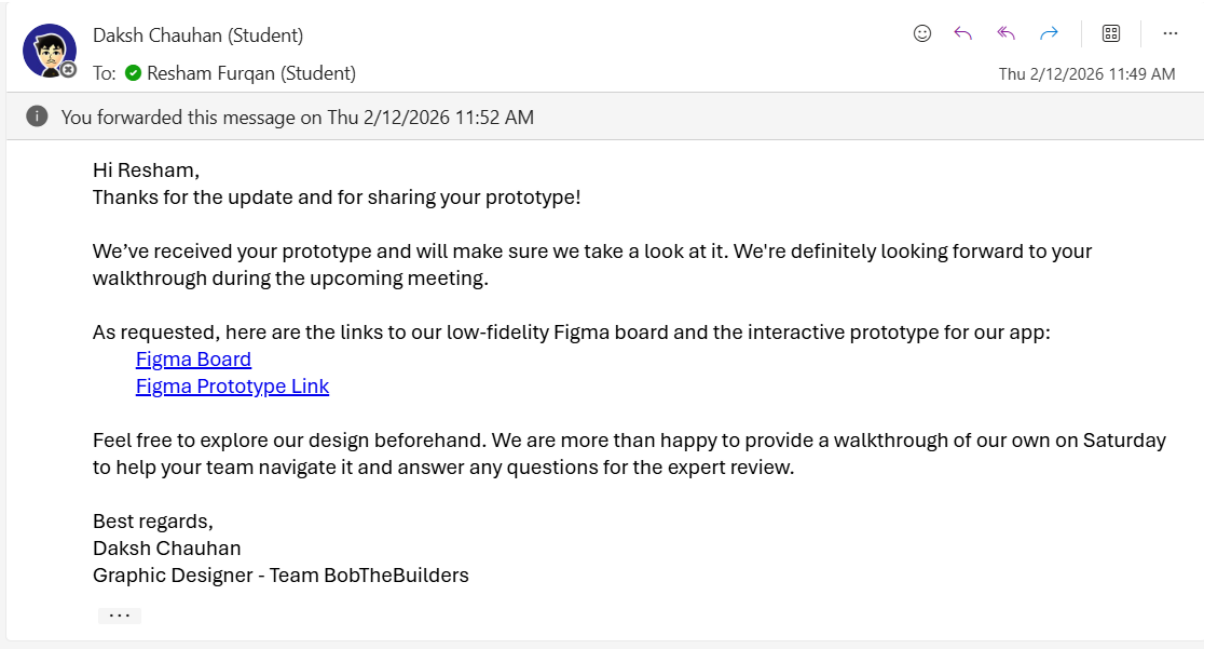
For Worksheet 05: Expert Review, we'd like to review your low-fidelity prototype. Could you please share it with us? We will go through it and, if needed, we can ask for a walkthrough during our meeting on Saturday (will be sharing the meeting invite soon).

I have attached our low-fidelity prototype with this email. Please ensure to have balsamic installed to view it. We will be doing a walk-through as well in the upcoming meeting so its easier for you to understand.

Looking forward to your response.

Kind regards,
Resham Furqan
Project Manager – Team UXplorers

Figure 68: Email Conversation with BobTheBuilders (a)



Daksh Chauhan (Student)

To: Resham Furqan (Student)

Thu 2/12/2026 11:49 AM

You forwarded this message on Thu 2/12/2026 11:52 AM

Hi Resham,
Thanks for the update and for sharing your prototype!

We've received your prototype and will make sure we take a look at it. We're definitely looking forward to your walkthrough during the upcoming meeting.

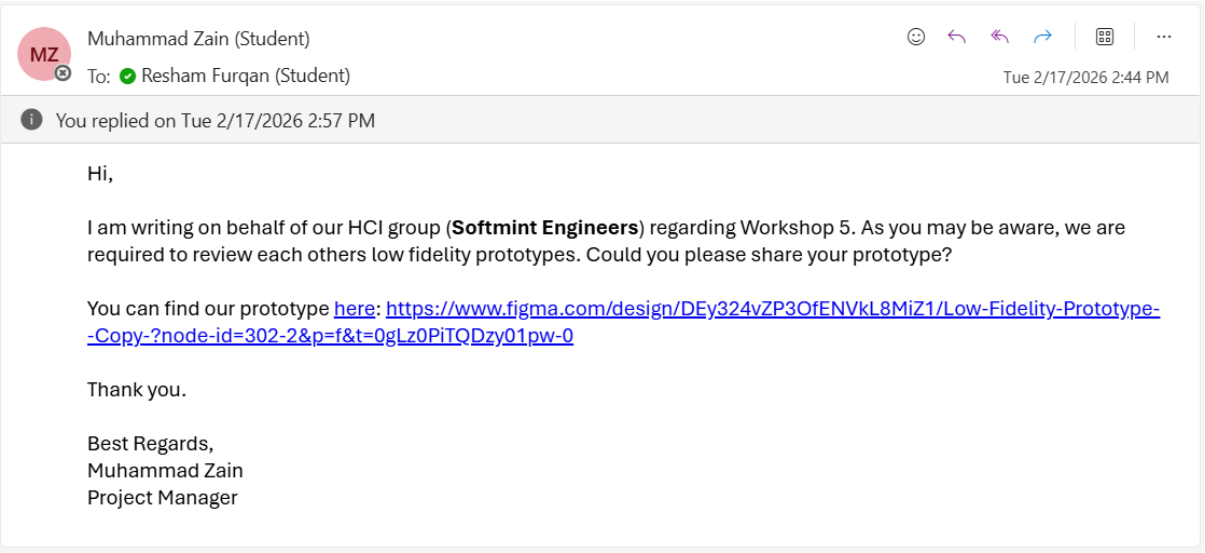
As requested, here are the links to our low-fidelity Figma board and the interactive prototype for our app:
Figma Board
Figma Prototype Link

Feel free to explore our design beforehand. We are more than happy to provide a walkthrough of our own on Saturday to help your team navigate it and answer any questions for the expert review.

Best regards,
Daksh Chauhan
Graphic Designer - Team BobTheBuilders

...

Figure 69: Email Conversation with BobTheBuilders (b)



Muhammad Zain (Student)

To: Resham Furqan (Student)

Tue 2/17/2026 2:44 PM

You replied on Tue 2/17/2026 2:57 PM

Hi,

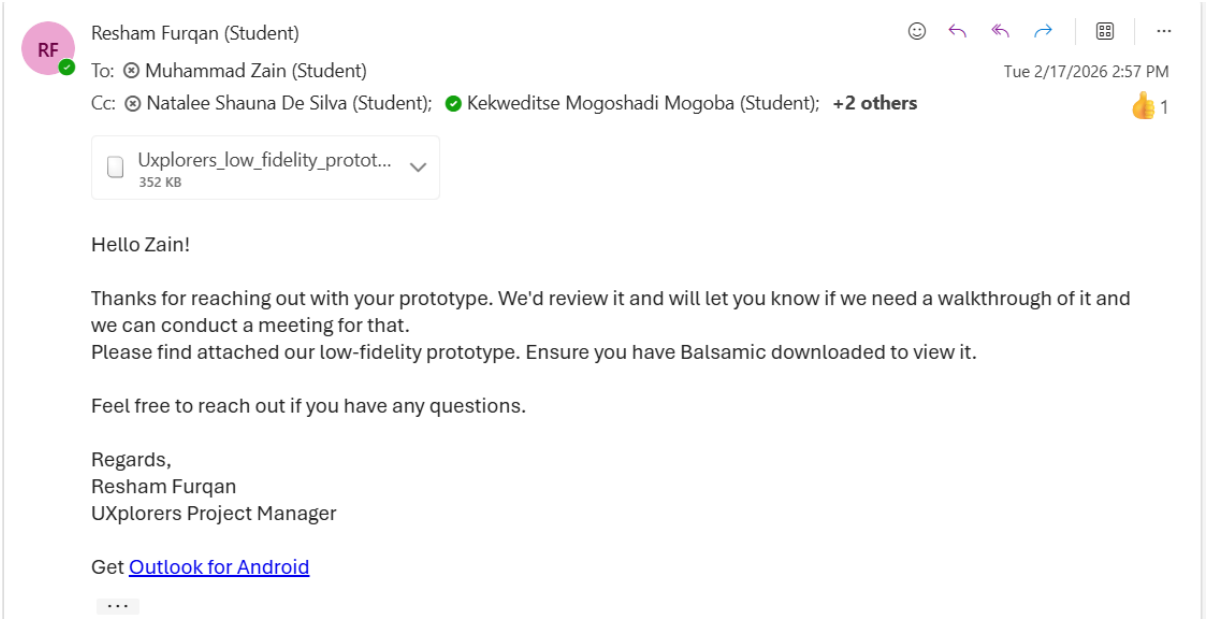
I am writing on behalf of our HCI group (**Softmint Engineers**) regarding Workshop 5. As you may be aware, we are required to review each others low fidelity prototypes. Could you please share your prototype?

You can find our prototype here: https://www.figma.com/design/DEy324vZP3OfENVkL8MiZ1/Low-Fidelity-Prototype--Copy-?node-id=302-2&p=f&t=0gLz0PiTQDzy01pw-0

Thank you.

Best Regards,
Muhammad Zain
Project Manager

Figure 70: Email Conversation with Softmint Engineers (a)



Resham Furqan (Student)
To: Muhammad Zain (Student)
Cc: Natalee Shauna De Silva (Student); Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba (Student); **+2 others**
Tue 2/17/2026 2:57 PM
1
Uxplorers_low_fidelity_protot...
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Hello Zain!

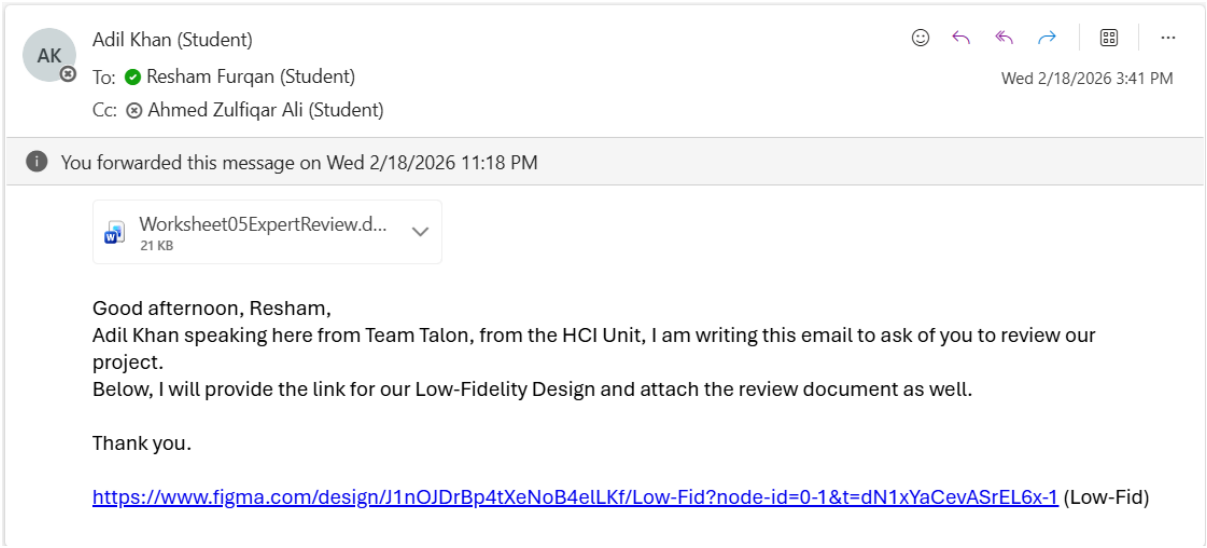
Thanks for reaching out with your prototype. We'd review it and will let you know if we need a walkthrough of it and we can conduct a meeting for that.
Please find attached our low-fidelity prototype. Ensure you have Balsamic downloaded to view it.

Feel free to reach out if you have any questions.

Regards,
Resham Furqan
UXplorers Project Manager

Get Outlook for Android

Figure 71: Email Conversation with Softmint Engineers (b)



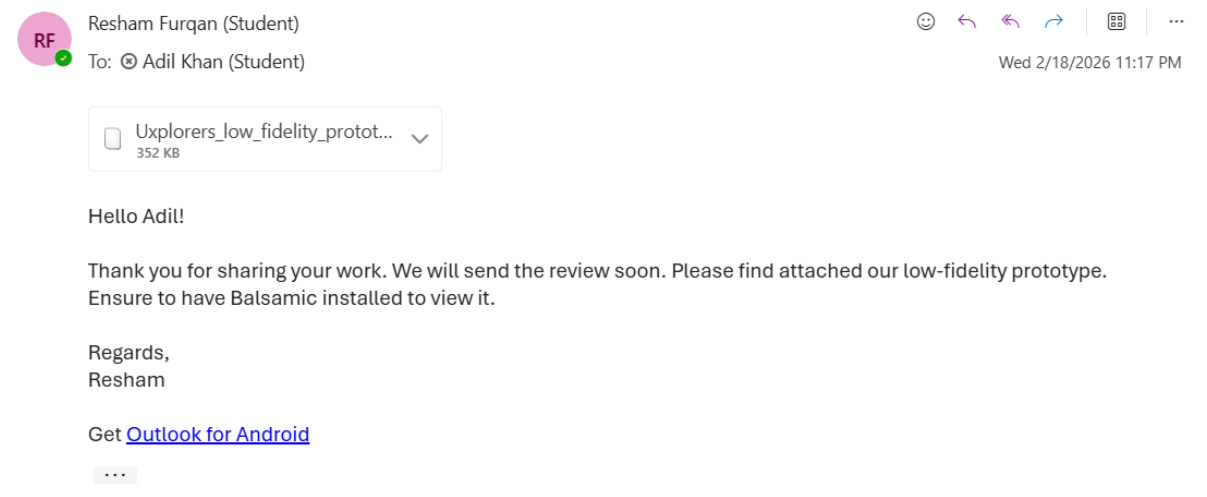
Adil Khan (Student)
To: Resham Furqan (Student)
Cc: Ahmed Zulfiqar Ali (Student)
Wed 2/18/2026 3:41 PM
You forwarded this message on Wed 2/18/2026 11:18 PM
Worksheet05ExpertReview.d...
21 KB

Good afternoon, Resham,
Adil Khan speaking here from Team Talon, from the HCI Unit, I am writing this email to ask of you to review our project.
Below, I will provide the link for our Low-Fidelity Design and attach the review document as well.

Thank you.

https://www.figma.com/design/J1nOJDrBp4tXeNoB4elLKf/Low-Fid?node-id=0-1&t=dN1xYaCevASrEL6x-1 (Low-Fid)

Figure 72: Email Conversation with Team Talon (a)



Resham Furqan (Student)
To: Adil Khan (Student)
Wed 2/18/2026 11:17 PM
Uxplorers_low_fidelity_protot...
352 KB

Hello Adil!

Thank you for sharing your work. We will send the review soon. Please find attached our low-fidelity prototype.
Ensure to have Balsamic installed to view it.

Regards,
Resham

Get Outlook for Android

Figure 73: Email Conversation with Team Talon (b)

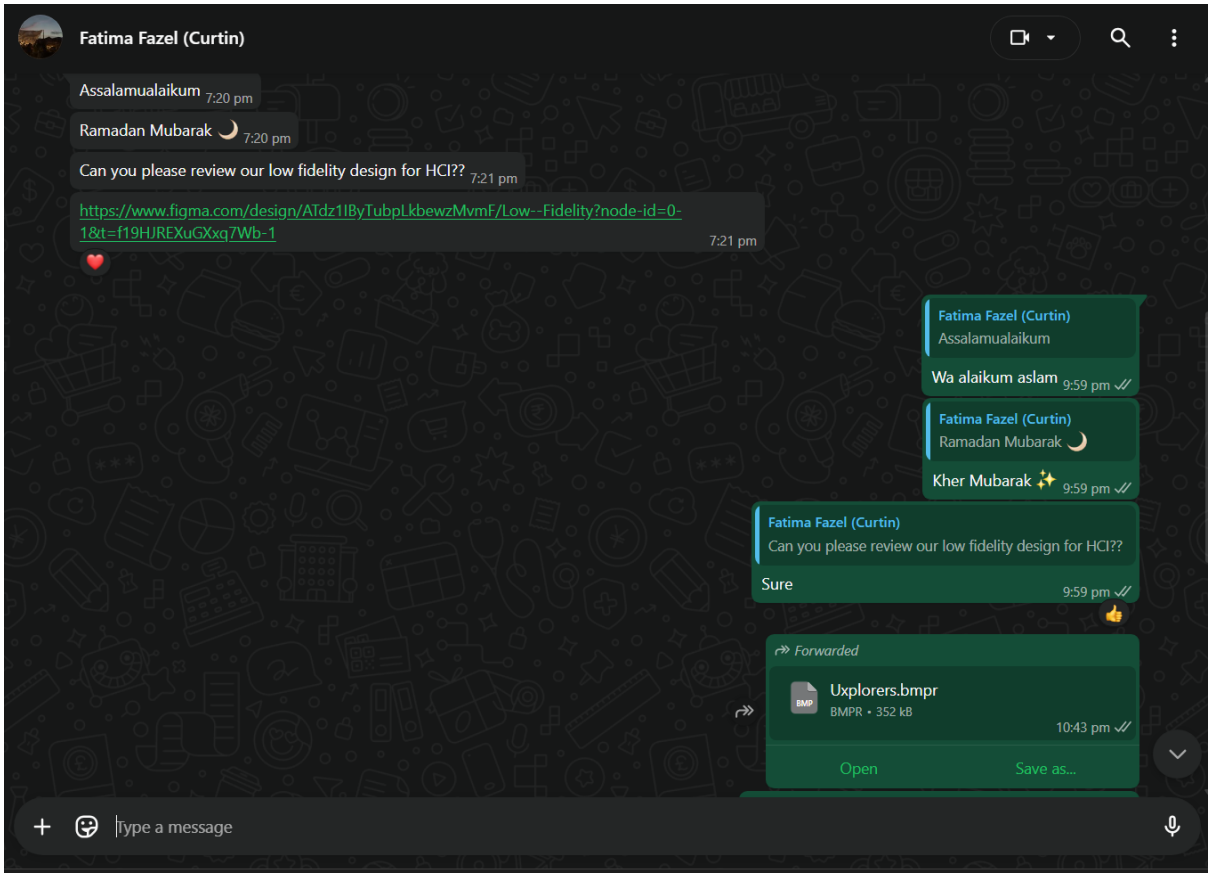


Figure 74: WhatsApp Conversation with Deadline Survivors (a)

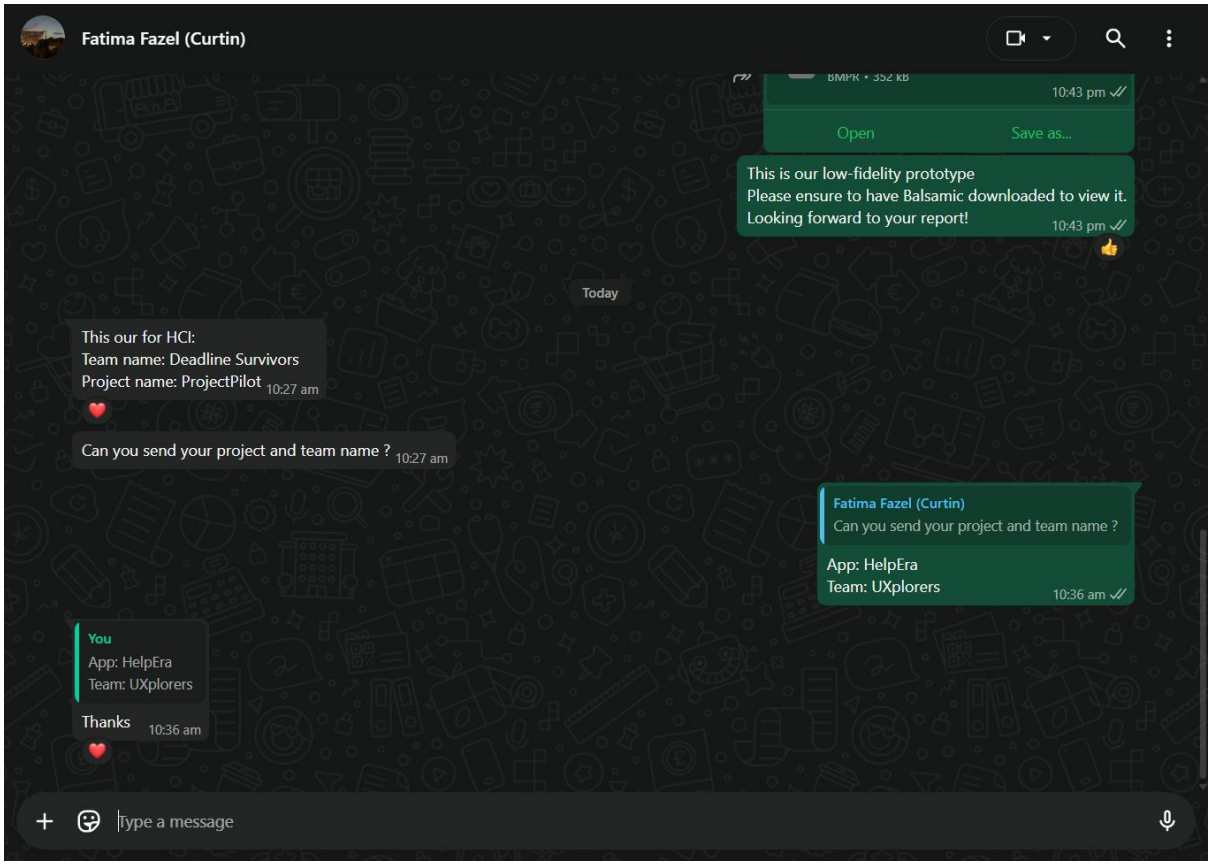


Figure 75: WhatsApp Conversation with Deadline Survivors (b)

Appendix E: Contribution Table

All the team members equally contributed to various sections of this report as well as Figma development. Despite the assigned roles, everyone helped in all the sections of this project. All the members did most of the parts altogether in the weekly meetings. The matrix below indicates primary authorship responsibilities for the Figma prototype and adding the content in this document while it was prepared by everyone:

Contribution Matrix

TASK	STATUS	IN CHARGE
Executive Summary	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Introduction	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Background	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Team	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Software Engineering Lifecycle	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Design Thinking	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
Design Thinking Process	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
User-Centred Design	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
User Research	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
Data Analysis	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
Personas	✅ Completed	Blessed Dendere
User Journeys/Flows	✅ Completed	Blessed Dendere
User Stories	✅ Completed	Blessed Dendere
Use Cases	✅ Completed	Blessed Dendere
Competitor Analysis	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Pain Points	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Problem Statements	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Ideate Solutions	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Requirement Sepecification	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
Hierarchical task Analysis	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
UI/UX Goals	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
UI/UX Design Principles	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Usability Heuristics	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Wireframing	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Low-Fidelity	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Expert Review	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
High-Fidelity Prototype	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Design Specs for Handoff	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva

Project Management	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Optional Development	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Conclusion	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Acknowledgements	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
References	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
Glossary	✅ Completed	Blessed Dendere
Appendix	✅ Completed	Everyone
Figma	✅ Completed	Everyone
Welcome Page	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Mood Pages	✅ Completed	Resham Furqan
Log in/Sign up Pages	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
Professionals Pages	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
User Profile Page	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Settings Page	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
FAQs Page	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Privacy Page	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Journal Pages	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
My History Page	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
My Progress Page	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed
Chatbot Page	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva & Resham Furqan
Community Pages	✅ Completed	Blessed Dendere
Groups and Chat Pages (Community)	✅ Completed	Blessed Dendere
Emergency/Suicidal Hotlines	✅ Completed	Maria Waheed & Resham Furqan
Home Page	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva
Sidebar Menus	✅ Completed	Natalee De Silva, Maria Waheed, Blessed Dendere
Learn Page	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Anxiety Page	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Depression Page	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
PTSD Page	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Eating Disorder Page	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Articles Pages	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Guidance Pages	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba
Redirect Pages	✅ Completed	Kekweditse Mogoshadi Mogoba

Figure 76: Contribution Matrix

Appendix F: Toggl Reports

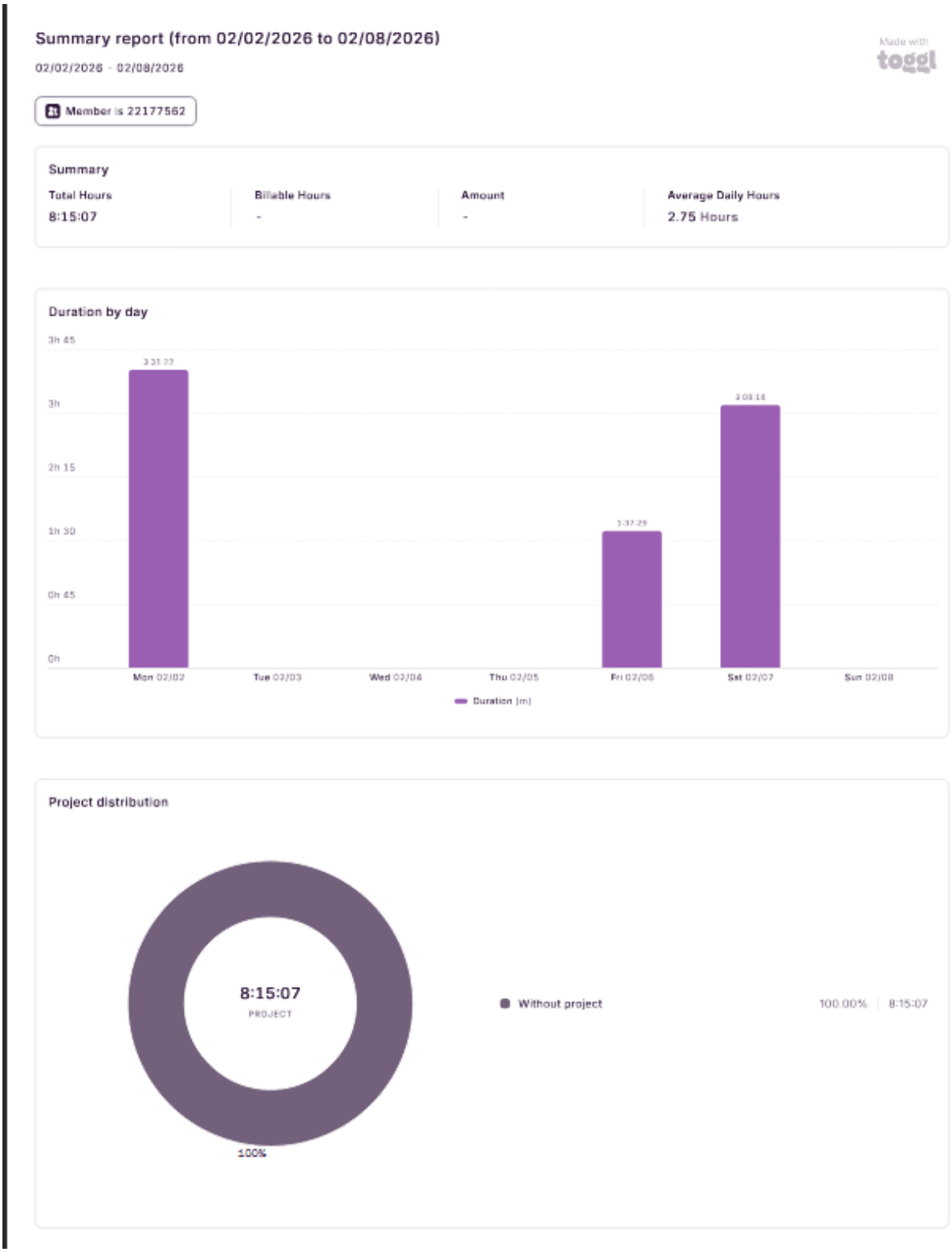


Figure 77: Toggl Report - Blessed (a)

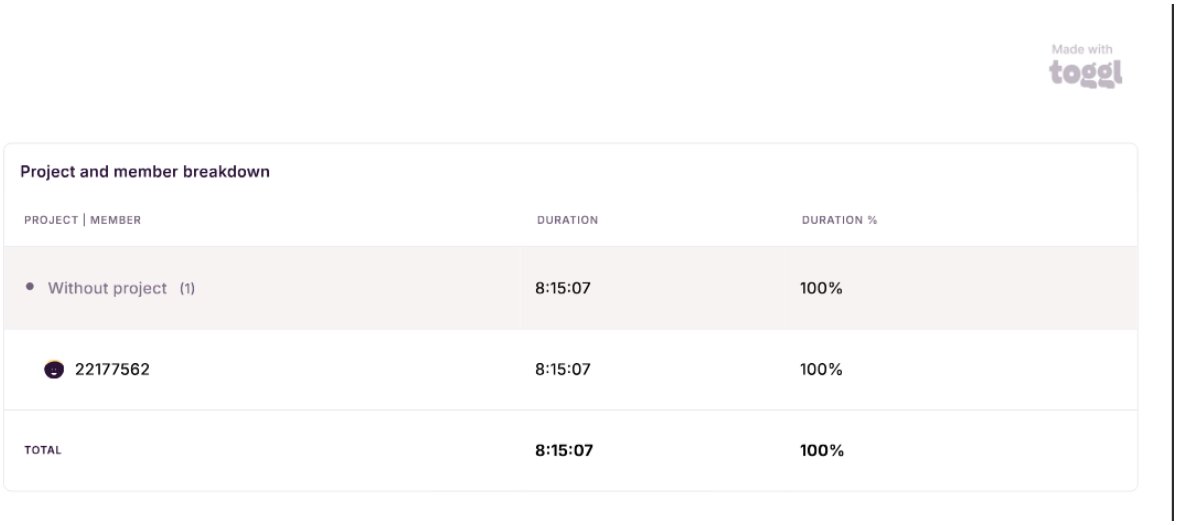


Figure 78: Toggl Report - Blessed (b)

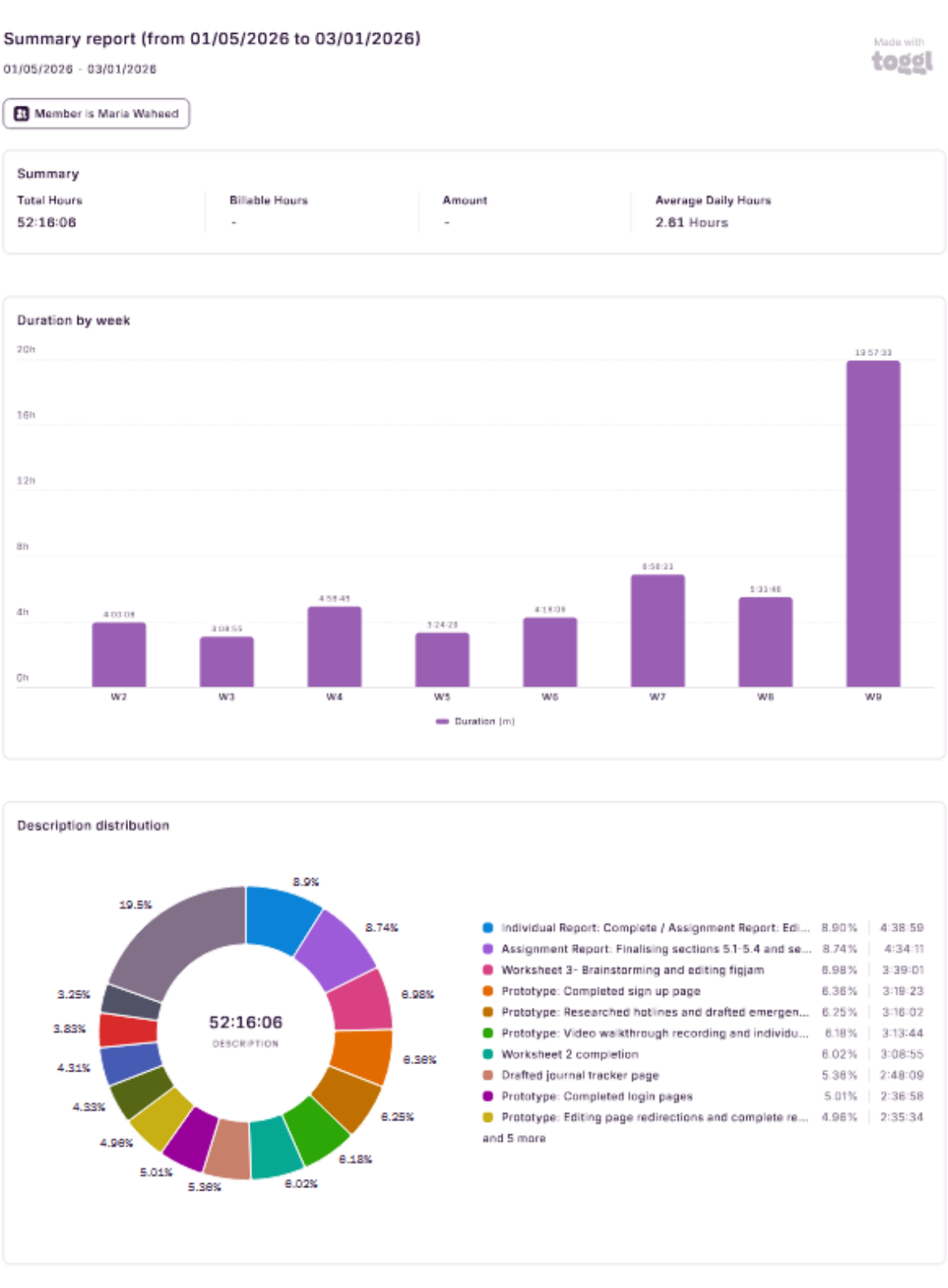


Figure 79: Toggl Report - Maria (a)

Project and description breakdown

PROJECT | DESCRIPTION	DURATION	DURATION %
• UXplorers (22)	52:16:06	100%
Assignment Report: Finalising sections 5.1-5.4 and section 6.3	4:34:11	8.74%
Drafted journal tracker page	2:48:09	5.36%
Drafted login and signup page for prototype	1:24:29	2.69%
Group meeting	1:30:00	2.87%
HCI class lec and assigning pages to each member	2:00:00	3.83%
Individual Report: Complete / Assignment Report: Editing headings and figures	4:38:59	8.9%
Prototype: Complete my progress page	1:29:57	2.87%
Prototype: Completed Journal tracker, my history pages	2:15:16	4.31%
Prototype: Completed login pages	2:36:58	5.01%
Prototype: Completed sign up page	3:19:23	6.36%
Prototype: Created my history page and modified log in/sign up pages	2:15:44	4.33%
Prototype: Editing page redirections and complete report sectionsreport	2:35:34	4.96%
Prototype: Researched hotlines and drafted emergency hotline page and drafted my progress page	3:16:02	6.25%

Figure 80: Toggl Report - Maria (b)

Made with toggl

Project and description breakdown

PROJECT | DESCRIPTION	DURATION	DURATION %
Prototype: Video walkthrough recording and individual report	3:13:44	6.18%
Prototype: Video walkthrough script	1:09:52	2.23%
User Research: Created survey	1:41:56	3.25%
Worksheet 2 completion	3:08:55	6.02%
Worksheet 3- Brainstorming and editing figjam	3:39:01	6.98%
Workshop 1 Meeting	1:10:43	2.25%
Workshop 1: Extension question- tech stack	1:07:29	2.15%
Workshop 4 Meeting	1:19:44	2.54%
Workshop 5 Meeting	1:00:00	1.91%
TOTAL	**52:16:06**	**100%**

Figure 81: Toggl Report - Maria (c)

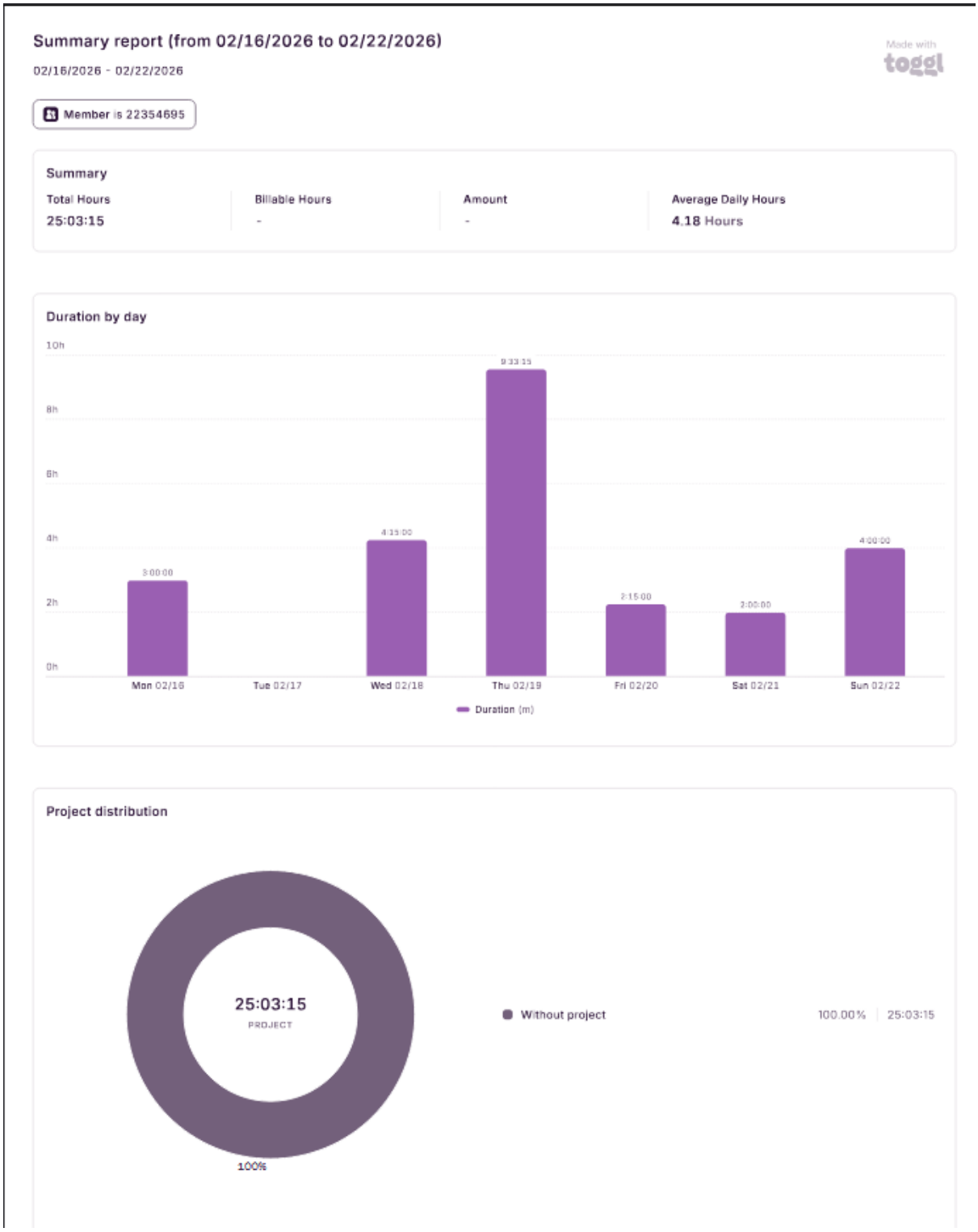


Figure 82: Toggl Report - Kekweditse (a)

Made with toggl

Member and client breakdown

MEMBER | CLIENT	DURATION	DURATION %
22354695 (1)	25:03:15	100%
Without client	25:03:15	100%
TOTAL	**25:03:15**	**100%**

Figure 83: Toggl Report - Kekweditse (b)

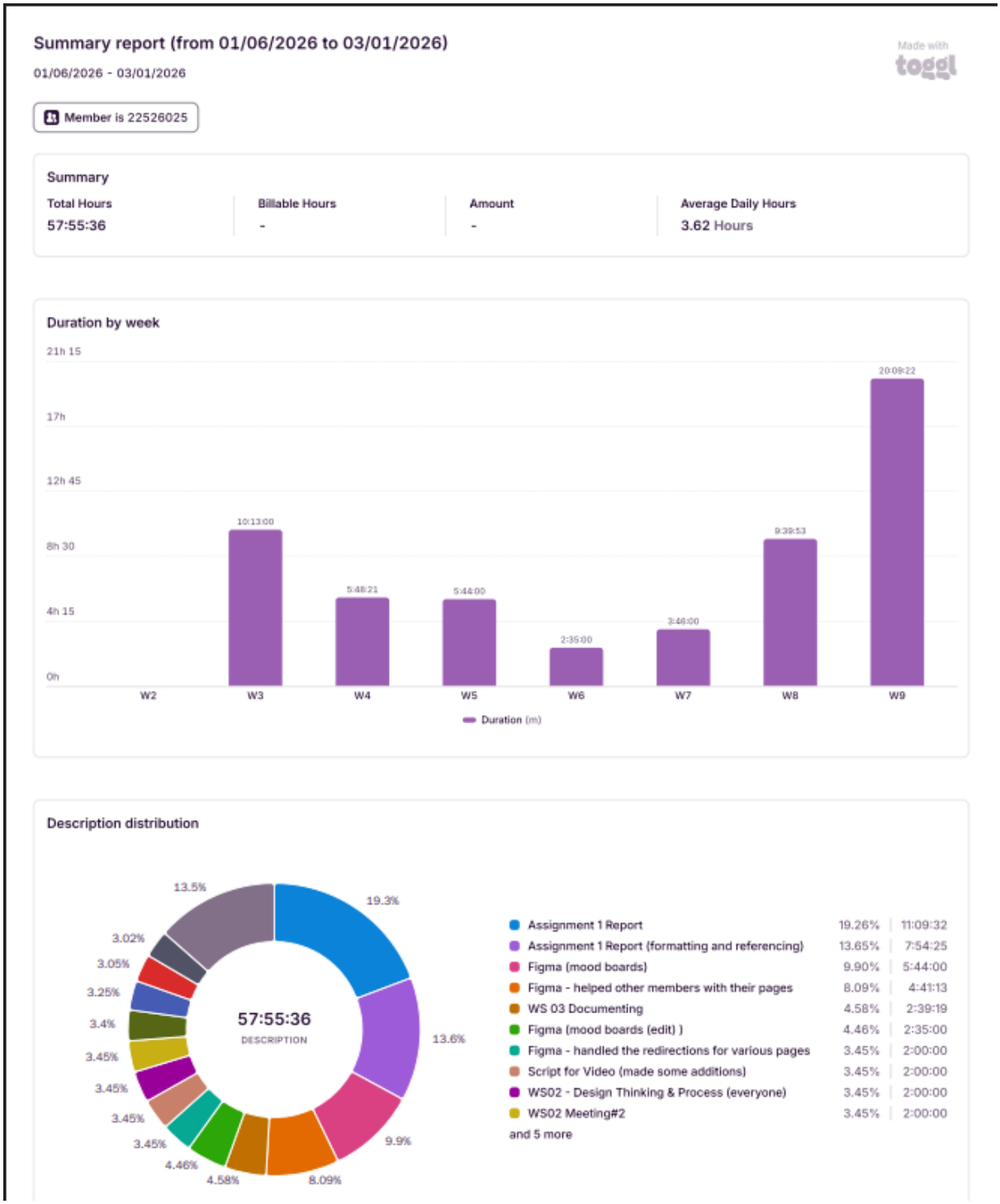


Figure 84: Toggl Report - Resham (a)

Project and description breakdown

PROJECT | DESCRIPTION	DURATION	DURATION %
• UXplorers (22)	57:55:36	100%
Assignment 1 Report	11:09:32	19.26%
Assignment 1 Report (formatting and referencing)	7:54:25	13.65%
Conduct the WS02 meeting	1:00:00	1.73%
figma - editing the welcome page	0:30:07	0.87%
Figma - handled the redirections for various pages	2:00:00	3.45%
Figma - helped other members with their pages	4:41:13	8.09%
Figma (mood boards)	5:44:00	9.9%
Figma (mood boards (edit))	2:35:00	4.46%
final touches	1:58:00	3.4%
made the logo	1:35:00	2.73%
Record the video	0:06:05	0.18%
Script for Video (made some additions)	2:00:00	3.45%
Started a kickoff prototype (team)	1:45:00	3.02%
wireframe (team)	1:14:55	2.16%
WS02 - Design Thinking & Process (everyone)	2:00:00	3.45%

Figure 85: Toggl Report - Resham (b)

Project and description breakdown

PROJECT | DESCRIPTION	DURATION	DURATION %
WS02 Meeting#2	2:00:00	3.45%
WS02 Report	1:53:00	3.25%
WS 03 Documenting	2:39:19	4.58%
WS 03 Meeting	1:24:00	2.42%
WS05 meeting	0:40:00	1.15%
WS 05 Meeting with BobTheBuilders Team	1:20:00	2.3%
WS 05 Report	1:46:00	3.05%
TOTAL	**57:55:36**	**100%**

Figure 86: Toggl Report - Resham (c)

Appendix G: Figma & Walkthrough Video Link

Figma Link: https://www.figma.com/proto/B43XWUpUHCnrxVyWXjrQtc/Kickoff-Prototype?node-id=1161-2608&t=6zrZcrFM7Jatmcqg-1&scaling=scale-down&content-scaling=fixed&page-id=0%3A1&starting-point-node-id=119%3A31&show-proto-sidebar=1

Walkthrough Video Link: